PART THREE | AN EXPANDING NATION

# CHAPTER 12

# RELIGION, ROMANTICISM, AND REFORM

1825-1854

## Secondary Source Reader

Historical scholarship for History B17A

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| **INCLUDED** | 117 verified selections from 61 supplied monographs. |
| **SOURCE TEXT** | Continuous passages from supplied editions; image-only passages are identified in the verification baseline. |
| **CITATIONS** | Chicago Notes and Bibliography; original book locators, never reader page numbers. |

Prepared from the supplied editions.

# Reader's Guide

Each numbered reading is a continuous excerpt from a historian's work. The main heading gives the monograph title; the metadata identifies the verified original chapter or section and original book locator.

## Citing These Readings

Use the full footnote citation the first time you cite a book and the shortened form thereafter. Cite original book pages or verified ebook locators, not reader page numbers.

# Contents


| | | |
|---|---|---|
| S12.001 | The Democratization of American Christianity<br>Nathan O. Hatch | 9 |
| S12.002 | The Democratization of American Christianity<br>Nathan O. Hatch | 10 |
| S12.003 | Strangers and Pilgrims: Female Preaching in America, 1740-1845<br>Catherine A. Brekus | 11 |
| S12.004 | Southern Cross: The Beginnings of the Bible Belt<br>Christine Leigh Heyrman | 13 |
| S12.005 | Citizens of Zion: The Social Origins of Camp Meeting Revivalism<br>Ellen Eslinger | 16 |
| S12.006 | The Antislavery Impulse, 1830-1844<br>Gilbert Hobbs Barnes | 17 |
| S12.007 | The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846<br>Charles Sellers | 19 |
| S12.008 | Citizens of Zion: The Social Origins of Camp Meeting Revivalism<br>Ellen Eslinger | 22 |
| S12.009 | Cradle of the Middle Class: The Family in Oneida County, New York, 1790-1865<br>Mary P. Ryan | 24 |
| S12.010 | The Market Revolution in America: Social, Political, and Religious Expressions, 1800–1880<br>Melvyn Stokes and Stephen Conway, eds. | 26 |
| S12.011 | A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837<br>Paul E. Johnson | 28 |
| S12.012 | The Burned-over District: The Social and Intellectual History of Enthusiastic Religion in Western New York, 1800-1850<br>Whitney R. Cross | 30 |
| S12.013 | Radical Spirits: Spiritualism and Women's Rights in Nineteenth-Century America<br>Ann Braude | 32 |
| S12.014 | Sisters and Saints: Women and American Religion<br>Ann Braude | 33 |
| S12.015 | Strangers and Pilgrims: Female Preaching in America, 1740-1845<br>Catherine A. Brekus | 34 |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| S12.016 | Southern Cross: The Beginnings of the Bible Belt<br>Christine Leigh Heyrman | 36 |
| S12.017 | Vanguard: How Black Women Broke Barriers, Won the Vote, and Insisted on Equality for All<br>Martha S. Jones | 37 |
| S12.018 | Freedom's Ferment: Phases of American Social History from the Colonial Period to the Outbreak of the Civil War<br>Alice Felt Tyler | 39 |
| S12.019 | Pillars of the Republic: Common Schools and American Society, 1780-1860<br>Carl F. Kaestle | 41 |
| S12.020 | The Jacksonian Promise: America, 1815-1840<br>Daniel Feller | 42 |
| S12.021 | The Discovery of the Asylum: Social Order and Disorder in the New Republic<br>David J. Rothman | 44 |
| S12.022 | American Heretic: Theodore Parker and Transcendentalism<br>Dean Grodzins | 46 |
| S12.023 | Women and the Work of Benevolence: Morality, Politics, and Class in the Nineteenth-Century United States<br>Lori D. Ginzberg | 48 |
| S12.024 | Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872<br>Nancy A. Hewitt | 50 |
| S12.025 | The Transcendentalists and Their World<br>Robert A. Gross | 53 |
| S12.026 | American Reformers, 1815-1860<br>Ronald G. Walters | 55 |
| S12.027 | Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England<br>Teresa Anne Murphy | 56 |
| S12.028 | The Burned-over District: The Social and Intellectual History of Enthusiastic Religion in Western New York, 1800-1850<br>Whitney R. Cross | 58 |
| S12.029 | The Alcoholic Republic: An American Tradition<br>W. J. Rorabaugh | 60 |
| S12.030 | The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846<br>Charles Sellers | 61 |
| S12.031 | Pillars of the Republic: Common Schools and American Society, 1780-1860<br>Carl F. Kaestle | 64 |
| S12.032 | City of Women: Sex and Class in New York, 1789–1860<br>Christine Stansell | 65 |
| S12.033 | Their Brothers' Keepers: Moral Stewardship in the United States, 1800-1865<br>Clifford S. Griffin | 67 |
| S12.034 | The Discovery of the Asylum: Social Order and Disorder in the New Republic<br>David J. Rothman | 69 |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| S12.035 | Women and the Work of Benevolence: Morality, Politics, and Class in the Nineteenth-Century United States<br>Lori D. Ginzberg | 71 |
| S12.036 | A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837<br>Paul E. Johnson | 73 |
| S12.037 | Pillars of the Republic: Common Schools and American Society, 1780-1860<br>Carl F. Kaestle | 75 |
| S12.038 | A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837<br>Paul E. Johnson | 76 |
| S12.039 | American Reformers, 1815-1860<br>Ronald G. Walters | 78 |
| S12.040 | The Trials of Anthony Burns: Freedom and Slavery in Emerson's Boston<br>Albert J. von Frank | 79 |
| S12.041 | The Black Image in the White Mind: The Debate on Afro-American Character and Destiny, 1817-1914<br>George M. Fredrickson | 80 |
| S12.042 | The Grimké Sisters from South Carolina: Pioneers for Women's Rights and Abolition<br>Gerda Lerner | 81 |
| S12.043 | All on Fire: William Lloyd Garrison and the Abolition of Slavery<br>Henry Mayer | 83 |
| S12.044 | Holy Warriors: The Abolitionists and American Slavery<br>James Brewer Stewart | 85 |
| S12.045 | The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement<br>Julie Roy Jeffrey | 86 |
| S12.046 | Virtue's Hero: Emerson, Antislavery, and Reform<br>Len Gougeon | 87 |
| S12.047 | The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition<br>Manisha Sinha | 89 |
| S12.048 | The Transformation of American Abolitionism: Fighting Slavery in the Early Republic<br>Richard S. Newman | 91 |
| S12.049 | American Reformers, 1815-1860<br>Ronald G. Walters | 93 |
| S12.050 | Slavery: A Problem in American Institutional and Intellectual Life<br>Stanley M. Elkins | 94 |
| S12.051 | In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863<br>Leslie M. Harris | 96 |
| S12.052 | In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863<br>Leslie M. Harris | 98 |
| S12.053 | The Trials of Anthony Burns: Freedom and Slavery in Emerson's Boston<br>Albert J. von Frank | 100 |
| S12.054 | Black Abolitionists<br>Benjamin Quarles | 101 |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| S12.055 | Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom<br>David W. Blight | 103 |
| S12.056 | Gateway to Freedom: The Hidden History of the Underground Railroad<br>Eric Foner | 105 |
| S12.057 | Until Justice Be Done: America's First Civil Rights Movement, from the Revolution to Reconstruction<br>Kate Masur | 107 |
| S12.058 | The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition<br>Manisha Sinha | 109 |
| S12.059 | All Bound Up Together: The Woman Question in African American Public Culture, 1830-1900<br>Martha S. Jones | 111 |
| S12.060 | Vanguard: How Black Women Broke Barriers, Won the Vote, and Insisted on Equality for All<br>Martha S. Jones | 113 |
| S12.061 | The Transformation of American Abolitionism: Fighting Slavery in the Early Republic<br>Richard S. Newman | 115 |
| S12.062 | Black Women Abolitionists: A Study in Activism, 1828-1860<br>Shirley J. Yee | 118 |
| S12.063 | Liberty Power: Antislavery Third Parties and the Transformation of American Politics<br>Corey M. Brooks | 120 |
| S12.064 | Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom<br>David W. Blight | 122 |
| S12.065 | Free Soil, Free Labor, Free Men: The Ideology of the Republican Party before the Civil War<br>Eric Foner | 124 |
| S12.066 | Gateway to Freedom: The Hidden History of the Underground Railroad<br>Eric Foner | 126 |
| S12.067 | The Antislavery Impulse, 1830-1844<br>Gilbert Hobbs Barnes | 128 |
| S12.068 | Holy Warriors: The Abolitionists and American Slavery<br>James Brewer Stewart | 130 |
| S12.069 | Until Justice Be Done: America's First Civil Rights Movement, from the Revolution to Reconstruction<br>Kate Masur | 132 |
| S12.070 | The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition<br>Manisha Sinha | 134 |
| S12.071 | Ballots for Freedom: Antislavery Politics in the United States, 1837-1860<br>Richard H. Sewell | 136 |
| S12.072 | Freedom's Ferment: Phases of American Social History from the Colonial Period to the Outbreak of the Civil War<br>Alice Felt Tyler | 138 |
| S12.073 | Radical Spirits: Spiritualism and Women's Rights in Nineteenth-Century America<br>Ann Braude | 140 |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| S12.074 | Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life: Vol. 2, The Public Years<br>Charles Capper | 142 |
| S12.075 | Feminism and Suffrage: The Emergence of an Independent Women's Movement in America, 1848-1869<br>Ellen Carol DuBois | 144 |
| S12.076 | The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement<br>Julie Roy Jeffrey | 146 |
| S12.077 | The Myth of Seneca Falls: Memory and the Women's Suffrage Movement, 1848-1898<br>Lisa Tetrault | 148 |
| S12.078 | Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872<br>Nancy A. Hewitt | 150 |
| S12.079 | American Reformers, 1815-1860<br>Ronald G. Walters | 151 |
| S12.080 | The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement<br>Julie Roy Jeffrey | 153 |
| S12.081 | Women and the Work of Benevolence: Morality, Politics, and Class in the Nineteenth-Century United States<br>Lori D. Ginzberg | 154 |
| S12.082 | Cradle of the Middle Class: The Family in Oneida County, New York, 1790-1865<br>Mary P. Ryan | 156 |
| S12.083 | Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872<br>Nancy A. Hewitt | 158 |
| S12.084 | Strangers and Pilgrims: Female Preaching in America, 1740-1845<br>Catherine A. Brekus | 160 |
| S12.085 | The Myth of Seneca Falls: Memory and the Women's Suffrage Movement, 1848-1898<br>Lisa Tetrault | 161 |
| S12.086 | White Women's Rights: The Racial Origins of Feminism in the United States<br>Louise Michele Newman | 162 |
| S12.087 | The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition<br>Manisha Sinha | 163 |
| S12.088 | All Bound Up Together: The Woman Question in African American Public Culture, 1830-1900<br>Martha S. Jones | 165 |
| S12.089 | Vanguard: How Black Women Broke Barriers, Won the Vote, and Insisted on Equality for All<br>Martha S. Jones | 167 |
| S12.090 | American Heretic: Theodore Parker and Transcendentalism<br>Dean Grodzins | 169 |
| S12.091 | The Inner Civil War: Northern Intellectuals and the Crisis of the Union<br>George M. Fredrickson | 171 |
| S12.092 | Understanding Emerson: "The American Scholar" and His Struggle for Self-Reliance<br>Kenneth S. Sacks | 173 |
| S12.093 | Virtue's Hero: Emerson, Antislavery, and Reform<br>Len Gougeon | 175 |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| S12.094 | American Transcendentalism: A History<br>Philip F. Gura | 177 |
| S12.095 | The Transcendentalists and Their World<br>Robert A. Gross | 179 |
| S12.096 | American Reformers, 1815-1860<br>Ronald G. Walters | 181 |
| S12.097 | Brook Farm: The Dark Side of Utopia<br>Sterling F. Delano | 182 |
| S12.098 | The Trials of Anthony Burns: Freedom and Slavery in Emerson's Boston<br>Albert J. von Frank | 184 |
| S12.099 | Transcendentalism as a Social Movement, 1830-1850<br>Anne C. Rose | 185 |
| S12.100 | Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life, vol. 1, The Private Years<br>Charles Capper | 187 |
| S12.101 | Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life: Vol. 2, The Public Years<br>Charles Capper | 189 |
| S12.102 | The Inner Civil War: Northern Intellectuals and the Crisis of the Union<br>George M. Fredrickson | 191 |
| S12.103 | Understanding Emerson: "The American Scholar" and His Struggle for Self-Reliance<br>Kenneth S. Sacks | 193 |
| S12.104 | American Transcendentalism: A History<br>Philip F. Gura | 195 |
| S12.105 | The Imperial Self: An Essay in American Literary and Cultural History<br>Quentin Anderson | 197 |
| S12.106 | The Transcendentalists and Their World<br>Robert A. Gross | 198 |
| S12.107 | The Rites of Assent: Transformations in the Symbolic Construction of America<br>Sacvan Bercovitch | 200 |
| S12.108 | Slavery: A Problem in American Institutional and Intellectual Life<br>Stanley M. Elkins | 201 |
| S12.109 | Brook Farm: The Dark Side of Utopia<br>Sterling F. Delano | 203 |
| S12.110 | The Quest for Nationality: An American Literary Campaign<br>Benjamin T. Spencer | 204 |
| S12.111 | Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life, vol. 1, The Private Years<br>Charles Capper | 206 |
| S12.112 | Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life: Vol. 2, The Public Years<br>Charles Capper | 208 |
| S12.113 | Waking Giant: America in the Age of Jackson<br>David S. Reynolds | 210 |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| S12.114 | Understanding Emerson: "The American Scholar" and His Struggle for Self-Reliance<br>Kenneth S. Sacks | 212 |
| S12.115 | The Raven and the Whale: The War of Words and Wits in the Era of Poe and Melville<br>Perry Miller | 214 |
| S12.116 | American Transcendentalism: A History<br>Philip F. Gura | 216 |
| S12.117 | The Rites of Assent: Transformations in the Symbolic Construction of America<br>Sacvan Bercovitch | 218 |

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.001

# The Democratization of American Christianity

Nathan O. Hatch

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Democratization of American Christianity |
| SELECTION | Crisis of Authority |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 34 · Yale University Press, 1989. |

## Excerpt

These expressions of egalitarian Christianity, however volatile and short-lived, remain striking evidence of the uncertainty of the times, of unexpected influences upon religious belief, and of the gravitation of common folk to forms of Christianity antagonistic to received authority. These religious leaders were fierce independents and localists, embodying the gospel in populist forms that went considerably beyond the sacred cause of the Revolution as defined by established clergy. Their gospel of the backcountry resonated with powerful Anti-Federalist and Jeffersonian persuasions. It challenged the right of a natural elite to speak for the people and empowered those who could claim no real stake in the promise of America.

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Hatch, *The Democratization of American Christianity*, 34.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.002

# The Democratization of American Christianity

Nathan O. Hatch

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Democratization of American Christianity |
| SELECTION | Crisis of Authority |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 35 · Yale University Press, 1989. |

## Excerpt

As increased numbers of these theological neophytes attempted to explicate religious matters for themselves, the overall range of religious options multiplied. Populist preachers could differ from each other as easily as they could from the establishment. This was particularly true given the clarion message that rang out above all their diversity: the primacy of the individual conscience. This emphasis relates to a third distinguishable pattern: an inversion of the traditional modes of religious authority. Instead of revering tradition, learning, solemnity, and decorum, as did Timothy Dwight and Lyman Beecher, a diverse array of populist preachers exalted youth, free expression, and religious ecstasy. They explicitly taught that divine insight was reserved for the poor and humble rather than the proud and learned.

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Hatch, *The Democratization of American Christianity*, 35.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.003

# Strangers and Pilgrims: Female Preaching in America, 1740-1845

Catherine A. Brekus

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| WORK | Strangers and Pilgrims: Female Preaching in America, 1740-1845 |
| SELECTION | Recovering the History of Female Preaching in America |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 10–11 · University of North Carolina Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

Finally, I looked at a wide variety of other books and manuscripts in order to reconstruct the vibrancy of eighteenth- and nineteenth-century evangelical culture. Local histories helped me to imagine the small, outlying towns and villages where women often preached; clergymen's diaries o√ered colorful descriptions of boisterous camp meetings and revivals; and denominational histories helped clarify questions of church doctrine. After reading several polemical tracts against female preaching and sermons on women's "natural" domesticity, I began to realize the intensity of the clerical debates over women's right to speak in public.

All of these records have helped me to piece together the story that I tell in this book, but much to my frustration, many o√ered me only the most fleeting glimpses of female preachers. For example, while reading the diary of William Smyth Babcock, a Freewill Baptist minister, I found a brief sketch of Nancy Mitchell, "a celebrated Preacher in this & the neighbouring towns; whose character for truth is very doubtful."∞∂ Intrigued by this tantalizing description, I searched for Mitchell's name in countless numbers of periodicals, church records, and clerical memoirs, but to my disappointment, I never found another mention of her. Who was she? Why did Babcock question her "character"? And why was she so "celebrated"? I will never know. Such have been the challenges of writing a history of "strangers and pilgrims" who never "received the promise" of historical fame.

Recovering the stories of these pioneering female preachers sheds new light on many of the most important debates about the history of women and the history of religion in America. In some ways, of course, their stories simply confirm what scholars have long known or suspected about eighteenth- and nineteenth-century American culture. For example, few religious historians will be surprised to learn that evangelicals o√ered women one of their few opportunities for public leadership, nor will many women's historians be shocked to learn that ordinary women often violated the "cult of domesticity." In that sense, this book builds on a wealth of critical scholarship published over the last twenty-five years.

Yet the history of female preaching also expands and challenges our understandings of the American past. As feminist historians have argued time and again, integrating women into history involves more than merely pasting them into previous grand narratives of political events. "The e√ort to conceptualize women's history as a collection of 'missing facts and views' to be incorporated into the empty spaces of traditional history is too limited, even fallacious," Gerda Lerner has written.∞∑ Since women's experiences often do not fit into the conventional categories for understanding American history, we must learn how to ask new questions and create new paradigms. In some cases, adding women to history simply bolsters our commonly accepted interpretations, but in others, it requires us to rethink our assumptions about the e√ects of cultural, political, economic, and religious change.

When seen through the eyes of women as well as men, the eighteenthcentury revivals, collectively labeled the Great Awakening, look particularly significant, even extraordinary, but also surprisingly ephemeral. For the first time in American history, large numbers of evangelical women spoke publicly in their churches, and for a few brief years, they seemed to stand on the verge of a new era of female religious leadership. Within a decade, however, most evangelical churches in New England and the South tried to prevent women from testifying or witnessing, and during the American Revolution, they drew sharper lines between the "masculine" and the "feminine," the public and the

private. Contrary to what I had originally expected, fewer women seem to have been allowed to preach during the Revolution—the celebrated era of the common man—than during the earlier revivals. Even though the Great Awakening decisively influenced the future shape of American culture, especially in breaking down colonial habits of deference and hierarchy, it ultimately did not change the gendered lines of authority within the churches.

Besides illuminating the short-lived radicalism of the Great Awakening, the stories of female preachers also o√er a unique perspective on nineteenth-century revivalism. In many ways, the presence of large numbers of white and black women in the pulpit seems to o√er evidence of the democratization of American Christianity. Intoxicated by the republican rhetoric of equality, the Methodists, African Methodists, Christian Connection, Freewill Baptists, and Millerites insisted that the distinctions of race, class, and sex were less important than whether or not one had been "saved." As historian Nathan Hatch has argued, the revivals of the Second Great Awakening (1790–1845) represented an "explosive conjunction of evangelical fervor and popular sovereignty," "an upsurge of democratic hope."∞∏ Populist and egalitarian, they helped transform America into a liberal, competitive, and market-driven society.

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Brekus, *Strangers and Pilgrims*, 10–11.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.004

# Southern Cross: The Beginnings of the Bible Belt

**Christine Leigh Heyrman**

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| **WORK** | Southern Cross: The Beginnings of the Bible Belt |
| **SELECTION** | Mothers and Others in Israel + |
| **SOURCE LOCATOR** | Original pages 167–168 · University of North Carolina Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

Women were singled out to exercise such gifts by congregational acclaim and with full clerical approval. It was a point of pride for Joseph Travis, another Methodist itinerant, that his mother's "talent in public prayer was rather extraordinary," and that "Many a time has she been called upon to conclude a meeting, after preaching, by a prayer." His colleague in Kentucky, Henry Smith, likewise observed that during a revival at the turn of the century, "all of our praying men and women were in great demand.... [T]hose who could sing and pray as though they would bring down Heaven's blessings by strong faith... were called upon."® A few evangelical preachers hoped to win for white women an even wider scope for the public exercise of their spiritual gifts. Some early Methodists argued that white women should be permitted to preach, an oral performance distinct from exhorting in that it entailed expounding a biblical text. The inspiration for those views came, in part, from the practice of the first English Methodists, who allowed women to serve as local preachers. But a more immediate influence, as Stith Mead acknowledged, was the early Methodist clergy's admiration for silver-tongued southern Quaker women: "I have uniformly, since obtaining the true spirit of religion been, from my plain dress in apparel, taken to be one of that society by some of the Quaker Friends," he remarked proudly, because of "my aversion to National War and Negro Slavery, and acquiescence to female preaching." Yet Mead's enthusiasm for female preachers, if not wholly singular among southern evangelicals, was never widely shared by either the clergy or the laity. From their first appearance in the South, most Methodists as well as Baptists stopped short of endorsing preaching by women of any age or race. Although many women served as local preachers among Methodists in late-eighteenth-century England, and the ranks of upstate New York's early Baptists included a few female itinerants, there is no evidence that southern women, Methodist or Baptist, preached in their own neighborhoods or abroad. Among southern churches, only the Quakers permitted women to preach, and even within their ranks support for the practice among male Friends was withering rapidly after 1800.° Early evangelical churches also strictly limited the participation of women in matters of governance. Lay Methodists, regardless of their gender or race, played no role in selecting preachers or, before about 1800, accepting new members and expelling wayward ones. By contrast, lay those powers, although some churches permitted white female and black members a role in their deliberations. While practice varied from one congregation to another, in most, African-American and white female Baptists were allowed to attend church meetings that decided the appointment of pastors and the admission and discipline of members. In some churches they had leave to express their views, present evidence, and even serve on committees investigating charges against a member of the same sex or race. But by 1800 nearly all churches barred both groups from voting, the exclusive and jealously guarded right of the white brethren. It appears, too, that, by the last decades of the eighteenth century, the white Baptist brethren were steadily curtailing women's participation in governance. A few preachers, like Kentucky's John Taylor, urged their churches to appoint deaconesses charged with visiting the sick and dying, an office instituted by some of the first Separate Baptist congregations that fell into disuse shortly after the Revolution. But the ruling brethren were content to consign deaconesses to their past, along with voting rights for female members. In 1771, one North Carolina association advised its member churches that "it was not lawful" for the sisters to vote in church meetings—a ruling that suggests some women either enjoyed or claimed that privilege earlier. By 1794, a church belonging to the same association went still further, instructing female members "not to make motions in their own Person nor debate on the floor." By 1802, a Virginia association offered the same counsel, averring that "none but free white male members" could speak with an authoritative voice in matters of governance because white women, like underage sons and African Americans, lacked the independence to reach impartial judgments. Most early-nineteenth-century southern churches shaped their policies accordingly, vesting rule and discipline firmly in the hands of the brethren. Yet the exclusion of women from governing powers was less an accomplished fact than a continuing achievement. White settlement of each successive frontier renewed such contests, and in some new western churches, the sisters triumphed. In the second decade of the nineteenth century, the brethren of one early Mississippi Baptist church thought better of their initial policy, which had allotted women "all the privileges of male members in the church," and informed them that "we consider it their duty to learn of the Apostle [Paul] not to speak in the church nor to usurp authority." But when the sisters resisted, the brethren relented.

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Heyrman, *Southern Cross*, 167–168.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.005

# Citizens of Zion: The Social Origins of Camp Meeting Revivalism

Ellen Eslinger

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Citizens of Zion: The Social Origins of Camp Meeting Revivalism |
| SELECTION | The Social Significance Of Camp Meeting Revivalism |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 241–242 · University of Tennessee Press, 1999. |

## Excerpt

Christianity to its original purity, when the disciples of Jesus Christ gathered for worship without the mediation of an educated clergy, impressive church structures, or doctrinal intricacies. This vision formed the foundation for the religious denomination soon organized by Stone and his adherents, named most appropriately the Christian Church. The Stonites rejected all creeds save the New Testament." Neither Stone nor any of his fellow revivalists who left a personal account of their experiences seem to have noticed that the particular aspects of Christianity being expressed at camp meetings also resembled republican social ideals. This oversight is hardly surprising, since defenders of the new evangelical format attributed its power not to earthly concerns but to divine favor. Yet the character of early camp meeting revivalism reveals an emphasis on key qualities of morality, egalitarianism, and unity that were central to both worlds. The camp meeting, which on one level was the temporary creation of an ideal Christian society, was also the temporary creation of an ideal republican society. Moreover, camp meeting participants were not required to distinguish between the two ideals. Indeed, they were encouraged not to do so, but rather to infuse the young nation with renewed Christian virtue. And, if a Christian republic could be realized for a few days at a camp meeting, hope also existed for a more permanent achievement. Thus camp meeting ritual contained an instructive aspect, not only religiously but also socially. Although the full effect of camp meeting revivalism remains impossible to gauge, the extraordinary popularity of camp meeting revivalism among Americans in the nineteenth century offers indirect yet indisputable testimony for its tremendous importance. This popularity has often been under-appreciated, but the camp meeting's success lay not with the clergy but with the laity. Had people not found the new religious format meaningful, they would have declined to participate. Camp meeting revivalism would have gone down in history as merely a freak episode of spiritual excess. The specific meaning was certainly far from uniform, yet at least one general observation can be offered, an observation which pertains just as much to those participants who experienced religious transformation as to those who did not. The communitas experienced at camp meetings brought together people from different backgrounds in ways thought appropriate for both Christians and republicans. For a few days, to a varying degree, these Americans became, in the words of a popular hymn by Isaac Watts, "Citizens of Zion."

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Eslinger, Ellen. *Citizens of Zion: The Social Origins of Camp Meeting Revivalism*. Knoxville: University of Tennessee Press, 1999.

**Footnote citation:**

Ellen Eslinger, *Citizens of Zion: The Social Origins of Camp Meeting Revivalism* (Knoxville: University of Tennessee Press, 1999), 241–242.

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Eslinger, *Citizens of Zion*, 241–242.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.006

# The Antislavery Impulse, 1830-1844

Gilbert Hobbs Barnes

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Antislavery Impulse, 1830-1844 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 103–104 · D. Appleton-Century, 1933. |

## Excerpt

They agreed with Benjamin Lundy that an immediatism which involved “turning the Slaves loose without any restriction whatever,” regardless of consequences, was one which “no person of sane mind will advocate.” But Garrison continued to advocate it throughout his career.

In the West, the Lane rebels had revived a third alternative to the doctrinal dilemma. Preaching abolitionism as a great revival in religious benevolence, they had argued from the first that slavery was not only an evil but a sin, and on that account ought immediately to be abandoned. This was the doctrine with which the national agitation had begun ; but in the propaganda for the nation, at least, it was not widely emphasized, partly because many abolitionists contended that slavery was an evil and not a sin, and partly because the conversion of the South was hopeless so long as the sin of slavery was maintained.

At one stroke dilemma of immediatism; for as the South itself admitted, “if slavery be adjudged a sin, if it be condemned by the revealed word of God, then in Christendom it cannot continue to exist.”

In many of 1836, there was acrimonious debate between proponents of “slavery an evil” and “slavery a sin” ; and some time during the autumn of that year the doctrine of the Lane rebels became the leading tenet of the official gospel of abolitionism.

Weld wrote an official summary of the Lane rebels’ argument, but that was only the beginning of a new pamphlet controversy. Notable theologians, North and South, wrote extensively on the doctrine for the religious journals and for the press, and new dignity was added thereby to the antislavery cause.

While propaganda by the written word led to futility and disaster, propaganda by agents expanded into triumphant revival. Since the Lane rebels had been dismissed from the seminary “and God thrust them out, full of philanthropy and zeal, to awaken a slumbering nation,” 13 they had become to the antislavery leaders the hope of the cause. Their agitation was subject to none of the dangers of pamphleteering. It did not depend for success on triumphs of controversy, but rather upon repetitions of doctrine, always to fresh hearers. In the hands of agents, doctrine became dogma; an unchanging immediatism was the basis of their gospel.

Their immediatism, however, was more than the Jesuitical “gradualism in a British cloak” of the New York doctrine. It was an immediatism of repentance from sin. By making the sin of slavery “the standard to which the Abolitionist is to rally,” Weld’s agents made the antislavery cause “identical with religion ; and men and women are exhorted by all they esteem holy, by all the high and exciting obligations of duty to man and God, by all that can warm the heart and inflame the imagination, to join the pious work of purging the sin of slavery from the land.”

By 1836, the failure of pamphleteering and the sucess of revivalism had become so evident that the national society decided at its annual meeting in May to abandon the pamphlet campaign, to reduce printed propaganda to a minimum, and to employ all available resources in enlarging Weld’s ardent host. The number of the expanded band was to be seventy, the number sent out in Bible times to convert the world to Christianity. Their name too was to be “the Seventy,” and they were to be spread over the North to convert it to immediatism.15

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Barnes, *The Antislavery Impulse, 1830-1844*, 103–104.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.007

# The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846

Charles Sellers

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846 |
| SELECTION | God and Mammon |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 229–231 · Oxford University Press, 1991. |

## Excerpt

Other ministers complained "that I let down the dignity of the pulpit," the evangelist admitted; "that I was a disgrace to the ministerial profession; that I talked like a lawyer at the bar; that I talked to the people in a colloquial manner; that I said 'you,' instead of 'they;' that I said 'hell,' and with such an emphasis as often to shock the people." Finney pled guilty to addressing farmers and mechanics "in the language of the common people," to drawing illustrations from their life, to expressing himself "in few words, and in words that were in common use." To all objections he had one conclusive answer: "the results justify my methods."

The Moderate Light's Yankee hierarchs saw in the upstart evangelist only a dangerous eruption of antinomianism's "universal misrule and moral desolation." Vainly they tried to silence him with hysterical alarums of social disorder. By treating all sinners alike "without respect to age or station in society," they warned, the Finneyites threatened "a levelling of all distinctions of society." Like the mobs of the French Revolution, the "impudent young men" converted in the western revivals would be "poured out as from the hives of the North to obliterate civilization and roll back the wheels of time to semi-barbarism." Perhaps worst of all, complained strategist Beecher, Finneyism would wreck "the great evangelical assimilation which is forming in the United States."

In 1827 Beecher and other weighty Yankee clerics imperiously summoned Finney and his supporters to a conference at New Lebanon, New York, to be corrected. "I know your plan and you know I do," the hierarch stormed when the rebel proved unrepentant. "You mean to come into Connecticut, and carry a streak of fire to Boston. But if you attempt it, as the Lord liveth, I'll meet you at the State line, and call out all the artillery-men, and fight every inch of the way to Boston, and I'll fight you there." He would soon eat his words.29

Finney shocked clerical hierarchs by demonstrating how much antinomian enthusiasm they had to appropriate to remain competitive. Gradually he demonstrated also how antinomian rebellion could be channeled through benevolence into capitalist discipline. Eventually Dr. Beecher recognized the ardent young evangelist as the Moderate Light's savior. "I have felt the beating of his great warm heart before God," he would acknowledge when arraigned by orthodox Presbyterians for Finneyite heresy.

Although an instinctive Methodist by immersion of theological innocence in Come-outer Awakening, Finney had been reared on the Moderate-Light side of the tracks to disdain "ignorant Methodist exhorters." Soundly schooled in a Yankee academy and marked for success along village main streets, he was especially sensitive to the stresses of rising entrepreneurs. Swept into mushrooming canal towns on a tide of rural/female antinomianism, he silenced the Yankee hierarchs by inspiring Christian businessmen to heroic piety.

Assailed on one side by Finneyite wives, mothers, and children, they were dismayed on the other by social disorder. Transient laborers and roistering boatmen brought brothels and tippling houses to staid Presbygational villages. Communal controls dissolved as wage workers escaped the family discipline of patriarchal masters to crowd into their own rowdy districts, while the new elite withdrew to neighborhoods of quiet elegance. And Bucktail democracy defeated all efforts to stem a flood of drunkenness, cursing, and Sabbath desecration.

Finney offered businessmen who surrendered to maternal altruism both domestic and social tranquility. He promised to Christianize a fractious populace through antinomian universalism while defusing antinomian rebellion by making individual conversion the only means of social improvement. What sealed his alliance with businessmen and carried the refocused Moderate Light to hegemony was his unconscious equation of Christian virtue with their capitalist asceticism. Prescribing a heavy dose of New Haven's repressive moralism, he preached selfdiscipline to the working class.

"A self-indulgent Christian is a contradiction," the evangelist insisted. "You might just as well write on your clothes 'NO TRUTH IN RELIGION,'" he warned women, for their ribbons and ornaments proclaimed "GIVE ME DRESS, GIVE ME FASHION, GIVE ME FLATTERY, AND I AM HAPPY." He could not "believe that a person who has ever known the love of God can relish a secular novel" or give shelf room to "Byron, Scott, Shakespeare, and a host of triflers and blasphemers of God." At Oberlin College he lectured students " on the duty of keeping their nails clean and their clothes dry, of sitting straight in their chairs," and he joined faculty colleagues in banning meat, tea, coffee, and pastries from the dining hall. The only true reformers, he declared, were those "honestly endeavoring to reform mankind and denying their appetites."

But Finney offered businessmen more than capitalist discipline. By demanding total commitment to Hopkinsian benevolence, he assuaged their ethical distress. "Christians are by no means to conform to the business maxims of the world," he taught. Explicitly he warned against the market's basic maxim: "to buy as cheap as you can and sell as dear as you can, to look out for number one." Condemning debt and "the whole credit system" as dangerous "if not absolutely sinful," he called on the Christian businessman to follow Jesus' example "of self-denial, of benevolence, of sacrificing himself to do good to others." Wealth and capital were "tools with which he serves God and his generation."

"Only make it your invariable principle to do right and do business upon principle," he told them, "and you can control the market." If all Christians did so, he insisted, they "would soon do the business of the world" and demonstrate "the power of the church to regulate the commerce of the world." Thus they could usher in a Hopkinsian Kingdom of God combining disciplined capitalist production with communal love.

Finney's reborn businessmen immediately seized local evangelical leadership by organizing a Western Domestic Missionary Society. When their wives, despite protests from rural affiliates, meekly allowed the independent Female Society to be swallowed up, the banner of gender passed to the flourishing maternal associations. Meanwhile the national furor over the evangelist's new measures attracted the attention of Christian businessmen worried by growing armies of the unruly poor in eastern cities. Sponsored by enthusiastic laymen, he was soon igniting revivals in Lancaster, Reading, Wilmington, Philadelphia, and New York; and all too quickly Beecher had to welcome him to Boston.30

Finney was invited to his greatest triumph by a Rochester businessman so totally committed that he went broke stubbornly maintaining along the busy Erie his Sabbath-keeping, nonalcoholic Pioneer Line. Overwhelmed by seven-day stage and packet lines, Josiah Bissell rejoiced at the seven-day Finneyite evangelism that engulfed the flour-milling city for six winter months in 1830-1831. Growing spiritual excitement finally brought all business to a halt as relays of ministers assisted Finney in a five-day, sunrise-to-midnight Protracted Meeting. So many eager hearers packed the gallery of the First Presbyterian Church that the walls gave way.

Doubling local church rolls and exciting contagious hopes for a general blaze of grace, Rochester's epiphany ignited a wildfire of revival across the northern states. Connecticut churches swelled a third in a year, Vermont's almost as much, and Presbyterians by sixty thousand nationally in three years. Finney claimed that the spark he struck at Rochester brought a hundred thousand people into the churches by 18 3 5. It was, the awed and adaptable Beecher conceded, "the greatest work of God, and the greatest revival of religion, that the world has ever seen."31

Finney's "portentous union between the New Divinity and the New Measures" was especially impressive to the Christian businessmen who directed and financed the Moderate Light's cultural offensive from the Empire City. Confronting an uncontrolled working class, merchant Lewis Tappan was convinced that "this city must be converted or the nation is lost." He was looking for "ardent and practical men" rather than theologians and "controversialists. There was "too much 'theology' in the church now, and too little of the Gospel," he thought.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Sellers, *The Market Revolution*, 229–231.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.008

# Citizens of Zion: The Social Origins of Camp Meeting Revivalism

Ellen Eslinger

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Citizens of Zion: The Social Origins of Camp Meeting Revivalism |
| SELECTION | INTRODUCTION Xill |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of Tennessee Press, 1999. |

## Excerpt

Despite the implicit criticism by these scholars, and a frontal assault by others on the whole portrayal of frontier expansion as set forth by Turner, the simplest glance at textbook treatments of camp meeting revivalism will show that frontier explanations still prevail.‘ In large part, this is because no one has offered a persuasive alternative explanation for why camp’meeting revivalism began where it did, when it did, and then went on to become a virtually national phenomenon. This book, which began in 1988 as a dissertation, rests on two fundamental insights.’ One is that, by the time of the Great Revival in 1800, Kentucky no longer bore much resemblance to its frontier beginnings, particularly not according to Turnerian criteria. The other is that early camp meeting revivalism differed in significant ways not only from earlier evangelical forms but also from its later manifestations. Tightening the temporal scale of analysis and carefully reconstructing both the setting and the phenomenon itself suggest that camp meeting revivalism owed its phenomenal popularity to the ability to reintegrate a society rent by economic hardship, political partisanship, and cultural conflict.

Although Turner’s “Frontier Thesis” offers more hindrance than help, the process of Euro-American expansion is nonetheless important for understanding the beginnings of camp meeting revivalism. My interpretation of early trans-Appalachian settlement has been guided by a new interpretive framework oriented around early American expansion into the region west of the Blue Ridge Mountains, primarily in Pennsylvania, Virginia, and North Carolina. This region, known as the “backcountry,” was settled in the eighteenth century. It has attracted a thriving scholarship in recent years, “blazing an academic Appalachian Trail from the backwoods of Maine to the upcountry of Georgia.” The long stretch of interior settlements shared certain traits that historian Gregory Nobles has summarized as “independence and integration.” Whereas Turner looked at the frontier as a fresh departure, studies of the colonial backcountry have tended to emphasize the connection with established cultures.® And, in contrast to Turner and other historians of his generation, recent scholars have recognized that these established cultures were both white and red. What Turnerians would call a frontier, or border, is instead seen as a “middle ground” or regional zone with a mixture of traits creating a distinctive subculture.’ The geographic dimensions of the backcountry, never really finite, were defined as much by conflict as by anything else. On one hand was the tension produced by an insatiable appetite for native land while on the other stood a desire for autonomy. from control by seaboard centers of power. As settlement developed, of course, the backcountry found itself absorbed by the seaboard centers into the emerging national culture. Thus, as a recently settled region, Kentucky at the time of the Great Revival in 1800 had been going through a period of stressful reorientation.

Also important in how I have approached the secular context of camp meeting beginnings is a growing appreciation among historians for the late eighteenth century as an era of profound social transition. Two themes have especially engaged scholars of the period. One concerns America’s capitalist transformation. Increasing involvement in commercial markets was, many historians believe, beginning to erode older notions of society as interdependent. Competition was replacing cooperation as the reigning ethic, causing a widespread but still incompletely understood sense of social malaise.’ Social disintegration was also part of changes taking place in the political realm. Most late-eighteenth-century Americans still accepted a civic humanist tradition of a virtuous citizenry that subordinated personal interest for the common good. The partisanship and division produced in the wake of the American

Revolution was therefore extremely disturbing, often interpreted as a moral crisis threatening to the country's survival. Moreover, as liberalism gained ground, the pursuit of self-interest seemed to acquire a legitimacy it had not enjoyed earlier. Intertwined in the popular mind with Christian morality, these concerns acquired a special seriousness.? In other ways as well, the late eighteenth century was widely experienced as an era of unusual and troubling change. The late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries saw the organic, cohesive, cooperative ideal of age-old tradition being supplanted by a new liberal, plural, and competitive reality. Several recent historical studies have revealed the ambivalence with which many early Americans regarded this transformation." The experience in newly settled areas such as Kentucky, where the institutional framework was not yet capable of lending much guidance and stability, was often more difficult.

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.009

# Cradle of the Middle Class: The Family in Oneida County, New York, 1790-1865

Mary P. Ryan

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|---|---|
| WORK | Cradle of the Middle Class: The Family in Oneida County, New York, 1790-1865 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 96–97 · Cambridge University Press, 1981. |

## Excerpt

Woman's role in the conversion that ensued would have remained forever unrecorded were it not that the convert in question was none other than Theodore Dwight Weld. The famed abolitionist's aunt turns out to be Sophia Clarke, whose many unheralded accomplishments included a founding membership in both the Female Missionary Society and the Maternal Association and the enrollment of at least three children among the revival converts.

Women's role in the revivals was not confined to private, individual efforts like these. Rather, it was often conducted openly, in the quasi-public forums of the Female Missionary society and the Maternal Association. Despite the fragmentary records of these institutions, fully one-third of the converts, or their mothers, can be traced to one or the other organization. Harriet Dana, Mary Walker Ostrom, and Sophia Clarke, for example, were all members of the Female Missionary Society. Although the early awakenings enrolled the actual members of these organizations, the later stages of the revival cycle brought their children into the church. Eighteen of the converts of 1826 can be identified as children of the members of the Female Missionary Society and account for 15% of the conversions. That same revival brought saving grace to sixteen children (13% of all converts) whose mothers belonged to the newly formed Maternal Association. In the subsequent revivals, 1830 and 1838, the imprint of the older organization disappeared but the Maternal Association continued to exercise power behind the pulpit. All in all, known members of the Maternal Association brought at least fifty-five children into the revival ranks. Within these organizations, women consciously wove the social and familial ties that laced through the revival cycle (Table C.8).

In the aftermath of Finney's tour, Utica's male elite took greater interest in revivalism, now clearly a cause to be reckoned with. They quickly established several missionary societies of their own. The membership list of the Western Domestic Missionary Society, founded in 1826, reiterated the same surnames that stocked the earlier female organization: Bagg, Hastings, Stocking, Doolittle, and Van Rensselaer, to name a few. From the date of its founding, the Western Domestic Missionary Society courted the cooperation of women and within a year invited the female organization to become a formal auxiliary. The Utica-based leadership of the Female Missionary Society of the Western District voted to accept this invitation.

Off in the rural areas, however, the female organization of evangelism died a slower death and, in fact, experienced a brief renascence. The auxiliaries regarded the decision to consolidate with the Domestic Missionary Society as only tentative, and in 1829 they came back into operation. Even if the evangelical goals could be achieved without the Female Missionary Society, these women argued, "we should ourselves at any rate loose an important benefit. That pleasing interchange of views and feelings on the grand objects of our association - those heartfelt communications of hope, joy and gratitude, to which our connection gives rise, would nearly, if not entirely be lost. The deep interest produced by the work would give way to lassitude, and the living animation which they inspire be succeeded, we have reason to fear, by a chilling indifference/' Significantly, neither Utica nor Whitestown appointed trustees to the revised association. In the absence of their sponsorship, the society collected only $365, sponsored one missionary, and disappeared within two years. With the disappearance of the Female Missionary Society, the more expansive and broadly social wave of women's evangelism subsided.

It had served its purpose, however, and created a powerful successor in the Maternal Association. At the conclusion of the revival cycle, members of the Maternal Association accounted for more than one-third of the converts in the First Presbyterian Church. By this date, furthermore, the Maternal Association had acquired its own machinery for reaching out to women dispersed in their isolated homes. In 1833 the First Presbyterian Society commissioned one of its own members to edit a periodical on the subject of their mutual interest. Mother's Magazine was followed in but a few years by a Baptist equivalent, Mother's Monthly Journal. Other female organizations also continued to share in the exercise of women's converting power. The Sunday schools founded in 1815 flourished, expanded, and enrolled a broader spectrum of the population in the later stages of the revival cycle. The Sunday-school journal published by Merrill and Colwell regularly reported that scores of their students were converted during each revival season.

## Chicago Citations

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Ryan, *Cradle of the Middle Class*, 96–97.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.010

# The Market Revolution in America: Social, Political, and Religious Expressions, 1800–1880

Melvyn Stokes and Stephen Conway, eds.

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Market Revolution in America: Social, Political, and Religious Expressions, 1800–1880 |
| SELECTION | Consequences In The North |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 27–28 · University Press of Virginia, 1996. |

## Excerpt

Moreover, these changes entailed material, cultural, and political upheavals, divisions, and conflicts. Practitioners of the new ecological history have drawn attention to the alterations to the landscape that accompanied the introduction of market-dedicated farming and logging and the growth of industries dependent on water or mineral resources—changes that often brought lasting damage to ecological systems—and to the profound transformation of the West as white settlement, the expropriation of Native Americans, and the exploitation of animals, land, and minerals permanently changed the face of half a continent in little more than a generation.[9] Patterns of material life and cultural position became more varied. Family farming, for example, remained at the heart of northern agriculture even as farmers became market oriented, but their position as owners of property and producers of their own goods set farmers increasingly apart from the growing numbers of agricultural and industrial wage workers, whose relationship to the means of production were quite different. Class divisions within industrial districts and cities became more apparent, as distinctions grew between "masters" and "hands" and as residential segregation by class became common. Political changes accompanied—even if they did not perfectly reflect— these conflicts. In general terms, as Sean Wilentz has written, the market revolution engendered new forms of mass party politics. More specifically, as Sellers argues in his book, politics in the Jacksonian period became a conduit for the deep antagonisms that arose between market-oriented and marketresistant groups in American society; the emergence of mass democracy was also accompanied by changes in legal and political practice that helped fend off resistance to economic change and, in Sellers's words, "made democracy safe for capitalism."0 From the 1830s on, the North's rapid expansion and change, with its political and ideological accompaniments, also deepened its differences with the slave South, sharpening what Sellers calls "the great contradiction" in American society that would be resolved only by civil war.

So the evidence, both of material and economic conditions and of cultural and political circumstances, all points to deep changes in which the market revolution can be attributed a primary or contributory role. However, complex and multifaceted as these contributions were, and divided as historians' opinions are as to their precise significance, most interpretations on which the market revolution thesis rests share a series of assumptions in common about the directions American society took in the nineteenth century—assumptions essentially rooted in a set of binary comparisons between conditions before and after the market revolution had its effects.

To a considerable extent, discussions of market revolution agree in portraying the creation of a new American society and culture from a fixed menu of characteristics. Community gave way before individualism and competitiveness. The rise of long-distance trade, the growth of urban areas, and the decline of older patterns of neighborhood and reciprocity all produced greater impersonality, a greater need to deal with strangers, greater anonymity, and a more abstract system of transactions. Class divisions, mobility, and anonymity all made life more atomistic. Among other things, the market revolution helped instill a greater value on private life, on withdrawal from the world, on a focus on family above community, and on a guardedness about personal matters. These new patterns were mediated and legitimized, moreover, by the arguments of political economy—that "free" economic relationships conformed to the

patterns of nature and should be exempt from interference by government or moral concerns—and by the ideology of free labor, which at once seemed to explain characteristics of the emergent society in the North and to sharpen its conflict with the ambitions of the slave South. The market revolution, in other words, embodied the emergence of American liberalism and its political, ideological, and institutional forms.

Such consequences, and their contrasts with an older, different culture, have long been familiar to historians. What is striking is that so many new studies have been shaped to fit them rather than to call them into question. My argument is not that these things did not happen, or that they are not an accurate reflection of tangible, powerful changes in nineteenth-century culture, but rather that they are in many ways a selective, mutually reinforcing collection of observations that direct attention away from a much richer tapestry of circumstances. In suggesting the need for a different approach, I shall first discuss some of the conceptual bases of the market revolution thesis and then set out some of the social and cultural features that are often missed in assessments of its consequences.

## Author's Notes

9. Particularly valuable in understanding the status and world-view of early Methodists are Nathan O. Hatch, The Democratization of American Christianity (New Haven, Conn., 1989); Donald G. Mathews, Religion in the Old South (Chicago, 1977), esp. pp. 28—37; Russell E. Richey, Early American Methodism (Bloomington, 1991); and William Henry Williams, The Garden of American Methodism: The Delmarva Peninsula, 1769-1820 (Wilmington, Del., 1984). See also George Claude Baker, Jr., An Introduction to the History of Early New England Methodism 1789-1839 (Durham, N.C., 1941); Emory S. Bucke, ed,, The History of American Methodism, 3 vols. (New York, 1964).

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### Shortened citation:

Stokes, *The Market Revolution in America*, 27–28.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.011

# A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837

Paul E. Johnson

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837 |
| SELECTION | Introduction |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 13–14 · Hill and Wang, 1978. |

## Excerpt

Happily, there are ways of doing that. In recent years historians have devised quantitative means of analyzing family structure, kinship relations, political conflict, occupational and geographic mobility, patterns of association, and a variety of other phenomena that had been beyond the range of systematic study. The result has been a series of studies of the family, of political behavior, of occupational success and failure, and so on. Seldom, however, have these techniques been used to explain cultural change or the rise and fall of social movements. Yet the potential is there." With these methods we can demonstrate ways in which various changes intersected in the lives of persons who joined churches during revivals, and thus define the specific social strains that underlay the rise of evangelicalism. We can, in short, systematically trace the social origins of revival religion.

The approach is best tested in a single community. As the site of that investigation I have chosen Rochester, New York. Generally the makers of case studies claim that the subject of their work is somehow representative of communities that experienced whatever phenomena they are trying to explain. That is not the case with Rochester. The sequence of rapid urbanization, religious revival, and political and social reorganization struck that community with uncommon force. Rochester was the first of the inland cities created after 1815 by the commercialization of agriculture. In 1812 the site of Rochester was unbroken wilderness. By 1830 the forest had given way toa city of 10,000, the marketing and manufacturing center for a broad and prosperous agricultural hinterland. Rochester was the capital of western New York's revivalseared "Burned-over District," and a clearinghouse for religious enthusiasms throughout the 1820s and 1830s. The city holds a special place in the history of revivals, for Charles Finney's triumph there in 1830-31 was the most spectacular event within the national revival of that year. In short, Rochester was the most thoroughly evangelized of American cities.'®

Were revivals a response to insecurities engendered by a normless, dog-eat-dog economy? Did they result from spiritual emptiness among men and women who moved too often to establish new social ties or maintain old ones? America's first inland boom town seems a good place to test those propositions. What accounts for the increasingly urban, middle-class character of revivals after 1830? Rochester was the nation's newest city in that year, and Finney's revival there more than any other single event marked the movement of enthusiasm into the cities. What precisely were the links between revivals and the transformation of politics and reform in the 1830s? Again, Rochester was a center of those developments.

The pages that follow attempt a systematic explanation of Charles Finney's revival in Rochester. The attempt is not based upon tourists' tales, theological disputes, or the reminiscences of ministers, although it makes use of all of them. The focus is upon the biographies of the converts themselves, reconstructed from church records, newspapers, genealogical materials, tax lists, city directories, census schedules, petitions sent from Rochester to various agencies of government, and a surprising number of diaries and letters left by participants in the revival. These materials are used to place Finney's converts within four crucial spheres of social experience: domestic life, work, community relations, and politics. The first chapter determines the effects of migration and participation in the boom-town economy upon entrepreneurs and their families. Chapter II describes the transformation of work and community relationships in the 1820s. Chapters III and IV analyze the institutional and ideological framework of politics in the

1820s, and survey the temperance, Sabbatarian, and Antimasonic crusades of those years. The fifth chapter describes the revival itself. The sixth describes its aftermath.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Johnson, Paul E. *A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837*. New York: Hill and Wang, 1978.

**Footnote citation:**

Paul E. Johnson, *A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837* (New York: Hill and Wang, 1978), 13–14.

**Shortened citation:**

Johnson, *A Shopkeeper's Millennium*, 13–14.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.012

# The Burned-over District: The Social and Intellectual History of Enthusiastic Religion in Western New York, 1800-1850

Whitney R. Cross

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Burned-over District: The Social and Intellectual History of Enthusiastic Religion in Western New York, 1800-1850 |
| SELECTION | The Great Revival |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 9–10 · Cornell University Press, 1950. |

## Excerpt

Theological differences also existed, but apparently not in such a way as to affect religious emotionalism. All the major denominations (the Episcopal Church was relatively weak in this area) and most of the smaller ones were strongly revivalistic. Congregationalists, soon Presbyterian under the Plan of Union, were accustomed to social dominance just as they had been in New England. They consequently initiated revival campaigns in which other sects followed, as they had in the home region.

Evidence concerning the development of the Burned-over District churches before 1825 is unreliable, but it suffices to indicate similar patterns of growth among the several denominations. In periods of awakening all increased rapidly; in times of quiet all grew slowly. Prior foundation in particular vicinities gave one or another sect special local strength, but in the region as a whole they appear to have maintained uniform patterns of expansion. Their history can be told as one tale.

The winter of 1799-1800 was in western New York long called the time of the Great Revival, just as it was in Kentucky. But the violent sensationalism of the southern frontiersmen repulsed the relatively staid Yankees, whose experiences, because more calm, have been the more easily forgotten by historians. Additional factors conspired to diminish the fame of the northern awakenings which occurred throughout western New England and New York in scattered places, in various seasons. The one winter represented a culmination and peak of a period of several years, rather than a single, climactic outburst. The preaching techniques and excitement-breeding expectation, which long use would eventually make habitual, had been more completely out of style in New England than in Kentucky. The Great Awakening of the colonial period had come later to the South than to New England and memories were the fresher there on that account. Slow travel and imperfect communications prevented the immediate infection of large areas which would later become customary. Indeed, appearances could easily justify the feeling of conservative clergymen that the spasmodic nature of this Great Revival showed that it came unsought from Heaven, while later ones seemed more directly the work of human agents.

Yet, in proportion to the slight population of upstate New York, the Great Revival must have justified its name. Most of the settled neighborhoods participated. The more homogeneous Yankee centers provided leadership, and strongholds of Congregationalism developed in the towns of the Genesee country. Oneida and Otsego counties farther east shared equally, along with other communities sprinkled between these two population centers. The Methodists seem to have gained over 1,500 members in the one year. Two years later, Lorenzo Dow first visited the village of Western, where Charles Finney would commence his triumphs in 1825.

Paris Hill. Western itself, after a three-day camp meeting involving over twenty preachers of various sects, became the base of the key Methodist circuit for central New York. Here also “Crazy” Dow met and married his “rib,” Peggy, and here he returned four times before 1817 to reinvigorate the locality.

After 1800 excitement diminished, rose again to a lesser peak in 1807-1808, and slumped once more during the war years. But even the least promising seasons saw awakenings in a few localities.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Cross, *The Burned-over District*, 9–10.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.013

# Radical Spirits: Spiritualism and Women's Rights in Nineteenth-Century America

Ann Braude

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Radical Spirits: Spiritualism and Women's Rights in Nineteenth-Century America |
| SELECTION | Introduction |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 2–3 · Beacon Press, 1989. |

## Excerpt

Her baby's death and the advent of her mediumship culminated her emancipation from the religious perspective that dominated her family and her era. When Anne Denton Cridge became a Spiritualist, she joined a popular and controversial movement that assumed a self-conscious identity in North America in the mid-nineteenth century.' Spiritualism was a new religious movement aimed at proving the immortality of the soul by establishing communication with the spirits of the dead. Whether reverenced or ridiculed, Spiritualism was ubiquitous on the American scene at mid-century. For some it provided solace in the face of bereavement, for some entertainment, for some a livelihood earned from the credulous. For many it provided evidence of the immortality of the soul that formed the basis of a sincere religious faith. For iconoclasts and nonconformists it provided an alternative to the established religious order. It held two attractions that proved irresistible to thousands of Americans: rebellion against death and rebellion against authority.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Braude, Ann. *Radical Spirits: Spiritualism and Women's Rights in Nineteenth-Century America*. Boston: Beacon Press, 1989.

**Footnote citation:**

Ann Braude, *Radical Spirits: Spiritualism and Women's Rights in Nineteenth-Century America* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1989), 2–3.

**Shortened citation:**

Braude, *Radical Spirits*, 2–3.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.014

# Sisters and Saints: Women and American Religion

Ann Braude

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|---|---|
| WORK | Sisters and Saints: Women and American Religion |
| SELECTION | When The Spirit Moves Women |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 35–36 · Oxford University Press, 2007. |

## Excerpt

Although women constituted a majority of converts throughout the revivals, they made up a smaller majority than women usually did in church membership. Thus revivals marked an increase in the proportion of male church members. This increase, however, seems to indicate an increase in women's influence over male family members rather than a decline in women's religious role. Church records show that male revival converts were often led into church by pious wives, mothers, and sisters. The abolitionist Theodore Dwight Weld recalled the tactics used by his Aunt Clark to cajole male relatives into attending revivals. She asked him to join her for a morning service on the pretense that Charles Finney, whom he despised, was not preaching until the afternoon. Once there, she led him into a pew and followed with several ladies, making his exit impossible. When Finney began to preach and young Theodore attempted escape, Aunt Clark whispered, "You'll break my heart if you go!" Weld remained, was converted, and devoted his life to evangelical reform. Women had a lot to gain from men's participation in evangelical culture. Legally subject to and economically dependent on husbands and fathers, women were vulnerable to harddrinking, lazy, or unfaithful men. Men reborn as Christians absorbed the values of Evangelicalism: temperance, thrift, and productivity. Revival supporters pictured men who formerly spent their leisure time drinking with other men now praying with their families instead. Evangelical morality supplied men with a set of values that many believed benefited women. One reform movement especially symbolized the strength women gained from evangelical Christianity. This was the moral reform movement, aimed at eliminating prostitution. Advocates hoped to reform both the "fallen women" who worked as prostitutes and the men who patronized them. In doing so, they attacked the double standard that condemned the smallest fall from sexual purity in women, but accepted that moral men might patronize prostitutes.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Braude, Ann. *Sisters and Saints: Women and American Religion*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2007.

**Footnote citation:**

Ann Braude, *Sisters and Saints: Women and American Religion* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2007), 35–36.

**Shortened citation:**

Braude, *Sisters and Saints*, 35–36.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.015

# Strangers and Pilgrims: Female Preaching in America, 1740-1845

Catherine A. Brekus

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Strangers and Pilgrims: Female Preaching in America, 1740-1845 |
| SELECTION | 3 Female Preaching in the Early Nineteenth Century |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 138–139 · University of North Carolina Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

Demographically, the sheer number of women sitting in the church pews subtly a√ected clerical attitudes toward female preaching. Because women increasingly dominated church membership lists in the years after the American Revolution, one historian has christened the nineteenth-century revivals as a "women's awakening." In 1798, for example, the Freewill Baptist leadership refused to allow a church in Brookfield, New Hampshire, to form its own Monthly Meeting because almost all of its members were women. "There is so few mail members it Dont look as if you Could be able to keep up proper order," they explained. Similarly, between 1800 and 1860, women made up a full 60 percent of the new members admitted to all the churches in Cortland County, New York.∑∞ Although clergymen feared that such large numbers of female converts might make the church peripheral to the larger culture, they also began to give women greater opportunities to testify and preach. On one hand, they did not want women to "rule" over men, but on the other, they had always encouraged them to meet in single-sex groups for prayer and spiritual reflection. There seemed to be no reason to prevent women from speaking publicly to other women.

These sects also allowed women to preach because of the shortage of ordained male ministers. In their formative years, the Methodists, African Methodists, Freewill Baptists, and Christians simply did not have enough ordained clergy to keep pace with their spectacular growth. In 1795, for example, when Sally Parsons told the Yearly Meeting of Freewill Baptists that she had been called to preach, they were desperate to find new laborers in the harvest. Even by 1810, after intensive recruiting e√orts, there were still only sixty-four Freewill Baptist ministers to lead one hundred congregations.∑≤ Out of necessity, then, these sects turned to women as well as lay men to help lead meetings and organize new churches. As one Christian elder later remembered, his disapproval evident, "It was too much a fashion with the order of people with whom I had connected myself, to make preachers of almost all who opened their mouths in public." Even as late as 1838, when the Christians had become a popular and thriving denomination, the Christian Journal ran an article entitled "Laborers Wanted" encouraging lay people to appoint their own religious meetings "when ministerial help is not conveniently obtained.'

Because of the scarcity of laborers, particularly in remote areas of the country, women often held informal religious services for their friends and neighbors. During the 1770s, two Methodist "praying women" in the backwoods of Georgia began holding meetings that eventually attracted the "whole neighborhood." Although these women were too humble to presume to preach, they read chapters of the Bible aloud, sang hymns, and urged their listeners to shoulder the "cross" of Christian faith. At their first public meeting, one "o√ered up a most fervent and deeply impressive prayer to God," while the other told "the plain, simple story of her conversion." Moved by the power of their words, several fell "as if smitten with lightning to the floor," while "others fled from the house in the greatest consternation." The two women continued holding religious meetings until the Reverend Bennett Maxey, a Methodist itinerant, heard about their success and arrived to take control.∑∂ In a fitting irony, Maxey's name has survived in the historical record, but the women's names have not.

Emboldened by the absence of ordained clergymen, a few women asserted their call to preach as well as witness and exhort. When Abigail Roberts, a Christian, traveled to Milford, New Jersey, in 1833, there was not a single Christian Connection minister in the town, and as the sole representative of her church, she began holding meetings to explain

her beliefs. Perhaps her male colleagues would have resented her boldness under di√erent circumstances, but because they were anxious to find new laborers to minister to those who were "scattered abroad, as sheep having no shepherd," they gladly welcomed her help. "She was the first who carried the doctrine of the people known as the Christians... into the north and west of New Jersey," wrote David Millard. "For over one year she laboured alone, and may be said to have been the most e≈cient instrument of opening the way into most of the places where churches of our Connexion have since been planted in that state. Her labors have been abundantly blessed."∑∑ With few men available, Roberts helped to turn the Christians from a small, struggling sect into a successful denomination.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Brekus, *Strangers and Pilgrims*, 138–139.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.016

# Southern Cross: The Beginnings of the Bible Belt

Christine Leigh Heyrman

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|---|---|
| WORK | Southern Cross: The Beginnings of the Bible Belt |
| SELECTION | + Southern Cross |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 194–195 · University of North Carolina Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

Evangelicals, of course, had a horror of being confused with the Shakers. And that dread, as Shaker villages sprang up in the midst of southern settlements in the western country, only added to the urgency of resolving the dilemma posed by female virtuosos in Baptist and Methodist churches. Now southerners could witness firsthand women wielding both spiritual and temporal power over such Shaker "families," claiming superior religious charisma as the basis of that authority. Here, indeed, was a caution to Baptists and Methodists, whose own ranks harbored clergymen urging, on the same grounds, that godly women might hold church office and preach. Accordingly, evangelicals took steps to distinguish their views on women from those of the Shakers. One of their shrewdest polemicists was Abram Van Vleet, a Presbyterian printer in Lebanon, Ohio, who acquainted southerners with Mary Dyer and Eunice Chapman, two northern women who sought divorces and custody of their children after their husbands joined the Shakers.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Heyrman, Christine Leigh. *Southern Cross: The Beginnings of the Bible Belt*. New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1997.

**Footnote citation:**

Christine Leigh Heyrman, *Southern Cross: The Beginnings of the Bible Belt* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1997), 194–195.

**Shortened citation:**

Heyrman, *Southern Cross*, 194–195.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.017

# Vanguard: How Black Women Broke Barriers, Won the Vote, and Insisted on Equality for All

Martha S. Jones

| | |
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| WORK | Vanguard: How Black Women Broke Barriers, Won the Vote, and Insisted on Equality for All |
| SELECTION | CHAPTER 2 The Cause of the Slave, as Well as of Women |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages reflowed ebook; no fixed page numbers · Basic Books, 2020. |

## Excerpt

Not content to stay cloistered in classrooms or at her writing desk, Paul organized her pupils into the Juvenile Choir of Boston and traveled with them on the road throughout New England. On stage, the choir performed a repertoire that condemned slavery and colonization with songs such as “Ye Who Are in Bondage Pine” and “Home, This Is Our Home.” It was a test of New England’s commitment to racial equality and Paul exposed its fault lines. Though Massachusetts had abolished slavery decades earlier and led the abolitionist movement, racism plagued the work of Paul and her young charges. After a performance in Salem, coach drivers refused to shuttle the choir back to Boston. Paul found the group another way home, remaining steely and resourceful throughout the ordeal. She later remarked: “We were not surprised at our treatment from these persons. This is but a faint picture of that spirit which persecutes us on account of our color—that cruel prejudice which deprives us of every privilege whereby we might elevate ourselves—and then absurdly condemns us because we are not more refined and intelligent.”12

The urgent efforts of radical antislavery societies drew Paul to politics. She saw Black women playing pathbreaking roles in that movement. The Black women of Salem, Massachusetts, took the trouble to advise William Lloyd Garrison that he had wrongly accused Black Americans of failing to establish antislavery societies. The women published their constitution in The Liberator, evidence that the Female Anti-Slavery Society of Salem, led by Black women, had been founded in February 1832. They lit a spark. Paul joined antislavery societies—first the New England Anti-Slavery Society and then its women’s auxiliary, the Boston Female Anti-Slavery Society—and was immediately out in front of a movement. It did not take long for her to learn that women could not maintain middle-class comportment at antislavery meetings.

Paul soon witnessed firsthand how opponents did not hesitate to place women in the crosshairs of the contest over slavery during the October 1835 meeting of the Boston Female Anti-Slavery Society. A mob disrupted the proceedings, descending upon the delegates and attempting to capture the women’s guest speaker, British abolitionist George Thompson. Eventually, the crowd let the women escape. But they took William Lloyd Garrison into their hands and nearly lynched him on the streets of Boston. Paul weathered the melee and remained steadfast in her antislavery commitments. their local meetings remained important, and they still attended men’s meetings, in 1837, American women called for their own national convention. It was time, the call explained, for women to lead the movement, much in the way that women antislavery activists in Britain did. Not everyone welcomed the opportunity, and some women stayed home, reluctant to challenge the men who had steered the radical opposition to slavery through its early years. Those who packed their bags and set out for women’s gatherings were building something altogether new.

In 1838, Paul joined this new wave. She traveled by coach from Boston, part of a delegation that included two Black members, Paul and Martha Ball. A shared commitment to the cause moved these antislavery women—Black and white—to welcome one another across the color line. They were allies in a women-led foray into national politics, yet the alliance was not easy or untroubled. Antislavery women walked together on Philadelphia’s streets, but they did not travel in the same shoes. Racism divided their experiences, casting a shadow over women’s conventions, both outside and inside the meeting halls. When the women pledged to meet for politics, in public, together—Black and

white—everyone had reason to be uneasy.

Among the women who greeted Susan Paul in Philadelphia was Sarah Mapps Douglass. They knew one another from the antislavery press. Both women had been featured in Garrison's The Liberator. But at the convention, they met face-to-face, among the few Black women who made the trip to Philadelphia. Though small in number, this handful quickly assumed leadership, contributing their political acumen. Their presence was also symbolic for the women's antislavery movement. The visibility of women like Paul and Douglass testified to the convention's antiracist ideals. The delegates endorsed Susan Paul as a vice president, Sarah Mapps Douglass as treasurer and business committee member, and Martha Ball as secretary. These Black women then assumed seats within the convention's inner circle, steering toward a political platform and a distinctly women's agenda. It was a promising start. But it also proved to be as close as Black women would ever get to national leadership in the antislavery movement.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Jones, *Vanguard*, reflowed ebook; no fixed page numbers.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.018

# Freedom's Ferment: Phases of American Social History from the Colonial Period to the Outbreak of the Civil War

Alice Felt Tyler

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|---|---|
| WORK | Freedom's Ferment: Phases of American Social History from the Colonial Period to the Outbreak of the Civil War |
| SELECTION | Chapter |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 11–12 · University of Minnesota Press, 1944. |

## Excerpt

With the revolutions that marked the end of the eighteenth century the old manner of treating the delinquent and the defective was rejected as an anachronism in a world that had recognized the importance of the individual. Beccaria's Crime and Punishment had been as widely read as Rousseau's Emile, and Montesquieu was known for his doctrines on the reform of criminal law and procedure as well as for his theories of government. It was early recognized that there was a fundamental incompatibility between the social forces of the American Revolution and the criminal codes of the colonial era. If the equality proclaimed in the Declaration of Independence meant anything at all, it meant equality before the law. If American statesmen were to give more than lip service to the humane and optimistic idea of man's improvability, they must remove the barbarism and vindictiveness from their penal codes and admit that one great objective of punishment for crime must be the reformation of the criminal.

Already men were groping toward the conception that man is in part the product of his environment and that society itself is responsible for many nonsocial actions. Science was soon to suggest that heredity, health, and other physical and psychological factors might play their part in delinquency and deficiency, making the criminal the victim as well as the villain in the social drama that ended in the prisoner's dock, and marking the defective as the unfortunate result of conditions for which he could not be held responsible. "An eye for an eye and a tooth for a tooth" seemed a barbaric principle of social revenge, and the righteous desire of the Puritan to cut off the wicked from the face of the earth gave way to a gentler doctrine of regeneration.

The change was not peculiar to the United States but was a part of the worldwide humanitarianism of the period. As in other lines of social progress, reform crossed national boundaries, and any list of those interested in the improvement of institutions for criminals or defectives must be international in scope. But the part played by the United States was far from ignoble. Indeed, so marked was the American advance in the treatment of society's unfortunates that European travelers made special efforts to visit American prisons and asylums, and European governments commissioned agents to study and report upon American progress.

Always these visitors sought to note such features of American plans as might with profit be copied in their own lands. In their turn, American humanitarians traveling abroad made contact with the managers of European institutions and brought home ideas for further changes in the American system. These humanitarians gave of their time and money to societies organized to work for reform, wrote letters and reports, and left for posterity the record of the movement that had been of such importance to them.

The fundamental democratic principles on which American Society is organized, are those "principles of justice and mercy" by which the guilty, the ignorant, the needy, and the infirm, are saved and blessed. The charity of a democratic society is heart-reviving to witness; for there is a security that no wholesale oppression is bearing down the million in one direction, while charity is lifting up the hundred in another. Generally speaking, the misery that is seen is all that exists: there is no paralysing sense of the hopelessness of setting up individual benevolence against

social injustice. If the community has not yet arrived at the point at which all communities are destined to arrive, of perceiving guilt to be infirmity, of obviating punishment, ignorance, and want, still the Americans are more blessed than others, in the certainty that they have far less superinduced misery than society abroad, and are using wiser methods than others for its alleviation.

## Chicago Citations

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Tyler, Alice Felt. *Freedom's Ferment: Phases of American Social History from the Colonial Period to the Outbreak of the Civil War*. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1944.

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**Shortened citation:**

Tyler, *Freedom's Ferment*, 11–12.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.019

# Pillars of the Republic: Common Schools and American Society, 1780-1860

Carl F. Kaestle

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|---|---|
| WORK | Pillars of the Republic: Common Schools and American Society, 1780-1860 |
| SELECTION | X / Preface |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · Hill and Wang, 1983. |

## Excerpt

These groups did not make common cause with each other, did not have the same goals, and did not succeed in preventing the achieve various concessions and adjustments, thus contributing to the shape and content of American common schooling as it existed by 860. This book is about schools, not about all education. Families, churches, apprenticeships, and other institutions continued to was also the period during which the school was emerging as the principal agent of cognitive and moral teaching and as an important instrument of public policy. This book attempts to explain that process. It looks beyond schools to the broader economic and cultural context, but only in order to explain changes in the organization and purposes of schooling. If one wants to understand state policy toward education, schools are the appropriate focus. Society educates in many ways; the state educates through schools. The chapters of this book are organized around two chronothe antebellum period (1830 to 1860). Within these periods chapters are organized on a topical basis. After a brief prologue about the educational ideas of the founding fathers, two chapters describe rural and urban schooling in the early national period and note some connections between education and social changes between 1780 and 1830. The next four chapters concentrate on the North in the antebellum period. The argument moves from then to popular reaction. Common-school developments in the midwestern states generally followed the same lines as those in the Northeast. This raises some interesting questions about the causes of successful common-school systematization, because the Midwest was less industrial and less urban than the Northeast. Most southern states, in contrast, did not adopt tax-supported, state-regulated common schools by the time of the Civil War. Historians have long characterized the South as a region with truth. There was much common-school reform effort and support in the South. Nonetheless, the North-South contrast is important.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.020

# The Jacksonian Promise: America, 1815-1840

Daniel Feller

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Jacksonian Promise: America, 1815-1840 |
| SELECTION | The Kingdom of Christ |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 115–116 · Johns Hopkins University Press, 1995. |

## Excerpt

Reformers saw themselves as altruists. They wished to help others find the same conviction and discipline that had brought them success, happiness, and peace of mind. They preached liberation, not repression. They yearned to help everyone escape the bondage of sin. As they had learned, only those who mastered base impulses and achieved genuine self-control could count themselves truly free.

In short they wanted, quite innocently and honestly, to shape America in their own image. Their motives, if not disinterested, were far from selfish. Finney gave up a promising career at the bar to preach the gospel. Garrison and other abolitionists courted injury and even martyrdom. The Grimkes accepted exile from their Carolina home. Theodore Weld, an orator and writer of immense promise, knowingly destroyed his health in service to antislavery. Illinois abolitionist editor Elijah Lovejoy lost three printing presses to mobs. Defending a fourth, he lost his life. The Tappans spent a literal fortune on reform, and got paid in resentment, ridicule, riot, and ruin. They never regretted the bargain.

Still, many Americans rejected the reformers' self-image of selfless benevolence. If they saw themselves as humble advocates for Christ, others saw them as prudes and busybodies, meddling in other people's lives and telling them what to do. Baptists and Methodists, recalling their long struggle against state clerical establishments, hesitated to join reform ventures led by their old oppressors. Catholics, still few in number in 1830 (Irish immigration, which at mid-century would exceed one hundred thousand a year, totaled only fifty thousand during the 1820s), shunned crusaders who condemned their ways as sinful and refused even to recognize them as Christians.

To the unconverted, the unconvinced, and the uninterested, the moral certitude of Christian zealots could be truly insufferable. Lewis Tappan foisted tracts on everyone he met, at his boardinghouse and even on vacation. Lyman Beecher invited hearers to choose for themselves—but he threatened damnation on those who chose wrongly. Slaveholders and nonslaveholders who thought themselves good citizens and good Christians reddened with rage at William Lloyd Garrison's presuming to pass divine judgment on them.

Reformers for the most part favored tools of persuasion; they sought to convince, not coerce. Still, behind the helping hand of voluntarism lurked the fist of compulsion. Some temperance-minded businessmen organized boycotts against the liquor trade and demanded that their employees quit drinking. The Tappans required church attendance of their clerks and wielded their financial muscle to punish the ungodly, a tactic that slaveholders later turned upon them.

One branch of evangelical reform, the Sabbatarian crusade, was plainly coercive. Since the War of 1812, Congregational and Presbyterian clergy had tried to enlist the federal government in their campaign to stop business on the Lord's Day. On July 4,1827, Reverend Ezra Stiles Ely preached in Philadelphia on "the duty of Christian freemen to elect Christian rulers" and build "a Christian party in politics. " In New York, after failing to get Erie Canal locks closed on Sundays, Sabbatarian businessmen organized six-day stage and boat lines and threatened to boycott Sunday traffickers. In 1828 the General Union for the Promotion of the Christian Sabbath circulated petitions to ban federal Sunday mail service. Opponents charged them with trying to abrogate the separation of church and state.

Plans to evangelize the West hinted of both sectional and cultural imperialism. Eastern sophisticates found the explosion of raw western growth both exhilarating and disturbing. A young Ralph Waldo Emerson noted that "the

vast rapidity with which the deserts & forests of the interior of this country are peopled have led patriots to fear lest the nation grow too fast for its virtue & peace." Proper Bostonians, New Yorkers, and Philadelphians worried that without proper instruction, these "raw multitudes"— the "offscouring of civilized society," "an ignorant & licentious people"— would "pour out upon the world an accursed tribe of barbarous robbers." But if they could be schooled "to speak a voice of wisdom & virtue, the reformation of the world would be to be expected from America." It was to instruct the West in Christian civilization that Lyman Beecher went to Cincinnati, and that eastern societies showered westerners with Bibles, tracts, Sunday schools, and missionaries.

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**Footnote citation:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Feller, *The Jacksonian Promise*, 115–116.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.021

# The Discovery of the Asylum: Social Order and Disorder in the New Republic

David J. Rothman

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Discovery of the Asylum: Social Order and Disorder in the New Republic |
| SELECTION | Introduction to the 1990 Edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · Little, Brown, 1971. |

## Excerpt

The Discovery of the Asylum argues that Jacksonian Americans experienced a crisis o f confidence i n the social organization o f the new republic, fearful that the ties that once bound citizens together — the ties o f community, church, and family — were loosening and that, as a consequence, social disorganization ap peared imminent. Their fears were confirmed and exacerbated by the extent o f the crime, poverty, delinquency, and insanity that they saw around them. I n response to these perceptions, to an anxiety about the stability o f the social order and an alarm about the extent o f deviancy and dependency, they discovered the solution o f the asylum. This institution would at once reha bilitate the inmates, thereby reducing crime, insanity, and pov erty, andwould then, through the very success o f its design, set an example for the larger society. The good order o f the asylum, its routine o f punctuality and steady labor, would act as both a cure anda preventive — reforming its charges and serving as amodel to the community. It was a grand and almost Utopian vision, one that sought to ensure the safety o f the republic and promote its glory.

Michael Ignatieff, analyzing the origins o f prisons i n England, andAndrew Scull and Robert Castel, analyzing the origins o f insane asylums, one inEnglandand the other i n France, each put their own gloss o n this approach, but all o f them link the design and popularity o f the asylum to a wider societal mission, an effort to restore stability where disorganization seemed ram pant.

Ignatieff hinges his account ona sharp increase i n crime, pau perism, and unrest inEngland after 1815, the result ofa disin tegration o f traditional ties and relationships i n agriculture (in the southeast), i n the new factories (in the north), and, most visibly, inLondon.

" The massive investment i n institutional solutions," writes Ignatieff, "would have been inconceivable u n less the authorities had believed that they were faced with the breakdown ofa society o f stable ranks and the emergence ofa society o f hostile classes." This perception affected a diverse groupof constituents, including evangelical philanthropists, manufacturers, secular reformers, and public officials; and all o f them, for their own particular reasons, promoted the develop ment ofa prison system that would segregate the offender and subject him to a routine o f discipline and labor. For some, the main attraction o f the new arrangement was that it would divide the criminal class from the working class and thereby reduce a propensity to riot or rebellion. Others welcomed the prospect o f demonstrating that the state was powerful even as it was merci ful. Still others believed that the prison would promote religious reformation within and without its walls, and some hoped it would instill an internal discipline o f order and regularity not only i n those who arrived at the prison but also i n those who arrived each morning at the factory gate.

The motives o f asy lum proponents, then, were varied and not easily sorted out or ranked by weight o f influence. In the end, the prison satisfied a variety o f agendas, all o f which had as their initial inspiration an effort to bind together a fragmented society.

Andrew Scull is also convinced that a crisis swept over E n gland i n the late eighteenth and early nineteenth century as it lurched " froma social order dominated by rank, order, and degree to one based o n class." The chief agent o f

change was "the development o f national and international markets [that] producedadiminution, i f not a destruction, o f the traditional influence o f local groups (especially kinship groups), which for merly played a large role i n the regulation o f social life." Scull finds anumberof reasons that this breakdown should have stim ulated the growth o f the asylum. H e notes the contributions o f both Evangelicalism and Utilitarianism. For the religiously mo tivated, an ordered asylum was a way to make certain that "those who had lost their reason should not also lose their souls." For secularists, the filth, cruelty, and neglect that the insane suffered was "a powerful argument against the haphazard, amateurish, social policies o f the past" as well as an opportunity to impose a new rationality and order. A t the same time, marketing and manufacturing activities demonstrated how raw materials could be transformed through human intervention, thereby embold ening some o f the new capitalists (most notably the Quakers) to dare to consider transforming the mad. The new industrial ac tivity sensitized still others to the need to impose a new order o f discipline o n the working class and then, by extension, o n the mad: "Lunatics, too, were to be made over i n the image o f bour geois rationality."

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Rothman, *The Discovery of the Asylum*, no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.022

# American Heretic: Theodore Parker and Transcendentalism

Dean Grodzins

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|---|---|
| WORK | American Heretic: Theodore Parker and Transcendentalism |
| SELECTION | 5. All the Force of Transcendentalism That Is in Me |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of North Carolina Press, 2002. |

## Excerpt

Castor then announces that he will debate no more. He wants his scheme to be tried, "& since I am the strongest Beaver in the race, & of the most ancient family—& already have such a name for wisdom that the degree of Great Dam Projector—has been conferred on me this early, I shall go to work & take the lead of the rest in the most difficult labour of planning & building." The greybeards, afraid to sit still, joined him; the rest fell "merrily" in. They built better than before, and there has never since been a quarrel about mine and thine, for all have enough to spare.

There is an authoritarian element in this fantasy of which Parker may not have been wholly conscious. The idea of a single, heroic genius reorganizing a society resembles Jean-Jacques Rousseau's equally authoritarian concept of a national "Legislator."149 Parker's intended moral, however, seems to have been simply that society could be reformed if the true ideal were set before it—work he believed the "strong" members of society were both suited and morally obligated to undertake. Parker approved when George Ripley founded Brook Farm in □□□□on a democratic plan of mutual education: laborers and scholars would work side by side and teach each other. Yet Parker himself never joined Brook Farm, although he lived only two miles away. He believed his principal contribution to social reform would be made by transforming the church.

"I□□□□□□me groan to look into the evils of society," wrote Parker in his journal in July □□□□. "I thank God I am not born to set the matter right. I scarce dare attempt a reform of theology, lest I be in for the whole, & must… condemn the state & society no less than the church."150 Yet if Parker chose to focus his energies on reforming theology and the church, he did not believe he was thereby neglecting social reform. Rather, he placed religious reform at the center of his social reform plans.

So did the other Transcendentalists. At four of the five meetings of the little club in □□□□, the discussion revolved around reform and the creation of a new church. Brownson, Ripley, Alcott, and Parker, who differed with one another on many issues, all agreed that without religious reform, social change was impossible.

Once the Transcendentalists' ideas about religious reform are understood, some apparent disagreements between them diminish. For example, Parker says many times that although Christianity must be applied to the state and society, the "chiefest" and "best" way to apply it—the way that will ultimately do the most social good—is to the individual. Trust not to society, he says, to do the work of a divine life. Brownson, by contrast, in his articles on the "Laboring Classes," dismisses the idea society can be transformed by converting individuals to Christianity.

"Could we convert all men to Christianity in both theory and practice, as held by the most enlightened sect of Christians among us," he asserts, "the evils of the social state would remain untouched.… The only way to get rid of its evils is to change the system, not its managers.'

If read more carefully, however, Brownson is saying that it is useless to convert people to the Christianity of the church, even in its Unitarian form. He believes the world would indeed be changed if people were converted to the Christianity of Christ. The church "makes its deluded disciples believe that they have done their duty to God when they have joined the church, offered a prayer, sung a psalm, and contributed of their means to send out a missionary to preach unintelligible doctrines to the poor heathen." By contrast, Christ demands that we "labor to reform society,

to mould it according to the will of God and the nature of man." Parker's own distinction between the Christianities of the church and of Christ was similar.

Parker and Brownson, as has been seen, did disagree about inherited property. But in view of their ideas about religious reform, this disagreement does not appear so important. Brownson himself admits that any change in property relations would be a long time coming and then only after a mighty struggle. Our first task, he says, is the abolition of the "priesthood"—that class of persons which pretends to mediate between humanity and God. Fundamental change in the church, he and Parker agreed, was a priority.

Brownson locates the historical origin of social injustice in the priesthood. Early in human history, he says, certain people arose who took advantage of the natural human religious sentiment and the popular deference given to the wise to enslave their fellows and ensure honors and emolument for themselves. In this process, they brought to an end the wild freedom of the savage state and moved the race onto the first stage of civilization. The priesthood, therefore, is found everywhere as humanity rises out of savagery, ruling with an iron hand. The priests set up systems of social inequality that persist to this day, Brownson believes, and are the ultimate cause of the condition of the working classes.

## Chicago Citations

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**Footnote citation:**

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Grodzins, *American Heretic*, no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.023

# Women and the Work of Benevolence: Morality, Politics, and Class in the Nineteenth-Century United States

Lori D. Ginzberg

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| WORK | Women and the Work of Benevolence: Morality, Politics, and Class in the Nineteenth-Century United States |
| SELECTION | ¢ Introduction °* |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 8–9 · Yale University Press, 1990. |

## Excerpt

Tracing this transformation can help us trace the historical development of class identity in the United States and of women's role in it. Gender and class identities and interests, I argue, were not simply simultaneous throughout this process, each acting in its own place, but inextricable. Thus the book asks throughout how the ideology of female benevolence was used differently by women of different social groups and in different settings. What privileges—indeed, what authority— did the conflation of femininity and morality obscure? How did women of different social groups benefit from their commitment to the ideology of benevolent femininity? How did the middle class employ the ideology of benevolence and of female moral superiority in its own process of self-definition? Specifically, what roles did middleand upper-middle-class women themselves play in making the "language of virtue and vice," as Christine Stansell puts it, "a code of class"?10

Understanding the conflation of femaleness and morality in nineteenth-century ideology—and the history of that conflation—can also help us understand the changing nature of authority over the course of that century. Several layers of analysis must be peeled away from the rhetoric of benevolence in order to explain these changes. Certainly it is true, as some women's historians have pointed out, that the ideology of female moral influence granted some women more personal authority than they might otherwise have had, even as it demanded that they accede to their social subordination to men. It is also the case, as earlier historians of benevolence have argued, that the ideology of benevolence, and especially its insistence on specific standards of sexual, work, religious, and leisure behavior, underpinned the cultural authority of a multilayered middle class over the poor, the non-Protestant, and the fallen.

More surprising, perhaps, are the ways in which a reexamination of female benevolence and authority provides us with new insights into American political history. Antebellum political life reflected an important moment in the nation's struggle to balance democracy with the rule of dominant groups, a struggle too often viewed only in terms of an increasingly diverse electorate and party structure. Yet, although the extension of the franchise might mean the expansion and sharing of authority among Americans, it also meant that authority operated in hidden ways in an ostensibly democratic society. If the ideology of benevolence carried within it both radical and conservative implications for the development of women's sense of sexual solidarity, so too did the growing centrality of electoral politics contain complex and even contradictory meanings about the possibilities for social change. This book thus examines a society and, especially, a class that proclaimed the transcendent authority of women's influence in light of the changing nature of—and debate about—authority in American political life. The answers to these questions will surely teach us something about ideology—ranging from that of the most conservative and socially prominent of benevolent women to the most radical of middle-class Protestants—but more important, about the nature of gender as a social construct and the historical relationship among women, benevolence, and class.

The book is chronologically arranged, although several themes distinguish each chapter. After exploring the basic tenets of the ideology of female benevolence, chapter 1 describes the radical and conservative possibilities of that ideology, focusing especially on the role of women's belief in "benevolent femininity" in creating an analysis of

sisterhood which could undermine male dominance, in defining the middle class, and in guarding propriety. The book then explores the ways in which women of different social groups participated in undertakings that the ideology of femininity itself obscured—business and political activities, for example. Chapter 2 analyzes a broad spectrum of the business of benevolence, especially for women involved in traditional charitable and relief endeavors. It focuses in particular on women's participation in fund raising, wage paying, and legal incorporation, activities that the ideology of an intrinsically female nature so persistently obscured. Chapter 3 assesses the ideological separation of morality and politics in light of evidence that women participated in varied and extensive political activities. It also examines how the middle class's most radical—or "ultraist" female reformers grappled with their own political identities in the face of profound changes in American political life.

Although I initially expected to find that the fulcrum for the major changes in benevolence was the Civil War, it became clear that by the 1840s and 1850s, women and men were increasingly adopting institutional and electoral means for change and that these changes signaled new opportunities—as well as limits—for benevolent activists.

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**Shortened citation:**

Ginzberg, *Women and the Work of Benevolence*, 8–9.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.024

# Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872

Nancy A. Hewitt

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|---|---|
| WORK | Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872 |
| SELECTION | A Profusion of Pathways |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 45–46 · Cornell University Press, 1984. |

## Excerpt

Yet in 1806 in Guilford, Connecticut, female parishioners at the Presbyterian Church failed in their attempt to form a female charity society. Their major opponent was the Reverend Mr. Elliott, whose “opinion would bear great weight with many.” He believed such societies “to be ostentatious” and felt women could “find sufficient objects upon which to bestow their mite, within their own limits.” Mary Stone did not entirely agree with her spiritual leader but wrote to coworshiper and coworker Mabel Ward that it was perhaps best to “omit meeting” and “gather what money we can,... and send it enclosed in a letter with as little noise and ostentation as possible.” Frontier conditions and the attendant necessity of everyone’s labor apparently made women’s public labors more acceptable, for in 1822 Mabel Ward became the first president of the Rochester CS.'* Moreover, she and her coworkers received the wholehearted support of village fathers, including the leading clergymen, who preached fund-raising sermons on the CS’s behalf in 1822. For perfectionist women, the frontier was less geographical than moral. The land and animals around Rochester had been tamed, but men themselves had grown wilder, demonstrating vices too numerous to count and too lascivious to contemplate. In organizing local campaigns to rid the land of intemperance, slavery, and licentiousness, perfectionists drew on their experiences as benevolent laborers, revival agents, and small-town moral reformers and on their knowledge of activities in New York City, Philadelphia, and Boston.” The achievement of a perfect society demanded a nationwide effort, and the existence of the American Anti-Slavery Society in Boston and the American Female Moral Reform Society in New York City eased women’s entrance into public activism in smaller communities. The initial support of evangelical clergy, including such national figures as Charles Grandison Finney, also legitimated women’s efforts. Once involved in perfectionist activities, local women were spurred on by the need to send periodic reports to the parent societies and reinforced by the publication of letters and reports in national journals such as the Liberator and the Advocate of Moral Reform. Even when retreating from perfectionist labors in the 1840s, evangelical women would follow the paths set by their big-city sisters, who first moved from moral reform to the institutionalization of “friendless’” women and from immediate emancipation to aid for free blacks and fugitive slaves.'* Ultraists, settling in Rochester later than their benevolent or perfectionist counterparts, arrived with the greatest amount of public experience. Within Quaker meetings and farming communities, women were active in the promotion of social order and community welfare. Traditions of social service—to the poor, imprisoned, and insane—and of social reform—in religious testimonies against slavery, intemperance, and war—characterized Quaker circles throughout England and America. From the 1834 founding of the Genesee Yearly Meeting, which encompassed portions of Canada, central New York and the Old Northwest as well as Rochester, the women’s and men’s “meetings” also voiced their disapproval of capital punishment and tobacco and their support of Indian rights, manual labor schools and woman’s rights." In the transition from Quaker activism to worldly activism, ultraist women, like their perfectionist counterparts, utilized the resources of national associations such as the American Anti-Slavery Society. Since they came to worldly labors in Rochester with considerably more experience than earlier female activists. however, ultraists were less dependent on extralocal models and sometimes surpassed national leaders in their vision of a free and equal society." Frontier conditions, previous experience, clerical support, and extralocal models and resources all bolstered women’s entry into the public domain. On an individual basis“ however, the most important factor may well have been the support of family and friends, especially of female kin and husbands. In many families both men and women responded to appeals for action from ministers, village leaders, itinerant reform agents, or their own conscience. Activist networks overlay kinship networks, which also formed the infrastructure of Rochester’s business community, neighborhoods, and political leadership.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Hewitt, *Women's Activism and Social Change*, 45–46.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.025

# The Transcendentalists and Their World

Robert A. Gross

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Transcendentalists and Their World |
| SELECTION | 9. Freedom of Mind |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages reflowed ebook; no fixed page numbers · Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2021. |

## Excerpt

The Transcendentalist focus on religious sentiment was well suited to a society in transition. For if the core of faith was an ineffable feeling of communion with the divine spirit, knowable only to the individual in the recesses of the soul, then the means of its expression were mere expedients, dependent on time and place. “Everything connected with [religion] is subject to change,” George Ripley instructed the assembly at Brownson’s ordination. All its “forms … may be varied.” The place of worship may be “under the magnificent dome of a cathedral, or on the dreary hill-side with no canopy but the blue vault of Heaven.” The rituals of one church can seem “deficient or superfluous” to another. So too with theology: “the speculative doctrines of religion … may assume new forms and be clothed in new language.” Nothing was fixed but “the indestructible religious sentiment in the human heart … It is the same, today, that it always has been.”

This very fluidity of faith—its multiplicity of forms—was key to the future of religion. For “great changes [were] taking place on every side,” George Ripley observed, “old ideas, old institutions, old habits of thought” giving way to new conceptions “supposed to proceed more directly from reason, and the natural wants of man.” Why cling to an outdated status quo? Nothing in nature was “still.” The “material universe” was ruled by the “law of perpetual change.” Likewise for human affairs: “our experience is diversified by a constant succession of changes.” Under these shifting circumstances, organized religion—the institutions and practices of the Christian churches and of the Unitarians in particular—faced a fundamental challenge. “Will the progress of society … leave religion in the background,” Ripley asked, “and reject it as an outworn and useless thing?”

Not if these Transcendentalist ministers had their way. Their prospectus for change was framed for a democratic age. Religion, in this view, did not belong to the few; it was neither the property of priests nor the prerogative of an elect. The sentiment of faith inhered in every person, at once the foundation of human dignity and the spur to a virtuous life. It was thus crucial to awaken each individual to the divine potential within.

Brownson, the child of the laboring class, was acutely aware of the inequalities in American life and determined to overcome them in the name of faith. “The means of moral and intellectual growth, so far as society can furnish them,” he wrote in the Christian Examiner, “should be within the reach of the humblest as well as the proudest member of the community.” Free public education, overseen by an “aristocracy of real virtue,” was indispensable to this end. With those “who best represent the spirit of Jesus” at the helm, “there would be no subordination of classes, no exclusive privileges, no monopoly of social advantages.” All individuals would then exercise the opportunity to realize their highest selves. And in the process, government and society would embrace a “higher and purer principle of action.” For “all social reforms must be the effect of individual reform.” To encourage such personal transformation became the grand mission of the Transcendentalist clergy, Emerson included.

The stirring of Transcendentalism quickened the currents of dissent in the Boston area. As the Standing Order was coming to an end, the bustling capital presented an unprecedented spectacle of religious pluralism. In 1833 over fifty congregations and chapels served some sixty thousand residents. While orthodox and liberal Congregationalists fought for control of a dying establishment, a variety of other Protestant faiths—Baptists, Methodists, Episcopalians, Quakers, and Universalists—took advantage of the disarray and found opportunities for growth among those who were disaffected from the mainline churches or flocking into the city from the countryside. Heterodoxy flourished. A Church of the New Jerusalem, founded on the teachings of the Swedish mystic Emanuel Swedenborg, promised to

reveal the hidden spiritual meanings behind all living things—a doctrine with passing appeal to Emerson and other Transcendentalists. Also claiming a place in the City upon a Hill were two Roman Catholic houses of worship, serving a fast-growing population, overwhelmingly Irish immigrants, that would reach twenty thousand by 1835.

A large body of citizens was unchurched, often by preference. Radical ideas were circulating in the Boston area during the early 1830s, as a Workingmen's Party organized to protest harsh conditions of labor and inequalities of wealth and power in the industrializing economy. It denounced the capitalist class as furiously as the Anti-Masons assailed the secretive fraternity. The iconoclasm extended to religion. In 1830 an irreverent activist named Abner Kneeland (1774–1844) launched the Boston Investigator to foster "universal mental liberty" and to support the political program of Andrew Jackson. Once a Baptist layman and then a Universalist minister, the editor was now a freethinker who devoted himself to mocking the beliefs of faithful Christians and attacking the clergy for upholding an unjust social order. Twice a week he held forth to a Society of Free Enquirers with a thoroughgoing materialism that deemed the New Testament's account of Jesus's virgin birth, miracles, and resurrection to be utterly absurd. The "Temple of Reason" also hosted weekly dancing parties at which young men and women cultivated the "social affections." Adding to the scandal caused by the promiscuous assemblies was the open sale of a frank guide to birth control and sexuality, Fruits of Philosophy, written by a Massachusetts doctor named Charles Knowlton. Such concentration on physical existence, with no hint of religious sentiment, was antithetical to idealists like Emerson. "To be without God in the world," he reflected in April 1834, was to endure a "terrible solitude," void of hope and meaning. Yet Kneeland's convictions could easily be confused with Transcendentalism. "I believe that the whole universe is nature," the editor told readers, "and that God and Nature are perfectly synonymous terms."

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.026

# American Reformers, 1815-1860

Ronald G. Walters

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|---|---|
| WORK | American Reformers, 1815-1860 |
| SELECTION | American Reformers |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 28–29 · Hill and Wang, 1997. |

## Excerpt

The significance of perfectionism here is not the forms it took aggrandizement and heresy, it was also an energizing principle, inspiring people who wanted to impose absolute moral integrity upon their own lives and upon a changing world. Perfectionism helped creinsisted anything short of millennial standards should not be tolerated.

Evangelicalism was a religion of the heart, not the head. It asserted that salvation was an internal conviction, an experience, not something arrived at through study and contemplation. Theodore Dwight phrased it well when sympathizing with a friend who was puzzling his way through "mere intellectual theories of religion." Weld's advice was for the man to give up, turn "to direct communion with God," and bring his "spirit simply and utterly in contact with infinite purity and love." Weld was not repudiating intellectual activity, in the manner of some twentieth-century revivalists, but he was calling for a religion of emotion rather than dogma. That evangelical faith in the heart was extremely significant. Like Finney's disinterested benevolence and perfectionism, it belonged to was a proclamation that everyone, not just professors of divinity, could anything put forth by Jacksonian politicians. In common with much feeling and intuition. Of singular importance for reform was the antithe clergy, might be judged and found wanting by the true believer.

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**Shortened citation:**

Walters, *American Reformers, 1815-1860*, 28–29.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.027

# Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England

Teresa Anne Murphy

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England |
| SELECTION | Ten Hours Labor |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 176–177 · Cornell University Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

In Lynn the radical reform impulse moved about as far beyond institutional churches as it would go in any town in the nation. In a variety of forms, come-outerism structured reform activity in Lynn and marginalized clergy who might have otherwise participated in that town's reform activity. This may account for the lack of discussion about issues of religion or salvation in Lynn.[28]

Where such discussion did occur, however, the line between religious aspiration and economic activity was purposely blurred. Narratives focused less on the triumphs of salvation than on the physical and economic constraints of salvihc progress, less on the spiritual independence of true believers than on their dependence on workplace conditions. If evangelical religion encouraged working people to become agents of their own destiny, that agency now became problematized, as the cyclical and performative nature of religious conversion narratives was transformed into an instrumental language of change. A similar transformation was apparent in the adaptation of Washingtonianism.

As working people tried to establish an image of moral assertiveness in a morally degraded atmosphere, Washingtonianism would provide them with a model equally as important as religion. And just as religious leaders had provided support, so would Washingtonian speakers.

1844, and many of the leading Washingtonians supported the ten-hour men in the pages of The All Sorts. As The Mechanic would claim in trumpeting this support, "the Ten Hour men are Washingtonians in principle/ [29] Leaders among the Lynn Washingtonians were also leaders among the cordwainers and the tenhour advocates. When David Pierce came from Fall River to offer support to the journeymen of Lynn in their labor struggles, he was also dragged by William Fraser to Mechanics Hall to address the Washingtonian Society. While the impact of institutional religion in Lynn was limited, that of temperance reform was not.[30]

The ideal Washingtonian was particularly suited to providing a solution to the dilemma of representing a man who could be morally degraded yet virtuous, for both coexisted in the reformed drunk as it might in the reformed worker, at least the reformed male worker. Workingwomen were still bound by expectations of moral purity. But Washingtonianism provided an excellent model for the workingman to assert his moral superiority over the employer. Thus labor reform and Washingtonianism shared a dual strategy of conversion and subversion. Working people and the community at large might be converted by the example and rhetoric of labor activists while the moral authority of mill owners was undermined.

## Author's Notes

28. For a discussion of come-outerism in Lynn, see Lewis Perry, Radical Abolitionism: Anarchy and the Government of God in Antislavery Thought (Ithaca, N.Y., 1973), pp. 97-128.

29. The Mechanic, July 13, 1844.

30. David Pierce's name figured prominently in the Record of the Fall River Washington Total Abstinence Society (Manuscript Collection, First Baptist Church of Fall River).

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**Footnote citation:**

Teresa Anne Murphy, *Ten Hours' Labor: Religion, Reform, and Gender in Early New England* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1992), 176–177.

**Shortened citation:**

Murphy, *Ten Hours' Labor*, 176–177.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.028

# The Burned-over District: The Social and Intellectual History of Enthusiastic Religion in Western New York, 1800-1850

Whitney R. Cross

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Burned-over District: The Social and Intellectual History of Enthusiastic Religion in Western New York, 1800-1850 |
| SELECTION | A Moral Reformation |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 237–238 · Cornell University Press, 1950. |

## Excerpt

“I do love to meet a Yankee girl... especially... west of the Hudson.... She generally speaks what she thinks; nor is she fearful of thinking independently either.... She is less erratic in thought than the mincing prude.... She has none of the low tricks... too fashionable among many young ladies....” Thus spoke an editor far distant from western New York.

Not all Burned-over District folk shared this admiration for Yankee integrity in the fair sex, but ultraists for the most part seem to have sympathized. Women in western New York began with nearly equal rights in the church communion and preached in some sects from the earliest times. They fostered and abetted religious enthusiasm more largely than did men. They branched out in the ultraist period to participate strongly in temperance, abolition, and moral reform. Elizabeth Cady Stanton, Amelia Bloomer, Susan B. Anthony, Antoinette Brown Blackwell, the Grimke sisters, and others soon to lead the women’s rights movement served apprenticeship in the reforms which flourished in western New York. The one-ideaism of the religious zealots, however, kept them from associating feminism with their causes as did the New Englanders, and the female vote, like so many other things the radicals wanted, could be attained only by political action, which blended poorly with religious enthusiasm. Only after the ultraist phase had passed could the women’s rights enterprise take form, and that movement had very little connection with western New York’s religious history.

1848 occurred in a region which had done much to bring its purposes to the point of expression. Delayed though it was, this later crusade owed a great deal to the Burned-over District’s “moral reformation.”

ALL the abhorrence which now falls upon slavery, intemperilance, lewdness and every other species of vice will in due time be gathered into one volume of victorious wrath against sin....

If you love... the forefront of the hottest battle of righteousness... set your faces toward perfect holiness.” This advice of John Humphrey Noyes to William Lloyd Garrison closely paralleled Charles Finney’s to Theodore Weld, that he subordinate abolitionism to revivalism, and both indicate the superior logic of perfectionism over moral reform. For in exerting their zeal upon some single evil the reformers allowed their thoughts to be warped away from the comprehensive piety of their ultraist origin. Saner, more consistent minds persisted in seeking a progressively more intensive and more nearly absolute righteousness through spiritual regeneration. Perfectionism was the highroad out of ultraism. That some of the more spectacular experiments in Burned-over District history occurred along its route does not prove that its exponents were irrational fanatics but rather demonstrates their superior ability to carry originally questionable assumptions to thoroughly appropriate conclusions.

## Chicago Citations

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Cross, Whitney R. *The Burned-over District: The Social and Intellectual History of Enthusiastic Religion in Western New York, 1800-1850*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1950.

**Footnote citation:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Cross, *The Burned-over District*, 237–238.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.029

# The Alcoholic Republic: An American Tradition

W. J. Rorabaugh

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Alcoholic Republic: An American Tradition |
| SELECTION | The Pursuit of Happiness |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 176-177 · Oxford University Press, 1979. |

## Excerpt

In these countries the popularity of distilled spirits at particular times signified high aspirations combined with low motivation for achievement. Motivation was low because these were traditional societies. High aspirations, however, could lead to changes that would raise motivation, and high motivation, as social psychologist David McClelland has stated, is an indicator of future economic growth. I would hypothesize that when industrial expansion begins, motivation to succeed is necessarily low, rooted in peasant values that stress the virtue and safety of tradition. As economic development leads to success in meeting targets, confidence in the ability to attain goals grows. This increase in motivation, combined with a narrowing of the gap between aspirations and achievement, reduces anxieties, at least for those social and economic classes that achieve success. Consequently, many people who have drunk distilled spirits become abstainers. After 1825, when the United States enjoyed accelerating economic growth, the temperance movement flourished, particularly among the middle classes that were the principal beneficiaries of prosperity. Similar developments can be observed in the industrialization of Great Britain and Scandinavia. It might also be noted that in the United States after 1840, as factory workers whose dead-end jobs discouraged both motivation and aspirations became more numerous, the consumption of beer increased.[36]

## Author's Notes

36. David C. McClelland, *The Achieving Society* (Princeton, 1961). See chapter 3, note 40, and appendix 2.

## Chicago Citations

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**Footnote citation:**

W. J. Rorabaugh, *The Alcoholic Republic: An American Tradition* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1979), 176-177.

**Shortened citation:**

Rorabaugh, *The Alcoholic Republic*, 176-177.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.030

# The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846

Charles Sellers

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Market Revolution: Jacksonian America, 1815-1846 |
| SELECTION | Ethos vs. Eros |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 266–268 · Oxford University Press, 1991. |

## Excerpt

Teetotalers took over the ATS in 1836 and, with Lyman Beecher's blessing, reorganized it as the American Temperance Union, requiring a teetotal pledge. By 18 3 9 in New York state, a majority of the doctors and 8 5 percent of the ministers were claimed as subscribers.

With Moderate Light mobilizing millennial teetotalism against Demon Rum, demands for legal prohibition spread from lower New England. Campaigns against tavern licenses realigned Massachusetts politics in the thirties, escalating from towns to force election of county commissioners and culminating briefly in statewide prohibition. Taverns were driven by 1835 from all six southeastern counties and numerous towns in the other eight. The reformers' class bias became all too transparent when the 1838 legislature prohibited alcohol sales under fifteen gallons. Popular rebellion promptly empowered the hitherto feckless Democrats to repeal the obnoxious act, and statewide prohibition was temporarily discredited.

Yet teetotalism continued to spread with middle-class cultural transformation. Prohibitionism, falling back to local option in the forties to build a broader base for statewide purification, drove taverns from most of Massachusetts and expanded through Moderate-Light territory from Maine to the shores of Lake Michigan. Once Maine enacted total statewide prohibition in 1851, "Maine laws" swept the North. Within five years every free state restricted alcohol, and most adopted total prohibition. But estimated annual consumption of absolute alcohol (per American over fourteen) had already reached its nineteenth-century nadir, falling from 7. i gallons in 1830 to i.8in 1845. Legal repression barely held the ground largely won by collective repression.36

As Moderate-Light teetotalism brought Kulturkampf to climax on countless local battlegrounds across the North, the struggle over prohibition politicized a deeper struggle of class and culture. Competitive necessity, reinforcing the economic and cultural pressures of a driven bourgeoisie, propelled many workers and farmers into middle-class mythology and collective repression. Pious employers banned drinking and hired only the sober. Churchgoing business elites rewarded churchgoing, teetotaling mechanics, clerks, and shopkeepers with the patronage that made success possible—advice, recommendation, contracts, customers, above all credit and capital. The churches became gatekeepers of opportunity, and the teetotal pledge a badge of deserving middle-class respectability.

Middle-class mythology powerfully reinforced economic imperatives—but more by phobic denigration of failure than by fable of success. The poor man got "little pity in his poverty" because businessmen demanding total effort from self and workers equated poverty with depravity. The psychodynamics of self-making self-discipline embittered bourgeois/middle-class resentment of traditional easygoing ways and instinctual freedom to sharpen demands for labor discipline. As never before the poor were stigmatized as lazy and vicious.

Moral indictment of the poor linked temperance reform with reform of poor relief in a wider collective repression that shamed a traditional folk into capitalist effort. Benevolence ought "not to bestow alms, but labour," said New York merchant/reformer John Pintard, "so that there shall be no pretext for idleness." By making poor relief contingent on collective repression, his pioneering Society for the Prevention of Pauperism in the City of New York sought "to expel the drones from society."

Welfare reform consigned paupers to society's ultimate degradation short of slavery, the local workhouse or poor farm. Benevolent morality made these institutions as grimly penal as possible, and inmates' cadavers were donated to medical schools. Ascribing opprobrious poverty mainly to alcohol, Lynn's teetotaling physicians refused to treat any family headed by a drinker. Widely experienced shame and disgrace, like that of Prophet Joseph Smith's clan, made collective repression a compelling alternative.37

The religious motivation and sincere benevolence of the vast missionary/ benevolent enterprise and its bourgeois leadership can hardly be gainsaid. Neither, however, can their repressive cultural imperialism. Mobilized spiritually for selfrepressive effort, Christian businessmen lavished market-frustrated human altruism on bringing to others the middle-class salvation of collective repression. Class needs for work discipline, social order, and cultural hegemony concentrated Moderate-Light altruism on temperance reform. Teetotalism blazed highest in manufacturing centers.

Antinomian democracy and the Old Adam resisted. At first only the most striving sector of the old working class, especially mechanic/manufacturers, embraced middle-class myth and ethic, some through indigenous working-class Methodism, some under middle-class Presbygational patronage. Collective repression did not penetrate the working class deeply, especially in the cities, until another downturn of the capitalist cycle in 1837 created mass desperation. The working-class Washingtonian movement, by contrast with middle-class temperance, organized drinkers fraternally to conquer addiction in the confessional style of Alcoholics Anonymous. Penetrating resistant classes, the temperance crusade was the public face of a pervasive new form of class domination. Through pious benevolence, bourgeois needs energized collective repression to shape a middle-class society.

The class/cultural dynamics of capitalist transformation centered in Arthur and Lewis Tappan, merchant-prince patrons of revivals, Bibles, tracts, free churches, purity, Grahamism, teetotalism, and abolition. To infuse business with Christian morality, they founded not only the New York Journal of Commerce but also the first national credit-rating agency, now Dun and Bradstreet, Inc. Recruiting local credit investigators from the Benevolent Empire's clerics and reformers, their Mercantile Agency evaluated individual creditworthiness for New York wholesalers and lenders.

In awarding opportunity, American capitalism's Moderate-Light gatekeepers looked beyond birth, net worth, and liquidity to "character." Credit was denied "a rich man's son who ... never was educated to economy" while recommended for "industrious young men, formerly clerks," the "careful small businessman," the man of "small capital, good character."

In certifying good character, the Tappans' credit reporters especially scrutinized the instinctual danger zones, alcohol and sexuality. Ambitions were routinely frustrated by such notations as "intemperate habits," "likes to drink too much," "leads a sporting life." Lenders were warned against all who "run after the women" or "got mixed up with a bad woman." Therefore marriage was essential to good credit—a young venturer "has been pretty wild but has recently married and will probably be more steady now." But even marriage had its career hazards, for in this era of erotic repression and demographic transition a "large and expensive family" or "too many little Dutchmen" impaired credit.39

The Moderate-Light benevolence that wrenched Old Adam into capitalist discipline is seen by liberal historiography as a great upsurge of humane "reform" seeking with boundless optimism to eradicate all human ills. Yet the only true reformers, insisted Finney himself, were those "honestly endeavoring to reform mankind" by "denying their appetites." By mystifying the relations of class, power, and culture, our historical mythology of consensual capitalism renders incomprehensible the massive resistance that rallied around Andrew Jackson. While collective repression pushed bourgeois hegemony across the North, antinomian democracy—and racist slavery—empowered the patriarchal Hero of New Orleans to bring Kulturkampf to a showdown in national politics.

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**Shortened citation:**

Sellers, *The Market Revolution*, 266–268.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.031

# Pillars of the Republic: Common Schools and American Society, 1780-1860

Carl F. Kaestle

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Pillars of the Republic: Common Schools and American Society, 1780-1860 |
| SELECTION | / Pillars of the Republic |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 78–79 · Hill and Wang, 1983. |

## Excerpt

Native Protestant localists shared many ideological perspectives with native Protestant cosmopolitans, but they believed that cosmopolitan reformers had wrongly interpreted the ideology's very first proposition. The sacredness and fragility of republican government required local control and participation in institutions, above all else. A thoroughgoing delineation of variants of native Protestant ideology in nineteenth-century America would also identify a Southern slaveholding variant and possibly—though the evidence is still shrouded—one or more working-class variants.

Arguments about the relationship between ideology and class cannot be conclusive at our present state of knowledge. Did the social beliefs shared by Horace Mann, Henry Barnard, John Pierce, and William Seward constitute a class ideology? The fact that most writers on educational and moral reform were themselves middleclass does not necessarily make it a middle-class ideology. But class." Protestant revivalism and reform activities had a bourgeois character. Religion, reform, and education provided pious activities and sometimes careers for young middle-class males and females. The adoption of such values and participation in such class family and in the embourgeoisement of some middle-level workers such as clerks, foremen, and teachers. Furthermore, many literature, or the derogatory attitudes toward poor workers and immigrants in schoolbooks, newspaper commentary, and sermons.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Kaestle, *Pillars of the Republic*, 78–79.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.032

# City of Women: Sex and Class in New York, 1789–1860

Christine Stansell

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | City of Women: Sex and Class in New York, 1789–1860 |
| SELECTION | City of Women, pp. 218-220 |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 219–220 · Alfred A. Knopf, 1986. |

## Excerpt

As gender identity became a contested issue in conflicts of class, reform ers drew part of their own sense of mission from combatting this expansion of working-class female culture. Especially on the streets, both the sexual culture of daughters and the domestic culture of mothers were antithetical to the terms of home life and womanhood developed and championed by urban ladies. Sympathy for their working-class sisters and a rudimentary perception of the debilities they shared with them did motivate female charity workers and reformers. Ultimately, however, the bonds of woman hood depended on notions of "true" gender identity based on a particular class experience, and sympathy for the "virtuous" working-class woman- she who conformed to the ladies' standards-was conferred at the expense of all the "vicious" who did not. The vision of universal sisterhood elevated bourgeois women and their imitators above misogynist ideology, but left unchallenged-indeed perpetuated-misogynist views of the mass of working-class women.

The idea of sisterhood was thus inextricable from the ascendancy of the bourgeoisie in New York to cultural and political dominance. By the r85os, the reform of the working-class gender system had become a pro grammatic goal of many municipal leaders. A movement largely dominated by men institutionalized domesticity into laws which sought to enforce genteel family practices among working-class people, laws that implicitly sought to transform the character of working-class womanhood into one resembling more closely the female identity that the cult of domesticity celebrated.

The 1850s set the terms of both female struggles and female accommoda tions across class lines for the next half century. In the new school attend ance law and the work of the CAS female volunteers lay the roots of the Americanization campaign which at the end of the century reshaped the lives of so many working-class immigrants to New York. Then, the settle ment houses and public schools were to expand the antebellum mothers' classes and girls' housekeeping lessons into a vast program of nativist assimi lation as well as female self-help. Women social workers and teachers, many of them inspired by feminist impulses to help their poorer sisters, would assure immigrant mothers and daughters that the key to decent lives lay in creating American homes within the immigrant neighborhoods-homes that aspired to a particular bourgeois configuration of possessions, housekeeping practices and family relations. As in the 1850s, the effort to domesticate the plebeian household would be linked in the Progressive era to a campaign to eradicate a ubiquitous and aggressive working-class culture.

The women's rights movement before the Civil War was too absorbed in middle-class women's dilemmas in marriage, work and property rela tions to learn much from working-class women. Only in the 1870s did Susan Anthony begin to turn away from abstract, sentimentalist images of workingwomen popular in her social milieu to begin learning about the concrete debilities of working-class women's lives. Even then, Anthony mostly had to do the investigating for herself; working-class women still lacked a collective language in which to articulate publicly their particular griev ances. Male-dominated trade unions, increasingly committed to the family wage, provided few ways for women to express either the troubles they endured or the desires they might conceive in the social terrain outside the male-headed family. Even the Knights of Labor, which actively sought out women's participation, did so under the beacon of a higher working-class domesticity, to be achieved when (male) workers finally earned the full value of

their labor. The family wage-and the ideology of gender that encompassed it-served well enough for women attached to men. For them, it meant a liberation from the double shift of wage earning superim posed on household work. And certainly when the labor movement at its most radical mobilized entire communities-as in the great railroad strike of 1877, the eight-hour day strikes of 1886 and the IWW strikes of the early twentieth century-it incorporated many concerns of wives and mothers.

Nonetheless, what Sally Alexander has written of the Chartist women in England in the 1830s and 1840s was also true of the militant wives in the small Ohio railroad towns on strike in 1877, the German women who cheered the May Day demonstrators in Chicago, 1886 and the Italian mill worker mothers who marched for bread and roses in Lawrence, 1912: "Women could only speak as active subjects at selective moments, and within the community." The language of feminism subsumed working class women's experience into categories of victimization, and the language of class struggle blurred the particularities of their lives into the unified interests of the working-class family.

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Stansell, *City of Women*, 219–220.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.033

# Their Brothers' Keepers: Moral Stewardship in the United States, 1800-1865

Clifford S. Griffin

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Their Brothers' Keepers: Moral Stewardship in the United States, 1800-1865 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages -5—4 · Rutgers University Press, 1960. |

## Excerpt

The trustees of the early nineteenth century were heirs of the stewardship tradition of the Calvinistic past. John Calvin's colonial disciples had stressed that the Elect of God should regulate their neighbors' lives by moral suasion and political action. Where Calvinists were in complete control, the result was theocracies in which morality laws buttressed the religious code. Calvinists everywhere bequeathed to their descendants the necessity of making other men good. Yet seventeenth- and eighteenth-century trustees faced sin on only a local scale. Their heirs in the new nation looked beyond state borders and found that problems formerly small and parochial were now stupendous and national. With the United States Constitution and local political conditions making impossible the continuance of the theocracies, the trustees of the Lord had to devise modern means to make people obey their will.

Their new means of control was national societies. Laymen and clergymen of several Protestant denominations, but most of them Presbyterians and Congregationalists, formed the American Education Society to subsidize poor ministerial students, and the American Home Missionary Society to subsidize indigent pastors to preach the Protestant gospel and Protestant morality. They began the American Bible Society to publish and circulate Holy Writ, the American Sunday School Union to issue religious and moral works for children, and the American Tract Society to guide adults. To end wars, liquor drinking, and slavery, they founded the American Peace Society, the American Society for the Promotion of Temperance, and the American Antislavery Society.

God's stewards thus announced to sinners that great national evils had called forth great national means to righteousness; thus did the heirs of the trustee tradition make plain that they intended to preserve their inheritance and transmit it to their descendants.

In laboring to make men behave, the stewards claimed that they were being benevolent. Benevolence in its simplest form was following the Golden Rule of the Bible and loving one's neighbor as one's self. But in the nineteenth century hundreds of lay and ecclesiastical theologians gave a new emphasis to the notion of doing unto others as one would have others do to him. The trustees argued that God wished all men to obey His laws as the stewards interpreted them. Since God's grace was the greatest gift any man could receive, the conservators of trusteeship asserted that the kindest thing they could do for others was to make them forswear sin and thus put them in a position to win everlasting life. Benevolence was an infinite concern for other men's souls and other men's deeds. And at the same time it was an instrument for molding the country to conform to God's— and the stewards'—ideas.

The leaders of the benevolent groups had personal reasons for wishing to control society. Although many of the officers were pastors of the more important churches in New York, Philadelphia, and Boston, the majority were wealthy men and men becoming wealthy through business, finance, and the law. The trustees believed that they would suffer if men playing lesser roles on the great American stage did not respect their economic and social obligations, and if American voters did not choose proper men as rulers. Religion and morality, as dispensed by the benevolent societies throughout the seemingly chaotic nation, became a means of establishing secular order.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Griffin, *Their Brothers' Keepers*, -5–-4.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.034

# The Discovery of the Asylum: Social Order and Disorder in the New Republic

David J. Rothman

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Discovery of the Asylum: Social Order and Disorder in the New Republic |
| SELECTION | Introduction to the 1990 Edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · Little, Brown, 1971. |

## Excerpt

The interpretations that locate the origins o f the asylum in aprofound uneasiness about the fragility o f the social order are often joined under the rubric ofa school o f social control. That they do share similarities o f outlook is indisputable — one need only note the repetition o f such words as social order, disorder, regulation, and discipline i n their titles and subtitles. Nevertheless, the social control label is an ill-suited one, obfuscating more than it clarifies and oversimplifying a complex historical analysis.

The term "social control" had its origins in sociology in the 1920s and 1930s, i n the writings ofmen like George Herbert Mead and E. A. Ross. They invoked it in order to promote a sharper appreciation o f the role o f subjective and qualitative values inbinding social groups together. Rather than assuming that the good order o f the society rested on the regulatory au thority or police power o f the state, they sought to connect it to commonly held values and principles, to make social order the result not o f fiat and force but o f ideas and sympathy. Accord ingly, the institutions o f social control that concerned them were not the police or the army but the family, the church, and the school. I n fact, they searched so broadly for the agents that instilled social harmony that they made social control indistin guishable from socialization. Convinced that Americain the opening decades o f the twentieth century exemplified an or dered society and that Americans shared a value system that bound everyone together (think, for example, o f the implica tions o f the metaphor o f the melting pot), they found social control everywhere and applauded its exercise.

Not until the post—World War II period did the term change, and actually reverse its meaning. Sociologists like RichardCloward and Francis Piven and left-leaning Marxist scholars made it synonymous not with persuasion but with imposition o f state or class authority over the lower classes. Social control was equated with repression and coercion, with the formal and in formal mechanisms intended to obscure realities (generally de fined as evidence o f class repression) and, that effort failing, to compel order and obedience. It was with this negative connota tion, not with its Progressive roots, that social control came to the attention o f historians.

A t first appearance, the concept served a highly useful pur pose, stimulating a series o f novel questions and serving as a useful corrective to the prevailing idea on "reform." Although "social control" was never clearly defined and one never knew what did or did not come under the rubric, it encouraged a group o f historians to stop taking claims o f benevolence at face value and to start investigating the purposes, benign or not so benign, that a purported reform might fulfill. (That the need for this exercise was not already self-evident testifies to the power within the discipline ofa reformist, or what the English call aWhig, interpretation o f history.) The result was to promote fresh questions about the asylum, and fresh answers as well. Indeed, this new perspective had a liberating effect also on the historians o f the family, o f education, and o f social welfare.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Rothman, *The Discovery of the Asylum*, no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.035

# Women and the Work of Benevolence: Morality, Politics, and Class in the Nineteenth-Century United States

Lori D. Ginzberg

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Women and the Work of Benevolence: Morality, Politics, and Class in the Nineteenth-Century United States |
| SELECTION | ¢ Introduction * |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 2–3 · Yale University Press, 1990. |

## Excerpt

Until very recently, historians who studied early nineteenth-century benevolent activity viewed it as an assertion of social control, an attempt to impose class-specific values on the poor and foreign. They were, however, reluctant to grant much import to women in this effort at cultural domination, except to describe them as "an indispensible source of educated hands to [do] the work."2 Apparently presuming class to be a "male" issue—a category both defined and disputed by males only—historians of the benevolent empire assumed that women played no role in shaping the particular causes which asserted a class identity.

Recent explorations in women's history have transformed the study of antebellum benevolent women. Nancy Cott, Kathryn Kish Sklar, and Carroll Smith-Rosenberg, in their studies of antebellum middle-class women's identities, have underscored both the ambiguities and the richness of the concept of "woman's sphere" and its impact on white middle-class women's self-understanding. By looking at women's own writings, Cott in particular has explicated the tensions between women's subordinate status and the sense of self worth gained from womanhood's "bonds"—the tensions, that is, between the conservative implications of relegating women to a separate sphere and the potentially radical sense of solidarity gained from that experience.[3] Building on these insights, Barbara Berg, Estelle Freedman, and others in their studies of nineteenth-century religion and reform have explored how, through the assertion of a shared female identity, middleclass women sought to transcend class differences between themselves and their less privileged "sisters." Barbara Epstein has illuminated the conflicts that evangelical religion ignited between women and men.[4] Women's historians have thus elucidated both the individual and the societal importance of the ideology of gender. They have at the same time given us a greater understanding of white Protestant women as active participants in nineteenth-century society and as shapers of benevolence itself. We still know little about why the ideology of "woman's sphere" emerged when it did and what large cultural implications it had, but we do know that many middle-class Protestant women incorporated its tenets into their own self image, that they used it to justify a wide range of social activities, and that it provided at least some basis for a consciousness based on the shared experience of being women.[5]

## Author's Notes

3. Carroll Smith-Rosenberg, "Beauty, the Beast, and the Militant Woman: A Case Study of Sex Roles and Social Stress in Jacksonian America," American Quarterly 23 (October 1971): 562—84, and "The Female World of Love and Ritual: Relations between Women in Nineteenth-Century America," Signs 1 (Fall 1975): 1-29; Nancy F. Cott, The Bonds of Womanhood: "Woman's Sphere" in New England, 1780—1835 (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1977); Kathryn Kish Sklar, Catharine Beecher: A Study in American Domesticity (New York: W. W. Norton, 1976).

4. Barbara J. Berg, The Remembered Gate: Origins of American Feminism: The Woman and the City, rt800—1860 (New York: Oxford University Press, 1978); Estelle B. Freedman, Their Sisters' Keepers: Women's Prison Reform in America, 1830-1930 (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1981); Barbara Leslie Epstein, The Politics of Domesticity: Women, Evangelism, and Temperance in Nineteenth-Century America (Middletown, Conn.: Wesleyan University Press, 1981). See also Mary P. Ryan, "A Women's Awakening: Evangelical Religion and the Families of Utica, N.Y., 1800-1840," in Women and American Religion, ed. Janet Wilson

James (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1980), pp. 89—110.

5. I frame the words "woman's sphere" in quotation marks intentionally. The concept of "spheres" is, after all, ideological, although it has too often come to represent historians' understanding of the actual experience of at least white middle-class Protestant women. What I have found in my work is that the reality of women's lives was quite different from the ideology which they themselves used and that, furthermore, the acceptance of the tenets of woman's sphere by historians has too often served to obscure that distinction, unwittingly preventing women from leaving the sphere itself. Several recent articles have grappled with these questions on a theoretical basis. Although several appeared after I had almost finished writing this book, they have helped me locate my own thinking in the changing historiography on women. See especially Nancy A. Hewitt, "Beyond the Search for Sisterhood: American Women's History in the 1980s," Social History 10 (October 1985): 299-321; Linda K. Kerber, "Separate Spheres, Female Worlds, Woman's Place: The Rhetoric of Women's History," Journal of

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Ginzberg, *Women and the Work of Benevolence*, 2–3.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.036

# A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837

Paul E. Johnson

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|---|---|
| WORK | A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837 |
| SELECTION | Introduction |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 5–6 · Hill and Wang, 1978. |

## Excerpt

Beecher based his statement not only on the number of conversions but on a profound change in what conversion meant. For the revival of 1831, more than any other event, marked the acceptance of an activist and millennialist evangelicalism as the faith of the northern middle class. New England revivals in the first quarter of the century had been quiet, decorous affairs, presided over by settled ministers who wanted only to reinstate conformity to God's laws among God's people. (In a world where God alone determined who was saved, mass evangelism was useless and vaguely blasphemous.) Lyman Beecher, when he heard that Charles Finney and other New Yorkers had devised ways of "getting up" revivals, promised to call out the militia if they brought their heresy into New England. But in 1831, with the revival exploding all around him, he invited Finney into his own Boston church.* Within a few years free agency, perfectionism, and millennialism were middle-class orthodoxy.

They were powerful ideas, and in the 1830s they underlay a missionary crusade that transformed society and politics in the United States. It was Gilbert Barnes, a historian of the antislavery movement writing in the 1930s, who "discovered" the revival of 1831.

1830s, critics of slavery rejected gradualist techniques, recruited thousands of new supporters, and attacked the South's peculiar institution as a national evil that demanded immediate abolition. He analyzed the rhetoric and tactics of the movement and the sources of its support, and argued convincingly that antislavery immediatism was a direct outgrowth of the revival of 1830-31.°

Since then, Barnes's discovery has been extended to the whole array of antebellum reform. The temperance, moral reform, and missionary societies of the 1820s had been organizations of gentlemen who wished to slow the course of social and political change and reinforce their domination over a hopelessly godless multitude. In the early 1830s newly converted evangelicals invaded all of these organizations and took most of them over. The new reformers did not want to control the inevitable excesses of drunkards and prostitutes and Jacksonian Democrats. They wanted to liberate them from their sins. Through individual conversion and public example, and increasingly through mass politics and outright coercion, they promised to eliminate sin from society and pave the way for the Second Coming. The same millennial hopes guided a dramatic increase in home missions, and they shaped the beginnings of organized anti-Catholicism in this country.®

The reform societies are parts of an accessible and public history, and we have known about religious influences within them for a long time. More recently, scholars have begun the systematic study of everyday social life, and again they are confronting the evangelicals and their works. The 1820s witnessed the beginnings of large-scale manufacturing in American cities, and with it came attempts to subject farm boys and preindustrial artisans to the discipline and monotony of modern work. Historians of labor are finding that in the 1830s proto-industrialists fought that battle with religious weapons. Their most favored means of combating drunkenness, spontaneous holidays, and inattention to work were the temperance society, the Sunday school, and the revival. Indeed many masters and manufacturers saw industrialization as a civilizing mission: they believed in their hearts that in proletarianizing workmen they were rescuing them from barbarism and granting them the benefits of Christian discipline. The workingmen, of course, saw things differently, and the crucial first generation of industrial conflict in

this country was fought largely along religious lines.'

## Chicago Citations

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Paul E. Johnson, *A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837* (New York: Hill and Wang, 1978), 5–6.

**Shortened citation:**

Johnson, *A Shopkeeper's Millennium*, 5–6.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.037

# Pillars of the Republic: Common Schools and American Society, 1780-1860

Carl F. Kaestle

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Pillars of the Republic: Common Schools and American Society, 1780-1860 |
| SELECTION | Ideology / |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 101–102 · Hill and Wang, 1983. |

## Excerpt

The coherence of native Protestant ideology gave it much persuasive force. If you assented to one or more of the proposithat you should believe in the subordination of women. Conversely, if you assaulted one of the beliefs, you could be portrayed as dependent; thus, if you attacked the unequal distribution of property, you could be portrayed, according to the ideology, as opposing the whole system. This rhetorical strategy—generalizing opponents' specific proposals into an assault on the social system can be seen in educational arguments. When some people proposed \ removing the Bible from classrooms in Wisconsin in 1858, the corporated in the law of the land." To remove the Bible from the schools would endanger "all we now hold dear and sacred: / our homes, our country, Christianity and the Bible." Historians have previously noted many overlapping articles of native Protestant social thought, but it is worth noting here again the tight web of cross-references and logical connections made by antebellum social commentators. They demonstrate the coherence of the ideology and help explain its potency. There were logical tensions and contradictions in the ideology—for example between racism and a belief in human perfectibility, or between domesticity and equal opportunity—but rhetorically each proposition was taken to be mutually reinforcing and completely compatible with the others. This is one aspect of ideology as simplification. While a culture as a whole may embody many paradoxes and contradictions, articulated ideology is a particular reflection of culture, a didactic and programmatic set of propositions used to defend institutions or reform; as such, articulated ideology tends to mute contradictions and stress coherence.

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**Footnote citation:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Kaestle, *Pillars of the Republic*, 101–102.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.038

# A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837

Paul E. Johnson

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | A Shopkeeper's Millennium: Society and Revivals in Rochester, New York, 1815-1837 |
| SELECTION | Impasse |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 4–5 · Hill and Wang, 1978. |

## Excerpt

N EITHER spontaneous controls nor a faction-ridden village government could tame the workingmen and drifters who filled Rochester in the 1820s. In their own streets and neighborhoods, dissolute men did what they pleased, and anxious merchants and masters had no means of stopping them. Some rich men sensed that they had the power to coerce workmen into being good. But most were uncomfortable with power, and tried to quiet society through a moral authority that had lost its basis in everyday experience. Arguments between advocates of power and advocates of authority surfaced periodically among the village trustees. The argument widened into an open fight in 1828, as Rochester's weakened elite tried new ways of fighting social evil.

In 1828, worried gentlemen formed the Rochester Society for the Promotion of Temperance, and affiliated with a national movement led by Lyman Beecher of Boston. These men proposed to end drunkenness through persuasion, example, and the weight of their names. Every old family and every church submerged their differences and contributed leaders to the society. Colonel Rochester himself, along with his son-inlaw Jonothan Child, represented the Rochester clan and the Episcopal Church. They were joined by their old enemies Matthew Brown and Levi Ward, and by Ward's son-in-law Moses Chapin. The Presbyterian, Baptist, and Methodist ministers were among the founders. So, temporarily, was Father McNamara of the Catholic chapel.' The Observer scanned the names and concluded that "'when we see that they are the most respectable, wealthy, moral, and influential individuals in society, we feel confident that this reformation will not cease but with the extermination of intemperance from our land."

The temperance reformers were wealthy men, and they possessed enormous power. But they preferred to translate power into authority, and to reform lesser men by persuasion rather than by force. Lyman Beecher, whose Six Sermons on Intemperance guided the movement from its beginning, defined the goal as "THE BANISHMENT OF ARDENT SPIRITS FROM THE LIST OF LAWFUL ARTICLES OF COMMERCE BY A CORRECT AND EFFICIENT PUBLIC SENTIMENT..." by social pressure and an aroused public opinion.' The society aimed its appeals at wealthy men, for these had always set standards for others. Members of the society gave up even the most moderate use of liquor. They would not buy it, drink it, sell it, manufacture it, or provide it for their guests or employees, and they would use all their influence to encourage others to do the same.* The organization and its methods were based on the touching faith that poor men would drink only "so long as the traffic in liquor is regarded as lawful, and is patronized by men of reputation and moral worth..."* Temperance men did not want to outlaw liquor or to run drunkards and grogsellers out of town. They wanted only to make men ashamed to drink. Reform would come quietly and voluntarily, and it would come from the top down.

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**Shortened citation:**

Johnson, *A Shopkeeper's Millennium*, 4–5.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.039

# American Reformers, 1815-1860

Ronald G. Walters

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | American Reformers, 1815-1860 |
| SELECTION | American Reformers |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 220–221 · Hill and Wang, 1997. |

## Excerpt

Christian anarchists, labor reformers, and African Americans who saw into the heart of injustice and inequality—posed a deep threat to the emerging social, political, and economic order. The chief effect of other crusades—notably temperance, phrenology, and asylumor school-building—was to encourage people to adjust to, rather than resist, the brave new world of the nineteenth century. Most antebellum reformers were, at heart, trying to adapt old and respectable verities, plus a few new ones, to an age of cities, steam power, rowdy politics, and get-rich-quick schemes. To their way of thinking, that did sumed, would ensure that God's (or Nature's) plan would continue to unfold. For them, reform explained what was wrong with individuals and the nation, what might go wrong in the future, and how to avoid it without sacrificing the historic mission of Americans to increase and be prosperous. It is one of the minor tragedies of antebellum reform that few noin the 1850s. By the 1870s they were all but gone. Perhaps the analogy is wrong.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Walters, *American Reformers, 1815-1860*, 220–221.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.040

# The Trials of Anthony Burns: Freedom and Slavery in Emerson's Boston

Albert J. von Frank

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Trials of Anthony Burns: Freedom and Slavery in Emerson's Boston |
| SELECTION | events that converted them. And of course many were converted in |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · Harvard University Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

Free Northern blacks, for their part, were also concerned with "the little lower layer," with matters that did not come and go — not so much with the power of Virginia slaveholders (a point of white fascination), but already with the next evolutionary step, emerging from the quasislavery of their own Northern identity. The progressive separation of black and white abolitionists — or the increasing independence of the former over the decade of the 1850s — is marked by a shift in their attention from the slave's plight to their own, by coming to focus on the continuities between black slavery and white prejudice. One clear indication of this advancing recognition may be seen in the call issued by William J.

Years of well-intended effort have been expended for the especial freedom of the slave, while the elevation of the free colored man as an inseparable priority to the same, has been entirely overlooked. But to every true friend of freedom it must now be too obvious, that the whole process of operation against the huge and diabolical system of oppression and wrong, has been shorn of more than half its strength and efficacy, because of this neglect of the interests of the Free People of Color — interests so vital that we dare not longer permit them to remain in a state of neglect. If nothing else, then, these years of experifree man is inseparable from, and lies at the very threshold of the great work of the slave's restoration to freedom, and equally essential to the highest well-being of our own common country.

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.041

# The Black Image in the White Mind: The Debate on Afro-American Character and Destiny, 1817-1914

George M. Fredrickson

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Black Image in the White Mind: The Debate on Afro-American Character and Destiny, 1817-1914 |
| SELECTION | 1. Prejudice and Reformism: The Colonization Idea and the Abolitionist Response, 1817-1840 |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 28–29 · Wesleyan University Press, 1987. |

## Excerpt

The real issue, however, was not the success or failure of colonization but its basic morality. The abolitionists of the 1830s charged that the colonizationist doctrine of ineradicable prejudice was un-Christian. To rule out the possibility of a racially egalitarian society was, to their way of thinking, a willful and perverse denial of both the Gospel and the Declaration of Independence. The controversy that then erupted in Northern reform circles was not, as is sometimes supposed, a dispute over the inherent capabilities of the Negro; as we have seen, prominent advocates of colonization often shared, in theory at least, the abolitionist belief that American Negro deficiencies were the result of a repressive environment. Rather it was a debate on the separate issue of whether white Americans could be expected to overcome their antipathy to blacks and achieve interracial equality and brotherhood. As "practical" conservatives with a powerful sense of the limitations of reform, the leading colonizationists regarded prejudice as too deeply rooted to be eliminated. The abolitionists, on the other hand, were idealistic Christian reformers who believed that racial antipathy, like other "sinful" human dispositions, could be overcome.

Thoughts on African Colonization, "that the day is coming when even the 'wolf shall dwell with the lamb, and the leopard shall lie down with the kid, and the wolf and the young lion and the fatling together'; and, if this be possible, 1 see no cause why those of the same species—God's rational creatures—fellow countrymen in truth, cannot dwell in harmony together." Garrison went on to affirm that "there is power enough in the religion of Jesus Christ to melt down the most stubborn prejudices, to overthrow the highest walls of partition, to break the strongest caste, to improve and elevate the most degraded, to unite in fellowship the most hostile, and to equalize and bless all its recipients."

## Chicago Citations

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Fredrickson, *The Black Image in the White Mind*, 28–29.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.042

# The Grimké Sisters from South Carolina: Pioneers for Women's Rights and Abolition

Gerda Lerner

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Grimké Sisters from South Carolina: Pioneers for Women's Rights and Abolition |
| SELECTION | The Grimke Sisters |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 200–201 · University of North Carolina Press, 2004. |

## Excerpt

But women, too, were kept away from the cause by their own repressed status, Few women could brave the disapproval of their friends and neighbors in order to take a public stand and actively participate in community affairs. Weld looked on the woman's rights question entirely as something affecting a few outstanding women in leadership positions, but the Grimkés saw the need of mobilizing the vast, untapped reservoir of antislavery sentiment in women and harnessing it to the cause.

As if in support of his "Quaker" argument, Weld enlisted the aid of the Quaker Whittier, a man the sisters greatly respected. Whittier's letter to them linked the issues of war, human government, church and family government as matters that ought to be held "far aloof from the cause of abolition." He attacked Wright and Garrison for tying these causes to abolition. As for the rights of women, the sisters were asserting these rights by their current lectures. "Why then, let me ask, it is necessary for you to enter the lists as controversial writers in this question?:.. Is it not forgetting the great and dreadful wrongs of the slave in a selfish crusade against some paltry grievances of our own?" §7 Weld's next letter was written after he had read the first several of the Letters on the Equality of the Sexes. "Woman, in every particular shares equally with man rights and responsibilities," Weld stated, describing his views on women as "ultra." He believed that qualified women could and should make laws, administer justice, govern — even propose marriage! Yet he deeply regretted that the sisters had started their articles. Writing of this sort was something any woman could do. But in their function as female antislavery speakers they were unique. He asked them to let others do "Brethren beloved in the Lord," Angelina began her reply, addressed jointly to Whittier and Weld, saying that she was writing for both herself and Sarah. She explained how they came to write the articles and insisted that they could see no harm in publishing their views on women in a paper which was not an abolition paper.** It was not these articles which aroused the public on the subject of woman's rights, it was the Pastoral Letter that did the damage. Angelina saw it as an attack on free speech. "This invasion of our rights was just such an attack upon us, as that made upon Abolitionists generally when they were told a few years ago that they had no right to discuss the subject of Slavery." At that time abolitionists did not ignore the attack. "The time to assert a right is the time when that right is denied. "We must establish this right for if we do not, it will be impossible for us to go on with the work of Emancipation." Could they not see that the clergy, in attacking their right to lecture, were trying to prevent people from hearing what they had to say? "If we surrender the right to speak to the public this year, we must surrender the right to petition the next year and the right to write the year after and so on, What then can woman do for the slave when she is herself under the feet of man and shamed into silence?" As for the Quaker argument, Angelina pointed out that their feminism was as different from the Quaker view on women as their abolitionism was from the Quaker variety. Quakers regarded woman "as equal to men on the ground of spiritual gifts, not on the broad ground of humanity. Women may preach: this is a gift; but woman must not make the discipline by which she herself is to be governed." This insight reflected years of practical experience in "Women's Meeting." Neither of the sisters had ff...

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Lerner, *The Grimké Sisters from South Carolina*, 200–201.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.043

# All on Fire: William Lloyd Garrison and the Abolition of Slavery

Henry Mayer

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|---|---|
| WORK | All on Fire: William Lloyd Garrison and the Abolition of Slavery |
| SELECTION | My Soul Was on Fire Then |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 65–66 · St. Martin's Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

Having referred to the sacred phrases of the Declaration of Independence, Garrison drove his point home by asking his listeners to imagine the language that American slaves would use in justifying to the world a rebellion of their own. In the cadences of Jefferson's declaration, Garrison then catalogued a long course of usurpation and tyranny: "They have invaded our territories.... They have wedged us into the holds of their 'floating hells.'... They have sold us in their market-places like cattle... driven us in large droves from State to State, beneath a burning sky.... They have lacerated our bodies with whips.... They would destroy our souls...."

Not only did the slaves possess inherent rights, Garrison insisted; the states had a democratic right to voice the concerns of the nonslaveholding majority in the counsels of the nation. We have "a common interest... as members of one great family... to demand a gradual abolition of slavery," he said. Even if one were to disregard the Golden Rule and "the common dictates of humanity," Garrison reasoned, the free states had a stake in the matter "because by [slavery's] continuance, they participate in the guilt thereof, and are threatened with ultimate destruction."

There were also sectional political concerns. New England Federalists had complained for years about the Southern weight in national politics, owing to the extra representation granted to slaveholders by the three-fifths clause in the U.S. Constitution, but Garrison gave the congregation a fresh lesson in political arithmetic. Though the free states had a population twice as large as the slave states, they wielded only twenty-two percent more of the electoral vote and had to suffer the "anti-republican" absurdity of slaveholders reducing men to property while claiming that they should be counted as constituents. The "price of Union," Garrison said bluntly, was too high if it silenced the voice of an "overwhelming majority" and required tacit approval of a soul-destroying evil.

Yet the abolition of slavery had to be a moral endeavor before it could be a political one. Only an aroused public conscience could persuade legislators to withdraw protection from slavery, the speaker contended, and he admonished the evangelically minded congregation that Christians could not, in fairness, strive to liberate other lands from darkness and superstition, yet make no impression upon the laws at home. Agitation would inevitably be noisy and disruptive, he acknowledged, but slavery could not be abolished without a collision "full of sharp asperities and bitterness" that would confront "the worst passions of human nature." The conflict, furthermore, would have to begin in their own communities, for "the prejudices of the north are stronger than those of the south; they bristle, like so many bayonets, around the slaves...." substitution. "Suppose that... the slaves should suddenly become white," he bade the silent hall.

"No," he roared, "your voice would peal in the ears of the taskmasters like deep thunder." Boston would rock more violently than it had during the revolt against Great Britain, the pulpits would shake with holy zeal, and the charge that such white slaves are "degraded" or "inferior," and therefore undeserving of freedom, would be dismissed outright.

This startling confrontation with racial bias brought Garrison to his final thesis: the equal citizenship of black and white. He condemned as a "pitiful subterfuge" the common argument that slavery had incapacitated black people for freedom and would thus make their liberation a curse rather than a blessing. He also condemned the racist corollary,

advanced most prominently by Thomas Jefferson in Notes on the State of Virginia, that differences of color, as well as capacity, loomed as powerful obstacles to emancipation and an egalitarian society. Look at the achievements of Carthage in ancient days and Haiti today (and perhaps the infant colony at Liberia, Garrison said, in his only, passing reference to the colonization scheme) to see what free black citizens might accomplish. If slavery had reduced black men and women to "a level with the brutes, is it a valid argument to say that therefore they must remain brutes?" Freedom and education would be the proper remedies to "elevate them to a proper rank in the scale of being," he said, though it would be "a wild vision" to think that such could happen overnight. Emancipation would have to come gradually, but it had to begin at once. "Our choice is simply between virtuous and quiet freemen and desperate and degraded slaves," he said, and asked, "Whose society is the more preferable?"

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**Footnote citation:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Mayer, *All on Fire*, 65–66.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.044

# Holy Warriors: The Abolitionists and American Slavery

James Brewer Stewart

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|---|---|
| WORK | Holy Warriors: The Abolitionists and American Slavery |
| SELECTION | J Holy Warriors |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 42–43 · Hill and Wang, 1997. |

## Excerpt

By far the most alarming was the ominous note of black militancy on which the new decade opened. In Boston in 1829, an ex-slave from North Carolina, David Walker, published the first edition of his famous Appeal A landmark in black protest literature, Walker's Appeal- condemned colonization as a white supremacist hoax, excoriated mem- "that one good black man can put to death six white men." Whites had never hesitated to kill blacks, he advised, so "if you commence... do not trifle, for they will not trifle with you." Other events, even more shocking, were to follow. In after, Southampton County, Virginia, erupted in the bloody Nat Turner insurrection, the largest slave revolt in antebellum America. Still another massive slave rebellion broke out in British Jamaica in 1831. Coinciding with these racial traumas was the Nullification Crisis of 1831-32, a confrontapolicy and by the deeper fear that the federal government might someday abolish slavery. Intent on preserving state sovereignty and hence slavery, South Carolina politicians led by John C. Calhoun temporarily defied national authority, threatened secession, and risked occupation by federal troops. As these frightening events unfolded, young evangelicals cast aside their self-doubt. Unfocused discontent gave way to soul-wrenching commitments to eradicating the sin of slavery. The combined actions of Nat Turner, the South Carolina "Nullifiers," and David Walker suggested with dramatic force that slavery was the fundamental cause of society's degraded state. As Theodore D. Weld observed, the abolitionist cause "not only overshadows all others, but step-by-step solutions advocated by their parents suddenly appeared to invite only God's retribution. Like Garrison, Arthur Tappan, and many others, James G. Birney sealed his commitment to immediate abolition by decrying colonization. The Colonization Society, Birney charged, acted as "an opiate to the consciences" of those who would otherwise "feel deeply and keenly the sin of slavery." In one sense, these sudden espousals of immediate abolition can be understood as a strategic innovation developed because of the manifest failures of gradualism. Slaveholders had certainly shown no sympathy to moderate schemes. In England, too, where immediatism was also gaining followers, the general public had remained unmoved by gradualist proposals. Demands for "immediate, unconditional, uncompensated emancipation" thus appealed to young American idealists—at least the slogan was free of moral qualifications. Indeed, in 1831 the British government, responding to immediatist demands, enacted a massive program of gradual, compensated emancipation in the West Indies.

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**Shortened citation:**

Stewart, *Holy Warriors*, 42–43.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.045

# The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement

Julie Roy Jeffrey

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of North Carolina Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

Some members of the Society of Friends, whose historical and religious experiences differed dramatically from those of evangelical Protestants, also found Garrison's analysis convincing. The Quakers had adopted a forceful stand against slavery during the eighteenth century, refusing slaveholders membership, taking the lead in early abolitionist organizations like the Pennsylvania Abolition Society, and fostering the education of free blacks. Friends were no longer in the forefront of antislavery by the time Garrison announced his program of immediate emancipation. The Pennsylvania Abolition Society, for example, supported gradual change through political channels and focused more on assisting free blacks than on freeing slaves in the South. But the Quaker belief in the Inner Light that revealed what had to be done in this life to each salvation in the next could prompt er became clear only o ver time, Ae emphasis ¢ on ee one's d duty i in the world did not differ so much from the compulsion that the climactic event of an ee saree aiytteseneepeasterennaeetemen LL evangelical conversion might unleash.!

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Jeffrey, Julie Roy. *The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1998.

**Footnote citation:**

Julie Roy Jeffrey, *The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1998), no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition.

**Shortened citation:**

Jeffrey, *The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism*, no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.046

# Virtue's Hero: Emerson, Antislavery, and Reform

Len Gougeon

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|---|---|
| WORK | Virtue's Hero: Emerson, Antislavery, and Reform |
| SELECTION | Virtue's Hero |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 4–5 · University of Georgia Press, 1990. |

## Excerpt

Ornately for Higginson and his cohorts—reformers like Wendell Phillips, William Lloyd Garrison II, and William J. Potter—a lack of biographical resources limited their arguments largely to Emerson's activities in the 1850s, where the record was reasonably well established. This, unfortunately, had the effect of suggesting to some that Emerson was indeed a reluctant latecomer to the cause, and so the debate was inconclusive and continues to this day. An understanding, if not a resolution, of the development of this historical dichotomy is imperative to an accurate understanding of Emerson's relationship to the abolition movement. Even an "inner life" such as Stephen Whicher's, in order to be valid, must be predicated largely upon the evidence provided by an outer life. This would include not only what Emerson actually said and wrote on the subject of abolition but also the activities he undertook in the name of this reform. However, as the present study will show, some of the most deep-seated scholarly commonplaces regarding Emerson's relationship to the important reforms of his day are based upon assumptions that have obtained credibility almost solely on the basis of historical reiteration rather than historical fact. Emerson's first major biographer and commentator, George Willis Cooke, in his Ralph Waldo Emerson: His Life, Writings, and Philosophy (1881) devotes a full chapter to the antislavery movement and maintains that "the real spirit and purpose of the man, [Emerson] are not likely to be understood without a knowledge of his relations to this agitation."2 Cooke highlights the growth of Emerson's involvement in the antislavery cause beginning in 1831-32 when he allowed Samuel May and Arnold Buffum to deliver antislavery addresses from his pulpit in the Second Church in Boston. This was at a time "when all the pulpits were silent on the subject of slavery."3 In his discussion Cooke also quotes extensively from Emerson's famous August 1844 address, "Emancipation in the British West Indies," and other major speeches such as "American Slavery" (1855), "The Assault upon Mr. Sumner" (1856), and "John Brown" (1859), which were delivered throughout the 1850s. Overall, Cooke creates the impression of a very concerned and active Emerson who strongly supported abolitionism, and who, because he "had faith in the triumph of freedom and love, gave such aid as he could and all his sympathies, to those seeking the emancipation of the poor and oppressed."4

Cooke's work was followed in 1882 by Moncure Conway's Emerson at Home and Abroad. Conway, a former slave owner who became an abolitionist, was a personal friend of Emerson in his later years. His study devotes an entire chapter to an exposition of Emerson's antislavery activities. Indeed, his enthusiasm in depicting Emerson as an active reformer led him at times to make somewhat misleading statements. Among these, for example, are the assertions that "Emerson was the first American scholar to cast a dart at slavery,"5 and that he was battling slavery "six years before even [William Ellery] Channing had committed himself to that side."6 Despite such deficiencies, however, Conway does succeed in calling attention to some of Emerson's major abolition activities and furthers the idea suggested by Cooke of an early and constant commitment on Emerson's part to the principles of abolition.

Another important biographical study of Emerson was published in 1882 by a British writer, Alexander Ireland. Emerson had met Ireland on his first visit to England in 1833, and he maintained a cordial correspondence and friendship with him for the rest of his life. Ireland had first published In Memoriam.

Visits to England in 1833, 1847-8, 1872-3 and Extracts from Unpublished Letters in London early in 1882. Encouraged by the swift sale of the book, he soon added a biographical sketch and, later in 1882, published Ralph

Waldo Emerson: His Life, Genius, and Writings, A Biographical Sketch, to Which Are Added Personal Recollections of His Visits to England, Extracts from Unpublished Letters, and Miscellaneous Characteristic Records.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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**Footnote citation:**

Len Gougeon, *Virtue's Hero: Emerson, Antislavery, and Reform* (Athens: University of Georgia Press, 1990), 4–5.

**Shortened citation:**

Gougeon, *Virtue's Hero*, 4–5.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.047

# The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition

Manisha Sinha


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|---|---|
| WORK | The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition |
| SELECTION | ELEVEN: The Abolitionist International |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 353–354 · Yale University Press, 2016. |


## Excerpt

Political abolitionists such as Elizur Wright backed land reform and the demands of labor, paving the way for the rise of free soilism. Wright's encounter with the British working poor and his own economic straits made him sympathetic to the condition of labor. As the editor of the Chronotype and later the Commonwealth in Boston, Wright supported abolition, labor, and women's rights. Smith, Goodell, and Wright formed the Liberty League in 1847, which combined abolition with economic and labor reform. In Massachusetts, Wright, with other Libertyites and Free Soilers, formed viable alliances with labor at the local and state levels, and the NRA endorsed Liberty Party candidates. Even Lewis Tappan admonished George Alexander of the British and Foreign ASS that the "rich would be better off if half or two-thirds of their wealth were distributed among their poor fellow men." He recommended "sub-divisions of landed property" and cultivation of small farms to achieve more "equality in property."

In New York Horace Greeley, the editor of the New York Tribune, combined antislavery with labor reform, becoming a leading proponent of land redistribution and utopian socialism. Early on, Greeley had called for the abolition of slavery in all its forms and, to the ire of abolitionists, advocated the settling of blacks in separate townships. Having the largest circulation in the nation, the Tribune became a mainstream outlet for northern reformism, forging connections with labor and partisan politics. Greeley was an advocate of what one might call today social democracy. He criticized untrammeled competition and individualism, which reduced workers to "abject want." The anti-rent rebellion in New York along with the NRA brought together land reformers like Evans and Greeley, an undertaking that culminated in the Republican Party's homestead platform. Land reformers and abolitionists also supported the homestead exemption for debtors. During Reconstruction, Greeley renounced his pro-labor, antislavery politics, becoming the presidential candidate of Liberal Republicans and Democrats, that is, of laissez-faire principles and white supremacy. Before the war, though, he popularized antislavery and labor reform. By the end of the 1840s workingmen's conventions and labor reform associations made opposition to the Mexican War and the extension of slavery one of labor's goals.[23]

Rejecting electoral politics, Garrisonians were more interested in utopian communities, most founded in the wake of the Panic of 1837 and inspired by early socialist thinkers such as Owen, Fourier, and Saint-Simon. The connection between abolition and communitarianism went back to the days of Frances Wright and Robert Dale Owen, freethinkers who supported abolition, workingmen's rights, and women's equality. The antebellum communitarian movement inspired by Fourierism complemented abolitionists' "come outer" philosophy of rejecting corrupt institutions, the state and church, as well as those built on precedents set by separatist religious communities such as the Shakers and Rappites. Garrison's conservative critics accused him of harboring radical "no government" as well as "no property" theories. In England, Collins reported that Garrison was "considered of the Owen school." In an editorial on "social reorganization" sympathetically evoking Owen and Fourier, Garrison commended the idea of cooperative associations personifi ed in the abolitionist Northampton Association for Education and Industry led by his brotherin-law George Benson, William Adam, David Mack, and E. D. Hudson. He also lauded his fellow nonresistant Adin Ballou's Hopedale community, which, like Northampton, was founded in 1842, the transcendentalist community at George Ripley's Brook Farm, and Collins's journal the Communitist, which advocated communal ownership of property.

## Author's Notes

23. Foner and Shapiro, eds., Northern Labor and Antislavery, 19–22, 127–30; Abel and Klingberg, eds., A Side-Light on Anglo-American Relations, 219–20; Lawrence B. Goodheart, Abolitionist, Actuary, Atheist: Elizur Wright and the Reform Impulse (Kent, Ohio, 1990), chap. 9; Bruce Laurie, Beyond Garrison: Antislavery and Social Reform (Cambridge, Eng., 2005), 67–71; Adam Tuchinsky, Horace Greeley's New-York Tribune:

## Chicago Citations

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**Footnote citation:**

Manisha Sinha, *The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2016), 353–354.

**Shortened citation:**

Sinha, *The Slave's Cause*, 353–354.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.048

# The Transformation of American Abolitionism: Fighting Slavery in the Early Republic

Richard S. Newman

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Transformation of American Abolitionism: Fighting Slavery in the Early Republic |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | supplied PDF 18–19 · University of North Carolina Press, 2002. |

## Excerpt

The era between the American Revolution and the 1830s was the first great period of transformation. What began as an elite abolitionist movement in Pennsylvania during the post-Revolutionary period yielded to an egalitarian movement based in Massachusetts during the early 1830s. With this shift in location, abolitionist strategy, tactics, and, perhaps most significantly, personnel shifted too. Whereas Pennsylvanians sought politicians' support for gradual abolition, "modern" abolitionists roused the masses — including blacks and women — to end slavery immediately.

However, this focus on motivation has often pulled scholars' attention away from what abolitionists did and how their activities shifted over time. Yet whatever their reasons, reformers' tactics often made more of an impression on slaveholders and skeptical northern politicians.

Similarly, just before the Civil War some southern slaveholders referred to the earliest petition campaigns of Pennsylvania abolitionists as the beginning of an abolitionist offensive — and a just reason to secede finally from a Union soon to be overrun by abolitionist policies.

In the early national era, for example, the New York Manumission Society and the American Convention of Abolition Societies joined the Pennsylvania Abolition Society as leaders in the fight against slavery. Similarly, the Massachusetts Antislavery Society was but one of a whole new generation of immediatist organizations that formed in the early 1830s, particularly in New York City, where black and white activists formed crucial ties. Nevertheless, the Pennsylvania and Massachusetts campaigns became virtual personifications of the abolitionist struggle during the early republic. Following the American Revolution, a variety of American and European reformers recognized the PAs as the preeminent organization to end slavery. The flow of information relating to abolitionist tactics went through the group's headquarters in Philadelphia more so than any other locale. Fifty years later, however, Massachusetts served as abolitionism's tactical center.

Pennsylvania reformers realized that a transition had occurred, and that abolitionists in Massachusetts (whom they labeled "Garrisonian" or "modern" reformers) now occupied a leadership position. "To Pennsylvania belongs the honor of first organizing a society" for abolishing slavery, one Quaker State activist somberly wrote in the late 1830s. "Its members were amongst the most excellent and virtuous of the day. They were animated by clear and lofty benevolence . . . and thus constituted and recognized, they wielded moral power, the effect of which is now felt among their descendants." But, he made clear, the present belonged to the younger generation of Massachusetts radicals.

one Bucks County, Pennsylvania, reformer wanted to know. "For a long time it has seemed as though the spirit of freedom had fled from our citizens' bosoms," a new local abolitionist society in Pennsylvania answered in 1837. The new group was Garrisonian.?

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Newman, Richard S. *The Transformation of American Abolitionism: Fighting Slavery in the Early Republic*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2002.

**Footnote citation:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Newman, *The Transformation of American Abolitionism*, supplied PDF 18–19.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.049

# American Reformers, 1815-1860

Ronald G. Walters

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | American Reformers, 1815-1860 |
| SELECTION | American Reformers |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 78–79 · Hill and Wang, 1997. |

## Excerpt

Before 1831 opposition to slavery had taken several forms. From the outset blacks made their feelings clear by flight from bondage, by daycentury—and especially by the time of the Revolution—increasing numbers of whites were preaching abolition, inspired by religion, Enlightenment humanitarianism, and their own republican and egalitarian rhetoric. Most Northern states ended slavery before 1800, while simultaneously limiting the rights of free blacks. Abolition sentiment was on the wane by then and the institution of slavery was, if anything, becoming more strongly entrenched in the lower South, as the newly invented cotton gin and population growth pushed cotton production differed strikingly from the caustic brand Garrison and his colleagues promoted after 1830. It was concentrated in the upper South, was conciliatory to the master, and had little sympathy for blacks. Above all, there was no particular urgency to it. Prior to 1831 most white critics of slavery assumed that manumission would be gradual and ter typified such an approach than the American Colonization Society, founded in 1816. Its mission was to send ex-bondsmen out of the porters included slaveholders, prominent politicians, and distinguished men of the sort who later shunned abolitionism. Their motives were varied and conflicted. Some genuinely hated slavery but believed the races could never coexist without it. Their solution was to expel black people. Other colonizationists were proslavery and merely wanted to dispose of the small free black population of the South and to eliminate bondsmen who might become a burden on their owners or sociit, the Colonization Society nevertheless profited from this ability to it discharged some white anxieties about slavery and race, and otherwise did well in the 1820s.

## Chicago Citations

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**Footnote citation:**

Ronald G. Walters, *American Reformers, 1815-1860* (Rev. ed. New York: Hill and Wang, 1997), 78–79.

**Shortened citation:**

Walters, *American Reformers, 1815-1860*, 78–79.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.050

# Slavery: A Problem in American Institutional and Intellectual Life

Stanley M. Elkins

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|---|---|
| WORK | Slavery: A Problem in American Institutional and Intellectual Life |
| SELECTION | Chapter 4. The Transcendentalist as Abolitionist |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of Chicago Press, 1959. |

## Excerpt

1838 and 1839, in which there was relatively little reform activity, the humanitarian projects burst forth once more in the early forties in greater profusion and with greater intensity than ever.

By the logo's many of the Transcendentalists were themselves in effect becoming abolitionists. To a certain extent they had been introduced to antislavery by their elder mentor, William Ellery Channing. They had shared at first Channing's repugnance to the more aggressive Garrisonian type of abolitionism, but as time went on they moved irresistibly toward more and more extreme positions. And as they did so, it is remarkable to note how their approach to slavery followed the same pattern as their approach to everything else.

We see once more their unwillingness to think in institutional terms. Theodore Parker, for instance, who had as wide an audience as any of the group, would not really think of slavery as an institution. Parker had read more widely in that subject than any man of his time; he knew all about slavery in Latin America and about the great variations which it had assumed in the ancient world; there is little that we now know on the law of slavery in this country and elsewhere that Theodore Parker could not have written a century ago. But although Parker used this information again and again in his attacks on slavery, as may be seen in his numerous papers and lectures on that subject, he never stopped to analyze the way these variations may have pivoted upon radically differing institutional arrangements. Nor did he ever give serious thought to specific improvements in the slave's condition such roles once carried in the community had been downgraded. Thus the young man of talent, learning, and sensibility with ties to an earlier era—either of family or simply of local tradition—was just not attracted to those careers in the way he might once have been (in the career of Henry Adams, at a later period in our history, we have the most poignant symbol of this). In this sense such a group as the Transcendentalists could quite properly be called a "displaced elite." The latest, best, and most precise version of the argument is David Donald's "Toward a Reconsideration of Abolitionists," in Lincoln Reconsidered: Essays on the Civil War Era (New York: Knopf, 1956), pp. 19-36.

Worlds of Theodore Parser (Boston: American Unitarian Association, I9°7-I3), [V], The Slave Power. by concentrating on specific features of the institution of American slavery. He was fully aware, for example, that marriage was sacred and inviolate in most other slave cultures, and although he attacked the American system on this basis, among others, he never thought of such a feature as a specific object of reform and of focusing his energies upon that. He used it instead as a justification for full emancipation; he used his learning in the role of moral agitator, not of intellectual.

Not only did these men fail to analyze slavery itself as an institution, but they failed equally to consider and exploit institutional means for subverting it. The primary choice as it appeared to most of them was simply, "Shall I oppose it, or shall I ignore it?" If the former, their action consisted principally in speaking out in public against it. Their relationship with abolition societies was never anything but equivocal. Neither Emerson nor Thoreau ever joined any of them; William Henry Channing and Frederic Hedge in the thirties joined a short-lived organization which had been formed to counter not only slavery but also Garrisonian abolition; James Freeman Clarke often attended meetings of the Anti-Slavery Society and made speeches there, but he was little concerned with the matter of nominal membership. Theodore Parker was of course his own one-man society.

("corpse-cold") as an institution dedicated to moral regeneration: "this icehouse of Unitarianism," Emerson had called it, "all external." Their pulpits were in effect platforms for personal agitation. Organization was distrusted more or less for its own sake.

This unusual obtuseness to the possibility of piecemeal reform could readily be understood in a single-minded fanatic like Garrison, but Parker was a man of extraordinary talents and a wide breadth of knowledge and interests; it is such cases as his that impel one to examine the social and institutional conditions amid which moral and intellectual energy is expended. Parker had had fifteen years of experience in New England reform movements before he turned his attention to slavery, and he had good reason to know that major changes in social institutions are not brought about in a day. And yet in the case of slavery the only solution he ever recognized was full and immediate emancipation. See Commager, Parser, p. 201, on the delay in Parker's concern over slavery.

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.051

# In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863

Leslie M. Harris

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863 |
| SELECTION | Radical Abolitionists and Black Political Activism |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 172–173 · University of Chicago Press, 2003. |

## Excerpt

The 1834 riots cooled the radicalism of New York City's abolitionists. Black middle-class abolitionists refocused their efforts on the moral and material reform of the black community. White abolitionists who had not anticipated the violence with which their calls for racial equality would be met backed away from addressing the material problems of northern free blacks to focus on eradicating southern slavery. The abolitionist movement also divided over the ways blacks should work against slavery and for racial equality. Some of these divisions were class based. Because anti-abolition, colonizationist, and racist whites used the poverty of many free blacks and their allegedly immoral activities to support arguments for racial inequality, black and white middle-class abolitionists focused on working-class blacks as crucial to solving the problems of racism in the North and slavery in the South. For these abolitionists, the end of slavery required not only that southern slaveholders realize their own sinfulness, but also that free blacks demonstrate their moral worthiness and equality. Thus, middle-class abolitionists focused on converting all blacks to the evolving middle-class ideals of moral and social improvement, such as classical education, temperance, and religiosity. Middle-class abolitionists also tried to control the participation of the black masses in the struggle to protect fugitive slaves in New York City. Middle-class abolitionists advocated nonphysical ways to fight against slavery and for racial equality, such as moral suasion, nonresistance, and legal action. Abolitionists should convince others of the sinfulness of slavery through propaganda campaigns, petitions to government, and refusal to participate in economic systems that upheld slavery. Physical or defensive force should not be used to protect fugitives. Rather, blacks accused of being fugitives should fight for their freedom only through the courts. These were tenets of abolitionist activism aimed at everyone regardless of class or race, though in some cases, abolitionists explicitly attempted to limit the participation of blacks whom they deemed uneducated or unruly.3

Abolitionists, black and white, were participating in the process of defining middle and working classes, consciously and unconsciously. In their own eyes, they advocated a new moral standard for all, regardless of class. But the rejection of their moral ideologies by both black and white working classes, albeit for different reasons, meant that they developed new meanings of what it meant to be middle class, based on morality as well as economic success.

By advocating certain ideological stances as best for blacks as a race, abolitionists tried to remove the class implications of such ideologies. Both black and white abolitionists advocated moral and intellectual reform out of a sincere belief in its efficacy for solving the problems of race in America. But black middle-class abolitionists occupied a special relationship to the reforms aimed at the black working class. The fate of the black middle class or aspiring middle class was bound inextricably with that of the black working class in a society that saw all blacks as inferior and defined that inferiority partially in class terms. Black abolitionists, reacting to the race- and class-based assumptions of inferiority promulgated by the society at large, sought both to control the black working class and also to define themselves in relation to that class. Discussions of the problems of working-class blacks were often cloaked in the unifying language of racial community. Black middle-class reformers thus attempted to create a united black community that would be a reproduction of themselves: their own moral, political, social, and intellectual goals and desires. This kind of black community, they believed, could not be denied equality in the United States.

Middle-class abolitionists' advocacy of certain tactics heightened class divisions among blacks. The solutions to racial inequality promulgated by both black and white middle-class abolitionists were increasingly markers of ideological differences between the black middle class and working class. A few blacks began to question the prescriptions for success spelled out by abolitionists. Some simply claimed working-class identities and pleasures privately, implicitly challenging moral perfectionism as the only way to prove black equality. Others, such as the porter Peter Paul Simons, publicly attacked moral suasion, nonresistance, and intellectual elevation as ways to achieve racial equality. Simons advocated manly physical struggle and greater public roles for women, forcing more conservative black middleclass abolitionists such as Samuel Cornish to defend their political methods. Some black middle-class activists, most notably David Ruggles, founder of the New York Committee of Vigilance, attempted but failed to find a middle ground between the tactics of middle-class radical abolitionists and those of black workers in order to create a more inclusive movement against slavery and for racial equality. These tensions over the best tactics to fight slavery and racism were mirrored in the larger abolitionist movement and resulted in the split in the abolitionist forces by 1840.

## Chicago Citations

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Harris, *In the Shadow of Slavery*, 172–173.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.052

# In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863

Leslie M. Harris

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863 |
| SELECTION | Radical Abolitionists and Black Political Activism |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 189–190 · University of Chicago Press, 2003. |

## Excerpt

The clothes one wore, the foods one ate, where one chose to spend money, for whom one chose to vote, and where and with whom one chose to pray were all part of the struggle against slavery. Free produce campaigns encouraged consumers to avoid buying slave-produced goods such as sugar and cotton. Men should vote only for political candidates who opposed slavery. Those who could not vote, namely, blacks and women, should sign the petitions that antislavery societies continued to send to Congress, despite the gag rule, and to state legislatures. Women organized antislavery sewing bees and sold their creations to supporters of abolition at antislavery fairs; the proceeds funded antislavery speakers and the publications of the local and national societies. Abolitionists encouraged even the poor and children to contribute to antislavery causes through “penny-a-month” campaigns. And if nothing else were possible, the abolitionists encouraged antislavery prayer. Chistians should “come out” of, or leave, religious denominations that continued to characterize slavery as God’s will.36

North and south, many whites found the radicalism of the abolitionists disturbing, even if they themselves opposed slavery. As the anti-abolitionist and colonizationist New Yorker David Meredith Reece said of the radical abolitionists, they were “not the creed and practice of Jefferson, Franklin, Rush, and John Jay, of the old school, for those laboured for gradual abolition, and were clearly right.” Yet, the radical abolitionists were gaining power and support at the same time as those members of the old antislavery school who had converted to colonization were unable to raise money for their cause.37

In New York City, blacks and whites, men, women, and children all formed local abolitionist societies. Among white societies, many of the new radical abolitionists had previously been colonizationists. As abolitionists, their criticisms of southern slave labor now assailed one of the cornerstones of New York City’s economy. As southern newspaperman J. D. DeBow stated, New York was “almost as dependent on Southern slavery as Charleston itself,” and the city far outstripped Boston and Philadelphia in its reliance on southern trade. New York producers sold clothing (including the “negro cloth” that slaves wore), shoes, and luxury items south. Southerners shipped cotton, tobacco, turpentine, pork, and other raw goods and produce to New York. The New York port served as a center from which merchants shipped cotton as well as other southern goods to points up and down the East Coast and to Europe. New York also served as the central point through which European goods were shipped south.

Ships filled with goods from the South landed on the wharves of the East River, where they were reloaded onto ships bound for Europe. New York shippers collected heavy tolls on these goods. New Yorkers also established shipping lines in southern ports and thus profited from shipments that went directly from southern ports to Europe. New Yorkers were able to do this because most southerners were fully absorbed with the wealth to be made through agriculture and the slave trade. Antebellum writers estimated that New Yorkers earned as much as forty cents on every dollar’s worth of southern cotton sold. New Yorkers sold southerners between also held part ownership in southern factories, plantations, and slaves through business and family connections. Finally, wealthy southerners and New Yorkers socialized together. Many southern merchants and planters made annual trips to New York City to purchase goods, and some brought their families with them, viewing such trips as social and cultural as well as business opportunities. Southerners also vacationed in New York state resorts, such as Saratoga Springs. The

reliance of New York's economy on the southern trade meant that working-class whites also depended on the continuation of the slave labor system.38

In New York City, proslavery, colonizationist, and anti-abolitionist whites' attacks centered on Arthur and Lewis Tappan. Migrants from New England, the Tappan brothers were the most visible of a new generation of radical, moral perfectionist reformers in New York City who sought to expunge a range of sins from the nation, from prostitution in northern urban centers to drinking to nonobservance of the Sabbath to slavery in the South. But even before the Tappans converted to radical abolition, New York City elites had begun to view Arthur Tappan as a threat to their way of life. As leader of New York City's Magdalen Society in 1831, Tappan linked economics and morality in a harsh criticism of city elites' participation in prostitution. The Magdalen Society, an organization to reform prostitutes, initially gained the support of a range of the city's religious, social, and political leaders. In the wake of Charles Grandison Finney's first New York City revival in 1829, some reformers had begun to address the issue of prostitution, particularly in the Five Points area. Princeton divinity student John McDowall spent a year leading prayer meetings in New York City brothels before founding the New York Magdalen Society in 1830 to organize the reformation of prostitutes. Lewis and Arthur Tappan were among the leaders of the society and the most generous contributors to its House of Refuge for reformed prostitutes.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Harris, *In the Shadow of Slavery*, 189–190.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.053

# The Trials of Anthony Burns: Freedom and Slavery in Emerson's Boston

Albert J. von Frank

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Trials of Anthony Burns: Freedom and Slavery in Emerson's Boston |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | supplied PDF 363–364 · Harvard University Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

It is also true that many of his actions on behalf of the cause were either ineffectual or unpublicized. That he did not come the twenty miles into Boston during the Burns trial is altogether characteristic.

Convinced that public affairs had reached a critical juncture, Emerson began in June 1854 to involve himself in such unaccustomed activities as political organization, local committee work, petitioning the governor, and raising funds for Kansas emigrants as also, a short while later, for John Brown and Harriet Tubman.

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.054

# Black Abolitionists

**Benjamin Quarles**

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| **WORK** | Black Abolitionists |
| **SELECTION** | Black abolitionists |
| **SOURCE LOCATOR** | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · Oxford University Press, 1969. |

## Excerpt

The most important and revolutionary reform in our country's past, it forced the American people to come to grips with an anomaly that would not down—the existence of slavery in a land of the free.

One of the distinctive themes of the American experience, slavery had been firmly established a century before the Declaration of Independence. Its supporters had come to believe that slavery was the normal relationship between black and white. Increasingly concentrated in the South after the Revolutionary War, they rallied to its defense, coming to resent bitterly the mounting Yankee attack. Hence, as nothing else, the abolitionist agitation intensified the cleavage between the North and the South, leading in turn to a resort to arms and the nineteenth century's biggest and most significant war. The seeds planted by the abolitionists carried a germinating force, furnishing the classic American example of the power of ideals in a social upheaval.

Who were these men and women who would not hold their peace about slavery? They did not fit into any particular mold, religious or secular. Embracing a contingent of transplanted Southerners, they comprised a cross-section of America, geographically and otherwise. It is hardly surprising, therefore, that the movement would have its Negro component. Indeed, the Negro could be numbered among the pioneers. The New Baptist Church in the Negro quarter of Boston on a snowy a Negro dentist in Philadelphia, furnished another historic site; it was here in December of the following year that a committee of the American Anti-Slavery Society, headed by William Lloyd Garrison, drew up the Declaration of Sentiments that quickly became the Magna Charta of the movement.

But the black abolitionist phalanx was not just another group of camp followers. The Negro was, in essence, abolition's "different drummer." To begin with, his was a special concern; he felt that the fight against slavery was the black man's fight. Not all Negroes were abolitionists; far from it. But their general attitude was not incorrectly sensed by the British reformer, John Scoble, after a first-hand observation: "The free people of color, with few exceptions, are true to their brethren in bonds," he wrote in 1853, "and are determined to remain by them whatever the cost." Although, as Scoble pointed out, the free Negroes felt a special kinship to the slave, their sense of concern was often rooted in a broad humanity:. "I am opposed to slavery, not because it enslaves the black man, but because it enslaves man," wrote Daniel A. Payne in 1839. And to John Mercer Langston the abolitionist movement was designed not only for the liberation of the slave but for "the preservation of the American Government, the preservation of American liberty itself."

Aside from his varied role as a participant, the black abolitionist constituted a symbol of the struggle. Many of the Negro leaders in the crusade were former slaves, men and women who brought to the platform an experience that in its way was as eloquent, however broken the English, as the oratory of Wendell Phillips. Moreover, it was the Negro membership in the newer abolitionist movement of the Garrison years that marked one of its greatest differences with earlier abolitionist effort, one in which the Negro was regarded as a recipient of good works rather than as an expounder of the faith.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.055

# Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom

David W. Blight

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| WORK | Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom |
| SELECTION | Chapter 7: This Douglass! |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages reflowed ebook; no fixed page numbers · Simon & Schuster, 2018. |

## Excerpt

"From Massachusetts University, Mr. Garrison, president." Douglass quickly knew he had joined a religious movement, what many historians have come to call a campaign of "Bible politics"; and its spiritual father was William Lloyd Garrison. One of Garrison's long-term admirers, Thomas Wentworth Higginson, recollected that the founder of the Liberator always sounded "like a newly discovered chapter of Ezekiel." But Garrison eagerly made many enemies. One found his style so harsh that he compared him to "the pert loquacity of a blue-jay." Even one among his own flock declared that it was all but impossible "to swallow Garrison whole."

In the early 1840s, Douglass did swallow whole the cluster of ideas and strategies the prophetic Garrison had honed into rigid orthodoxy. To the doctrines of immediatism, moral suasion, anticlericalism, nonresistance (pacifism), and racial equality that Douglass had relished reading about in the Liberator, Garrison had now advanced perhaps his most controversial tenets of all: disunionism (urging abolitionists to withdraw from any complicity with the proslavery US Constitution); antipolitics (denunciation of political parties and of voting itself in a system so corrupted by slavery); and women's equality (demanding women's political and economic rights). These three doctrines did more than anything else to tear asunder by 1840 whatever unity remained in the American Anti-Slavery Society (AASS), the organization Garrison had done so much to build. Garrison took abolitionism into the realm of Christian anarchy, human moral perfectionism, and rejection of virtually all governmental authority. Many devoted abolitionists, especially African Americans, stayed with him; his charisma and devotion alone could carry a crowd a long way. But many others, particularly evangelicals who did not believe all churches worth condemning, and especially those who saw antislavery potential in the Constitution and who believed it foolhardy to think that slavery could ever be eradicated outside the American political system, openly split with Garrison and his brand of ideological purity.

By fall 1841, as Douglass joined a stable of loyal lecturers, Garrison expressed great confidence about the movement. "Our antislavery struggle is constantly increasing in vigor and potency," he wrote to an English friend, "and never were our spirits better or our blows more effective.... Our fall and winter campaign will be carried on with unwonted energy." Invitations to speak came to Garrison himself and to his troops from "all parts of the free states." He relished the attacks on his methods and arguments from outside and from within abolitionism. The coffers of the American Anti-Slavery Society had grown and made possible the hiring of Douglass as well as other speakers. "The many base attempts... to cripple my influence, and render me odious in the eyes of the people," Garrison claimed, "have only served to awaken sympathy... and to open a wide door for usefulness." Portraying himself as undergoing a Job-like onslaught, Garrison exploited his enemies' wrath, a tactic Douglass soon mastered himself: "Thus has the Lord taken the cunning in their own craftiness, and carried the counsels of the froward headlong."

But Garrison no longer spoke for the entire antislavery movement. By 1840 the American Anti-Slavery Society broke apart forever in a schism. In response to the near collapse of moral suasion as a guiding strategy, Garrison, if anything, took it to an even higher intensity. He argued that the whole of American society, especially the North, needed a "moral revolution" in values, a transformation from a nation of sin and infamy to the goal of human perfection. Garrison was a great organizer, an intrepid newspaper editor, and sometimes a magical platform speaker. But he could also demand absolutist doctrines of his followers, as in the biblical injunction he fondly employed: "Be ye perfect, even as your heavenly Father is perfect." Garrisonians increasingly gained a reputation for extreme

radicalism, of being either dangerous or irrelevant cranks. Sometimes they earned such an image, even among other abolitionists, and sometimes it was merely the by-product of embittered factionalism.

Led by Arthur and Lewis Tappan, wealthy abolitionist merchants in New York, a growing cadre of more politically minded reformers came to believe that far more Americans could be reached by antislavery beliefs if immediatism, a radical temperament and the strategy that sought abolition of slavery without delay, did not appear so militant. Garrison outorganized the Tappanites at the 1840 annual convention of the American Anti-Slavery Society, managed adoption of many of his doctrines by narrow margins, and elected the radical feminist Abby Kelley to the executive committee by a tally of 557 to 451. The Tappans and many of their adherents especially opposed women's equality in reform movements; they bolted the older organization and formed the new American and Foreign Anti-Slavery Society, based in New York City and devoted especially to a broader political and legal movement against slavery. That group had also been deeply instrumental in forming the Liberty Party, the first antislavery political organization to gain genuine traction in America.

As Douglass found himself and his talents warmly embraced within the Garrisonian fold, he quickly discerned the ways of a swirling and contentious world of friends and enemies, devotees and apostates. For now, partly out of agreement, and partly because he knew where his bread was buttered, Douglass remained devoted to his mentor, who was thirteen years his senior and a man of prophetic qualities to the young romantic fugitive slave. Although only an upstart, Douglass joined up with the "old organization" men and their growing number of women activists, and he was more than eager to earn approval from his father figure, Garrison, by denouncing the heresies of the "new organization" men such as the Tappans, and the emerging political abolitionists in the Liberty Party.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.056

# Gateway to Freedom: The Hidden History of the Underground Railroad

Eric Foner

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|---|---|
| WORK | Gateway to Freedom: The Hidden History of the Underground Railroad |
| SELECTION | II |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · W. W. Norton & Company, 2015. |

## Excerpt

Most escapes could not have been successful without the support of black communities, free and slave, North and South. Long before there were organized networks to assist fugitives, individual slaves and free blacks offered hiding places and in other ways provided them with assistance in the South. In the North, black men and women whose names are lost to history offered aid to slaves seeking freedom: hotel employees informed slaves brought to New York City by their owners that they were legally free; stevedores assisted fugitives hidden on ships from southern ports; anonymous int roduc t ion: rethinki ng theun de rgrou ndrail roa d 19 individuals who encountered fugitives on the streets offered them aid. Free blacks were the main activists in the vigilance committees modeled on New York's that sprang up in Philadelphia, Boston, Syracuse, and other cities. The leadership of these groups, organized at the local level but in frequent communication with counterparts elsewhere, was generally interracial, but the committees were "to a considerable extent, and in some places entirely sustained by the colored people," the white abolitionist Samuel May Jr. noted.

At the time of the American Revolution, there had been few free blacks anywhere in the country. The growth of the free black population, North and South, in the first half of the nineteenth century proved crucial for the prospects of fugitive slaves. So did the rise of the abolitionist movement. Especially after the emergence of militant, interracial abolitionism in the early 1830s, sympathetic whites offered aid—material, legal, and monetary —to individual fugitives and to the black-dominated vigilance committees. The networks assisting fugitives offered a rare instance in antebellum America of interracial cooperation and a link between the lower-class urban blacks who provided most of the daily activism of vigilance committees and their more affluent white allies. Nearly every prominent white abolitionist, as well as antislavery politicians like William H. Seward and Thaddeus Stevens, at one time or another assisted fugitive slaves; many sheltered them in their homes. So did just about every major black abolitionist. Douglass, of course, became the era's greatest orator, editor, and writer in the cause of abolition and human rights. Pennington, while less well known, published A Text Book of the Origin and History of the Colored People (1841), a challenge to American racism, and participated in numerous efforts to achieve abolition and equal rights for northern blacks. Both provided aid to fugitives. Douglass concealed runaway slaves in his home in Rochester and forwarded them to Canada. "On one occasion," he later recalled, "I had eleven fugig at e way tofreed om tives under my roof." Pennington also aided individual fugitives and helped to raise money in Great Britain for New York's Vigilance Committee. Urban vigilance committees and rural antislavery activists hid runaway slaves and sent them on their way, and on occasion violently rescued fugitives from the clutches of slave catchers. They also defended fugitives in court, published accounts of their experiences, and raised money to purchase their freedom and that of their families. The public activities of these groups had an important impact on the evolving sectional conflict. Vigilance committee lawyers played a crucial role in persuading northern courts to recognize the "freedom principle"—the doctrine that once a slave (other than a fugitive) left a jurisdiction where local law established slavery, he or she automatically became free. Underground railroad operatives were deeply involved in campaigns for equal citizenship for northern free blacks, including the right to vote, access to public education, and economic opportunity. "Vigilance" involved all these activities and more.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.057

# Until Justice Be Done: America's First Civil Rights Movement, from the Revolution to Reconstruction

Kate Masur

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| WORK | Until Justice Be Done: America's First Civil Rights Movement, from the Revolution to Reconstruction |
| SELECTION | Epilogue |
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## Excerpt

In the wake of the 1883 Civil Rights Cases decision, an enduring regional distinction emerged regarding the question of race in public accommodations. In the 1880s and beyond, eighteen states—all of them in the North, Midwest, or Far West—passed laws barring discrimination in public accommodations. For instance, in 1885 the Republican-dominated Illinois legislature passed a measure, introduced by John W. E. Thomas, an African American legislator from Chicago, that guaranteed to all "persons" within the state's jurisdiction the "full and equal enjoyment" of various public accommodations. State supreme courts upheld the new public accommodations laws, and many states strengthened their antidiscrimination provisions in the 1890s. Meanwhile, developments in the states where slavery had been legal in 1861 were starkly different. Faced with the prospect of the federal Civil Rights Act in 1875, Delaware and Tennessee explicitly affirmed the right of public accommodations to discriminate as they saw fit. Then, from the late 1880s through the turn of the century, southern states passed stringent "Jim Crow" laws requiring racial segregation in public schools and in all manner of public accommodations.

There was also a marked regional split on race and voting rights. Beginning in the late 1860s, white southerners had already distinguished themselves for violent voter suppression directed at Black voters and white men who voted Republican. In the 1890s, southern Democrats followed two decades of terror and fraud with legalized disenfranchisement, rewriting their constitutions to reduce the Black vote and cement their party's power. By contrast, Black men continued to vote across the North, and by the early twentieth century, Black women joined them as voters in many places. Party competition in the North and West remained far more robust than in the South, and Black voters influenced local elections—and shaped policy—often by asserting independence from the Republican Party. In the early decades of the twentieth century, massive Black migration from South to North enabled Black voters—bolstered by rich networks of churches, women's clubs, and mutual-aid societies—to elect Black men to office, secure patronage positions, and eventually pursue their interests at the federal level.

THE ASPIRATIONS OF antebellum civil rights activists notwithstanding, the federal measures adopted during Reconstruction did not secure a baseline guarantee of racial equality in civil rights. Operating on the principle of "separate but equal," state and local governments continued to insist that race was a legitimate distinction in public policy and to reinforce forms of racial subordination that, as antebellum activists well understood, had originated in race-based slavery. Governments regularly used facially neutral laws—including those associated with vagrancy and other crimes linked to poverty—to perpetuate racial inequality. Meanwhile, white supremacist violence, as well as racial discrimination by private property owners, by employers, and in the administration of justice, went largely unchecked. From the 1890s to the 1950s, Congress chose not to use its powers under the Fourteenth Amendment to mitigate the damage.

And yet the legacies of the first civil rights movement lived on. In 1939, lawyers in the newly created Civil Liberties Unit of the US Justice Department (soon renamed the Civil Rights Section and later the Civil Rights Division) began using Reconstruction-era federal statutes to pursue cases on behalf of exploited and vulnerable Black and white

laborers, particularly in the South. In 1947, the President's Committee on Civil Rights, commissioned by Harry S. Truman, delivered a report outlining the many ways in which the United States was failing to live up to the Fourteenth Amendment's promises of equal protection and due process of law for all people. Recalling the first civil rights movement, the committee emphasized the still-unmet goal of securing for "each individual" the right "to physical freedom, to security against illegal violence, and to fair, orderly legal process." Meanwhile, activists, including Black lawyers, turned to the federal courts for redress, hoping the Supreme Court might breathe new life into the equal protection clause in particular. In 1954, they secured a signal victory when the court declared, in Brown v. Board of Education, that "separate educational facilities are inherently unequal" and therefore Black students who were subjected to segregated schools were "deprived of the equal protection of the laws guaranteed by the Fourteenth Amendment."

The mid-twentieth-century civil rights movement echoed and expanded the agenda of its antebellum predecessor. The new movement demanded federal protection for African Americans' basic rights to life, liberty, and property, but it also sought to end the racialized exploitation of laborers, which it likened to slavery itself. It demanded repeal of racially discriminatory laws and a newly robust understanding of equal protection of the laws. In addition to advocating racial equality in public education and public accommodations, which the nineteenth century's most progressive activists had envisioned, the twentieth-century campaign also sought protections against discrimination in private employment and housing. Like the first civil rights movement, the mid-twentieth-century movement pursued federal legislation to advance its goals.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.058

# The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition

Manisha Sinha

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| WORK | The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition |
| SELECTION | Introduction: The Radical Tradition of Abolition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 2–3 · Yale University Press, 2016. |

## Excerpt

The history of abolition is an integrated story even though it is usually not told in that manner. Black abolitionists were integral to the broader, interracial milieu of the movement. To read them out of the abolition movement is to profoundly miss the part they played in defi ning traditions of American democratic radicalism. The insidious divide between white thought and black activism that pervades some books on abolition is both racialist and inaccurate. There was no such racial division of political labor in the abolition movement. Early African American literature, black abolitionists' intellectual response to the pseudo science of race, and debates over citizenship and emigration performed the work of political protest. The theoretical sophistication of black abolitionist thought should fi nally put to rest the infl uential yet glib view of it as imitative, mired in the strictures of middle-class reform and elitism, and divorced from the plight of southern slaves and northern masses. Black and white abolitionists also went beyond a simple appeal to the American republican tradition that sought to include African Americans in its promise. They generated a powerful critique of the slaveholding Republic and constructed a counternarrative that highlighted its origins in the slave trade and slavery.[3]

The alternative nature of abolitionism is showcased by its diverse membership, which gave rise to cooperation as well as to creative confl ict across rigid lines of race, class, and gender that characterized early American society. The abolition movement, in which the disfranchised, including women, played a seminal role, was driven by passionate outsiders. Women were abolition's foot soldiers and, more controversially, its leaders and orators. In birthing the fi rst women's rights movement, abolition again revealed its radical face. The abolition movement married the black struggle against slavery to progressive white evangelicalism and to the iconoclasm of more secular reformers. Its steady radicalization on women's rights, organized religion, politics, and direct action made it quickly outgrow the empire of religious benevolence and moral reform.[4]

Abolition was a radical, democratic movement that questioned the enslavement of labor. The best works on abolition have tried to understand it by overturning simplistic social control models that emphasized social and ideological conformity to legitimize an emerging capitalist economy. Scholars have long known that modern racial slavery fostered the growth of early capitalism. If slavery is capitalism, as the currently fashionable historical interpretation has it, the movement to abolish it is, at the very least, its obverse. The history of capitalism illustrates that it has rarely marched in lockstep with democracy. The fraught relationship between capitalism and democracy is characterized more by contestation. Modern racial slavery was a monstrous hybrid that combined the horrors of an archaic labor system with the rapacious effi ciencies of capitalism.[5] Like the slave system they opposed, abolitionists were hybrids, old-fashioned moralizers as well as modern exponents of human rights. It is no coincidence that the brief, incomplete triumph of the abolitionist vision resulted in the greatest expansion of American democracy, and that the demise of abolition went hand in hand with the greatest contraction of democracy. At the heart of that movement lay the slave's struggle for freedom and human dignity.

Never the so-called monomaniacs they were lampooned as, abolitionists recognized that the oppression of slaves was linked to other wrongs in their world. More than a few abolitionists joined such international radical movements as utopian socialism, feminism, and pacifi sm and championed Native American, immigrant, and workingmen's rights. Some even anticipated contemporary American scourges, criticizing the criminalization of blackness and the use of capital punishment and force by the state. Abolitionists were the intellectual and political precursors of

twentieth-century anticolonial and civil rights activists, debating the nature of society and politics, the relationship between racial inequality and democracy, nation and empire, labor and capital, gender and citizenship. They used the vehicle of antislavery to criticize the democratic pretensions of Western societies and expose their seamier side. Abolitionists were opponents of rather than stalking horses of new forms of servitude and imperialism. As radical agitators, they were not so much theorists of liberal democracy as critics of it. In prioritizing the abolition of slavery, they did not ignore and certainly did not legitimize other forms of oppression in the modern world. Only by confl ating the state with the social movement can historians view abolition as the progenitor of European imperialism.[6]

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.059

# All Bound Up Together: The Woman Question in African American Public Culture, 1830-1900

Martha S. Jones

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| WORK | All Bound Up Together: The Woman Question in African American Public Culture, 1830-1900 |
| SELECTION | Chapter Three: Not a Woman's Rights Convention: Remaking Public Culture in the Era of Dred Scott v. Sanford |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of North Carolina Press, 2007. |

## Excerpt

Unchaste black women could never claim respectability in the Hannibal "discourses." Levison, along with Edward Christy, also ridiculed black women's associations with women's rights politics. Such parodies undermined the political pretensions of black men and women while simultaneously undercutting the women's movement itself. Among the entries in Christy's 1858 Ethiopian Joke Book was a lecture "delivered" by an African American man, C. H. Fox, titled "Women's Rights." The lecture and commentary moved quickly to a condemnation of the "lords ob de creashun," of whom Fox rhetorically asked: "Who gib 'em de pribelege to use dat cognoblem? Wat did dey eber do to desarbe it? Did dey eber do anyting?"∑∂ As if his use of faux dialect were not su≈cient to undermine Fox's intellect, Christy goes on to have Fox mis-tell the story of "creashun," or Genesis, explaining the fall as the fault of Adam rather than "Ebe." In his version of Genesis, Fox depicts humanity's fall from grace as the result of Adam's inattention to Eve. Adam stole apples with which Eve made a pie. Upon Adam's incarceration for thievery, Eve, finding herself unsupervised, took up public speaking: "Ebe gub up takin in washin, and went to work an gub lectures in the Metropolitan Hall, an got a party ob strong minded women to help her."∑∑ Fox concludes: "Ain't it led to Women's rights conwenshuns, sewin masheenes, baby jumpers, and Bloomer costumes? Don't de women wear trousers, an coats, an Panama hats.... Don't you hear de cry ob womans' rights trou de land?"∑∏ Here, gender relations among African Americans, both at home and in public culture, were inverted and, in Christy's presentation, perverted. Finally, the women's movement itself was undermined. Not only did it rely upon ill-equipped men for its champions, but it was also grounded in errors of literally biblical proportions.∑π

Only a small number of black activists openly took on the minstrelsy scene. In the late 1840s, Frederick Douglass commented indirectly upon the genre's ramifications. Reporting upon a performance by Gavitt's Original Ethiopian Serenaders, a troupe of African American actors in blackface, the editor of the North Star remarked that only when such performers "cease to exaggerate the exaggerations of our enemies" would they be "instrumental in removing the prejudice against our race." Although Douglass generally discouraged black artists from appearing before white audiences, he urged those who did to model respectability through "industry, application, and a proper cultivation of their taste."∑∫ Douglass pointedly criticized white performers. The "Virginia Minstrels," "Christy's Minstrels," and the "Ethiopian Serenaders" were the "filthy scum of white society," he remarked in an editorial promoting an appearance by the abolitionist Hutchinson Family singers.∑Ω Black activists recognized the caricature of themselves in minstrelsy's images. As Lott explains, the stump speech genre in particular was based upon white observations of black churches and street oratory and parodied these goingson in African American public culture. They built upon a kernel of lived experience: women's rights had emerged as a force in the shaping of African American public culture, and at stake in such expositions—real and imagined—were ideas about black women and their standing in public life.

How might black activists respond to the increasingly hostile climate of the 1850s? Ambivalences of the late 1840s pointed the way. For those who had remained at best uncomfortable with the rise of political women and the adoption of a women's rights platform, the disappointments of the 1850s presented an opportunity for retrenchment; their black political conventions were not women's rights meetings. For those who thought in tactical terms, the 1850s opened the door to a questioning of the capacity of any one movement—whether that seeking to abolish slavery

and achieve civil rights, or that seeking to advance women's rights—to further both "race" and "sex" interests. Yet for others the challenges of the 1850s became an opportunity to a≈rm their political vision and the alliances they suggested.

Even Frederick Douglass faltered under the weight of the decade's degradations. In an 1855 speech before the Rochester Ladies' Anti-Slavery Society, Douglass reflected on the history of the movement and lamented its ine√ectiveness. Abolitionism had taken on too many issues. He concluded in hindsight that "the battle of Woman's Rights should be fought on its own ground; as it is, the slave's cause, already too heavy laden, had to bear up under this new addition." It had been "a sad mistake" to allow the antislavery movement to be "rent asunder by a side issue," he lamented.∏≠ Douglass's retelling of the 1840 schism among antislavery activists was overly simple; the woman question was only one of several issues that divided activists. His remarks explained more about the political terrain during the 1850s. When he had adopted his motto, "Right is of no sex, truth is of no color," Douglass had intended it to stand both as a set of principles and as a model for political activism. By the mid-1850s this potent political ideal could no longer determine the shape of political culture.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.060

# Vanguard: How Black Women Broke Barriers, Won the Vote, and Insisted on Equality for All

Martha S. Jones

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| WORK | Vanguard: How Black Women Broke Barriers, Won the Vote, and Insisted on Equality for All |
| SELECTION | CHAPTER 3 To Be Black and Female |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages reflowed ebook; no fixed page numbers · Basic Books, 2020. |

## Excerpt

By the early 1850s, the Black-led colored conventions had hit their stride. Black leaders regularly met in their home states and in national gatherings that provided an independent political platform for men excluded from state legislatures and national political parties. The delegates came out of local, grassroots organizations that conventions knit together. Print culture served as a powerful instrument for organizing. Those who missed meetings read newsweeklies like Frederick Douglass's Paper (formerly known as the North Star) along with pamphlets that recorded proceedings and broadcast them to remote locales. Increasingly, the perspectives of enslaved people influenced Black politics. Fugitive slave narratives put firsthand testimony at the center of political deliberations. The genre reached its high point with the 1855 publication of Frederick Douglass's second narrative and the stories of William Wells Brown, Solomon Northup, and Jermain Loguen. Sojourner Truth released her narrative in 1850, adding a distinct woman's perspective to these tales about the journey from slavery to freedom.

Activists recommitted to Black politics in response to the Compromise of 1850. Congress had passed a series of bills by which it hoped to settle tensions generated by slavery's expansion west into new lands seized at the end of the Mexican-American War. The act permitted newly added territories to decide whether they would permit slavery. California was admitted as a Free State, and the domestic slave trade was banned in the District of Columbia. But it remained to be seen whether this—or, indeed, the Compromise itself —would calm the tension between pro- and antislavery factions. A final provision of the Compromise, a new and onerous Fugitive Slave Act, especially troubled Black Americans. It promised that slaveholders could demand the help of federal and state officials in capturing fugitive slaves. Those fleeing bondage were no longer entitled to due process protections, such as a jury trial or the right to testify, even if state law said otherwise. In the face of this national edict, thousands of Black Northerners fled farther north to Canada, seeking refuge on free soil. Those left behind exercised new vigilance and radicalism as they defended themselves and their communities.

Those who left the United States after 1850 did not act merely on impulse. A new movement was gaining momentum, an unprecedented Black-led emigration movement. Its leaders encouraged African Americans to reconsider their place in the world. Perhaps they could make a better home in West Africa, Canada, or the Caribbean. It was time, emigrationists urged, to go after a chance for full citizenship in their own lifetimes. Opponents of emigration bitterly denounced such schemes and reiterated the fact that Black Americans had paid many times over for citizenship's full privileges in the United States. Emigration opened yet another fissure within Black politics, one in which old allies faced off across a divide that went to the core of their political identities.

Women also aimed to remake the decade's politics. Beginning in 1850, they convened the first national women's conventions and made plain that a new movement, a women's movement, was part of the political landscape. It had originated in the antislavery meetings of the 1830s, and local gatherings such as those in Seneca Falls and Rochester, New York, in 1848. But the meetings of the 1850s were neither incidental to another cause, nor were they local or impromptu. Organizers intended to build and sustain the women's conventions over many years. They wanted to attract broad attention. They wanted political rights. And they brought a broad array of concerns to the floor. The first meeting in 1850, at Worcester, Massachusetts, included demands for property rights, access to education and

employment opportunities, and a general insistence upon women's "political, legal, and social equality with man." The convention even acknowledged enslaved women, whom the delegates deemed worthy of "natural and civil rights."6

Everywhere across this fractured political landscape, Black women took advantage of the cracks. They were newly strategic and took every chance to make inroads. Rarely did African American conventions recognize their claims on politics—many still insisted that race and gender were separate concerns to be addressed by separate movements. But, in spite of the opposition, Black women found their voices standing at the podium or with pen in hand. They spoke with the same courage that had emboldened Maria Stewart two decades before. They surrounded themselves with like-minded women just as Jarena Lee found support in the Daughters of Conference. Stepping into the political spotlight, Black women preached, taught, and demanded to be heard on their own terms.

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.061

# The Transformation of American Abolitionism: Fighting Slavery in the Early Republic

Richard S. Newman

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| WORK | The Transformation of American Abolitionism: Fighting Slavery in the Early Republic |
| SELECTION | suddenly reappear at that moment—it was seized by new generations of |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of North Carolina Press, 2002. |

## Excerpt

Viewed by early reformers as incompetent (they lacked political influence and legal standing), black activists were assigned segregated roles as teachers and community liaisons, if that. Not content to remain quiet while white reformers did the work, however, black leaders established a parallel universe of abolitionist tactics during the post-Revolutionary era. Revolving around the public sphere — pamphleteering against slavery's immorality, producing personal memoirs of oppression, making stump speeches — these tactics utilized the only political space available to African Americans during the early republic. Black activists hoped to enlist the public's sympathy and emotion to destroy racial subjugation. To repeat James Forten's 1813 phrase, black activists hoped to issue "an appeal to the heart." If Americans would take seriously the stories of oppression and injustice, Forten and his black colleagues asserted, they too would act swiftly to end slavery and institute universal equality in deeds as well as words. Despite an early and consistent push, literary tactics remained largely a part of African American life until a new generation of white reformers came to the fore in the 1820s and 1830s. Profoundly influenced not just by religious principles or economic and political changes but by black activism itself, white leaders like William Lloyd Garrison and Amos Phelps sought for the first time to integrate the movement to end slavery. Even where whites dominated positions of leadership during abolition's "modern" era, a black sensibility pervaded the movement. In new reformers' campaigns for complete racial vindication and a thoroughgoing investigation of white power, American society saw in abolition "blackness" projected before the public eye as never before. The greatest indicator of this black influence was in print culture. That Frederick Douglass's Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass: An American Slave (1845), Harriet Beecher Stowe's Uncle Tonvs Cabin, with its appendix of true black narratives (1852), Garrison's fiery editorials telling Americans that abolitionists would be heard. These literary tactics flowed first from black abolitionism. Although they were magnified with white help, without a preceding black push, abolitionism would have looked and sounded both radically different and much less radical after 1830. In a similar way, women helped produce both a new abolitionism and a new stage for projecting their political concerns. Previously excluded from formal roles in the movement, women became first-rank members of second-wave abolitionism. At one level, female reformers helped establish new strategies and tactics, particularly organizing at the grassroots level. Working in local communities throughout Massachusetts, women collected petition signatures, distributed books and pamphlets (especially those of female authors), organized antislavery meetings, funded abolitionist speakers, and often provided the critical votes for forming grassroots antislavery societies. Whether as protofeminists or concerned mothers, wives, and daughters, women changed the way abolitionists perceived the movement to end slavery. Their grassroots activities illustrated that every person in the republic had a role in ending bondage, not simply men in positions of political or legal power. In short, women gave practical meaning to second-wave abolitionists' grand strategy of turning the whole nation into one big antislavery society. In engaging in political behavior as essentially nonvoting citizens, women also expanded notions of political activism. Significantly, the transformation of abolition took shape in an era when politics itself expanded in all directions. The debate over women's role in the republic was no ancillary concern — it was part of a broader reconsideration of political culture. For example, in petitioning individual senators or critiquing southern slavery in a public forum, female reformers collapsed distinctions between male and female, public and private — not completely, to be sure, but in a definite way. Throughout the North and in parts of the South, women broke out of explicitly female roles: they worked in northern factories, staffed reform organizations, and began their own movement for equal rights. Female abolitionism melded with these trends, making abolition itself appear much more than simply a movement to end slavery.

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.062

# Black Women Abolitionists: A Study in Activism, 1828-1860

Shirley J. Yee

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| WORK | Black Women Abolitionists: A Study in Activism, 1828-1860 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 137–138 · University of Tennessee Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

Such attitudes continued throughout the nineteenth century, as white leaders worried that associating with blacks might jeopardize an alliance with southern white women who had not supported abolition. They knew that although abolitionist women were an active and vocal lot, they represented a numerical minority of the American population. Moreover, abolition had been unpopular among many northern as well as southern whites, who feared that ending slavery and promoting racial equality would result in racial amalgamation. But a failure to perceive race and class as essential to women's liberation shaped the agenda of the white women's movement and ultimately prevented the possibility of forging a biracial feminist alliance, a failure of vision that would remain problematic into the twentieth century.

White feminists' adoption of overtly racist tactics led black women once again to establish their own pattern of activism by forming black suffrage organizations. When white feminists fought to dissociate the movement from its abolitionist roots, black women activists recognized the need to maintain black abolitionist goals. Separate participation in the struggle for sexual equality, however, was not simply a response to exclusion by whites; it was a continuation and expansion of a tradition of resistance and protest, in which the terms "'liberation" and "'equality" included the elimination of racism as well as sexism. Consequently, their agenda was the most dangerous and radical that this generation of reformers could formulate, for it represented the possibility of overturning two of the most firmly entrenched forms of oppression.

Ironically, white and free black women who had participated in reform activities shared similar experiences, because on every level of public activism, sexist conventions had helped define their roles. In their interactions with men, women as a group occupied the "female" role as supporters of male activities. For those women who engaged in antislavery activism, public opinion made them acutely aware of the consequences of engaging in "male" activities. It was in organized abolition that black and white women publicly demanded an equal voice with men in the proceedings of state and national antislavery conventions. Abby Kelley Foster's election to the executive committee of the AAS in 1840 represented progress for white women in the national organizational hierarchy. Nearly a decade later, black women in Columbus, Ohio, demanded equal voting rights with men in the proceedings of the black conventions.

Many white men, including members of the clergy, vigorously opposed women's rights, arguing that political equality for women would eventually draw them away from their domestic responsibilities. But many black male leaders sympathized with the women's rights campaign because they, like all women, had experienced political disfranchisement. These men tended to be more tolerant of equal rights for black women, in particular, because they had suffered race discrimination. To black men, black women's suffrage was a means of achieving racial solidarity through selfimprovement and black empowerment, despite tensions between the sexes, for though some black men supported women's rights in principle, leaders such as Frederick Douglass believed it should remain separate from the struggle for racial equality. Others, as illustrated in the black conventions, simply opposed the equal participation of women.

The desire to impose culturally dominant sex roles placed women's rights in direct conflict with the effort to create a self-reliant free black community, despite the sense in which women's rights represented another step toward racial equality for black women. In the black conventions, gender ideals were strong enough to prevent some black men from giving full support to women's equality. Although they expressed less opposition to women's rights than did white men, black men were sometimes reluctant to grant women an equal voice in black antislavery and self-help organizations, and by 1869, political expedience had led most of these men to abandon their support for women's rights in favor of universal manhood suffrage.

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**Shortened citation:**

Yee, *Black Women Abolitionists*, 137–138.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.063

# Liberty Power: Antislavery Third Parties and the Transformation of American Politics

Corey M. Brooks

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| WORK | Liberty Power: Antislavery Third Parties and the Transformation of American Politics |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 11–12 · University of Chicago Press, 2016. |

## Excerpt

down the ominous road to civil war, most veterans of the Liberty and Free Soil Parties confidently embraced the opportunity to overthrow the Slave Power, end slavery, and, some hoped, transform American society and promote racial equality.

Across this decades-long political conflict, abolitionist strategy developed in conjunction with slaveholding politicians' rising apprehensions about their institution's security. As the abolitionist movement grew, its initiatives seemed to elicit excessive Southern wrath. Counterproductive Southern efforts to suppress antislavery speech and political action won abolitionists new sympathizers (which in turn lent further credibility to proslavery extremists' forebodings of an abolitionist conspiracy that might one day sweep the North). Learning quickly, abolitionists soon began working to consciously incite Southern overreactions, especially in Congress. To a degree, extreme proslavery politics and political abolitionism relied on each other. Increasingly common confrontations between proslavery and antislavery radicals made it harder and harder for mainstream politicians to ignore the slavery issue. Proslavery zealots, in their efforts to repel all antislavery incursions against a political system that was, on the whole, fairly friendly to slaveholders' interests, provided political abolitionists with valuable opportunities to further destabilize that system. Despite the best efforts of sectional moderates to paper over deepening discord, anti-abolitionist and anti-Slave Power politics together fed a cyclical dynamic that continually escalated the political conflict over slavery."

This book explores political abolitionists' indispensable influence on the dramatic rise of antislavery politics and employs a roughly, but not entirely, sequential organization, with some significant chronological overlap across chapters. The first chapter demonstrates how abolitionist arguments about overbearing Southerners' disproportionate political power developed into a sophisticated analysis condemning both the Democratic and Whig Parties. The chapter then shows how the Slave Power argument shaped political abolitionists' move toward third-party politics.

The second chapter illuminates political abolitionists' strategies for building collaborative relationships with prominent antislavery politicians, especially the handful of potential Whig allies in the U.S. House of Representatives. Antislavery representatives served as conduits through which abolitionists might broadcast portions of their message to a national audience. As political abolitionists lobbied and cooperated with antislavery congressmen, together they helped spread an anti-Slave Power message to an ever more receptive Northern public.

Capitalizing on intense competition between Whigs and Democrats in many Northern constituencies, abolitionists marshaled balances of power to impede major-party attempts to evade the slavery question. These efforts were especially productive in New England's majority-rule elections, where Liberty men forced repeated runoffs as a way to further expose Democrats' and Whigs' responsibility for upholding the Slave Power.

The next two chapters demonstrate how the Mexican-American War provoked an explosion of anti-Slave Power sentiment across the North, and how political abolitionists exploited this popular upsurge. Heated congressional debates over slavery's westward extension powerfully exhibited the growing appeal of antislavery arguments developed by political abolitionists. Coalition-minded Liberty men then seized on this widespread anti-extension

feeling to make the case for a new, broader anti-Slave Power party. While antislavery Whigs and Democrats still clung to faint hopes that their parties might nominate anti-extensionist presidential tickets, Liberty coalitionists laid the groundwork for the Free Soil Party. With its expanded ranks, third-party antislavery emerged more powerful than ever in Congress.

explicates, when the 1854 Kansas-Nebraska Act triggered a new crisis, Free Soil leaders in and out of Congress stood ready to organize and promote the anti-Nebraska coalition that quickly evolved into the Republican Party and became a powerful anti-Slave Power force in congressional and electoral politics.

Vignettes describing five elections for speaker of the House punctuate this story at key moments and highlight political abolitionists' efforts to reshape congressional politics. As a crucial component of their assault on the Slave Power's national ascendancy, political abolitionists emphasized Southern domination of the House speakership. Abolitionists aptly perceived the formidable policymaking role of antebellum speakers of the House, who determined all committee assignments without resort to the sorts of formalistic seniority rules that have shaped later congressional committee appointments.

## Chicago Citations

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Brooks, *Liberty Power*, 11–12.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.064

# Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom

David W. Blight

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| WORK | Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom |
| SELECTION | Chapter 14: My Voice, My Pen, or My Vote |
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## Excerpt

Lake until he found “a suitable place to renew my acquaintance with the art of swimming.” He told of his sheer joy in a kind of diary for the paper: “Here all my boyish pranks in the front basin of Baltimore were renewed. I had a glorious swim.”

On his Ohio tour, which included a convention in Salem, Douglass was Jim-Crowed twice. Going west on a boat on Lake Erie between Buffalo and Cleveland, the captain forced him to sleep on wood planks on the deck. On the return eastward, a captain “assaulted” Douglass at a dinner table. He “pulled the chair from under us and brought us down upon the cabin floor,” wrote the traveler. In Buffalo, Douglass consulted a lawyer, only to be told that the law was clearly on his side, but that no local judge would convict someone in such a case. “There is something canine in the bark and growl of a genuine negro-hater,” concluded the weary traveler, who could still smile. “But a truce to puppies!” He loved his Ohio audiences of abolitionists. He felt inspired by the throngs “composed… mainly of hard-handed farmers, their industrious wives, daughters, and sisters.” Back home in New York surging in and out of small towns and villages, Douglass spoke twice a day, he said, for a week in Oneida and Herkimer Counties. In mid-October he spoke in ten towns in seven days, and at the end of the campaign he reported a total of eighty lectures in some forty days on the road.

Everywhere Douglass went, he denounced the Fugitive Slave Act, argued that slavery could never be legal, demanded his auditors enter the civic and political fray, and acknowledged that the characters in Uncle Tom’s Cabin danced in the heads of voters in this season of politics. Abolitionist principles, he believed, had never had such a political airing as now. At a speech in Ithaca in October he boiled down his decadelong career to a personal statement of his politics: “I have one great political idea. That idea is an old one… widely and generally assented to; nevertheless… generally tramped upon and disregarded.” The best expressions of his views, he said, were “found in the Bible.” From Proverbs, he declared, “RIGHTEOUSNESS EXALTETH A NATION—SIN IS A REPROACH TO ANY PEOPLE.” Such a moral declaration, he concluded, “constitutes… the whole of my politics.” Such a choice of Scripture is interesting for a recovering moral suasionist. In all the maxims about wisdom and folly in Proverbs, though, Douglass would also have read many passages about how the prudent gain knowledge and understanding, and the deceitful fall in folly. His politics was anything but settled; like his sense of abolitionist strategy, it grew into a mixture of righteousness and pragmatism.

In his paper, Douglass delivered a ringing endorsement of Hale and the Free Soilers, despite that Hale had refused to declare slavery a form of “piracy,” as demanded by the Liberty Party. The bulk of Douglass’s endorsement reveals a mind torn between moral principle and political action. He urged Liberty men to remember that a vote could seldom represent all of one’s moral convictions. Sounding like a veteran politician, he offered a “rule” for action: “The voter ought to see to it that his vote shall secure the highest good possible, at the same time that it does no harm.” Once converted to political abolitionism, Douglass characteristically gave it his heart, mind, and soul; but he demanded more of it than it could deliver. Demonstrating his political fickleness, just before the November 1852 elections, Douglass withdrew his support of the Free Soilers Within a year and a half everything seemed to change. Douglass’s initial reaction to the Kansas-Nebraska Act in early 1854 was a combination of outrage and refurbished hope. In his view, the repeal of the Missouri Compromise (the geographical guarantee against slavery north of the 36°30' parallel) resulted from the “villainy of the slave power” and the “pusillanimity of the North.” “The Republic swings clear from

all her ancient moorings," he rejoiced from the isolation of Rochester, "and moves off upon a tempestuous and perilous sea. Woe! Woe! Woe to slavery! Her mightiest shield is broken… and for one, we now say… let the battle come." He felt encouraged by the increasing severity of the various drafts of the Kansas-Nebraska bill. "If we must have the repeal of the Missouri restriction," Douglass wrote privately, "let nothing be done to soften the measure." With good reason he anticipated a political awakening in the North, a rise in antislavery sentiment, and the splintering of political parties along sectional lines. Here was the anticipated political upheaval beyond anyone's control. "Let the old parties go to destruction," Douglass gleefully urged, "and henceforth let there be only a free party, and a slave party." A whole new front of attack seemed now to have opened, the ironic result of the Slave Power's insatiable quests for dominion.

The social furor and the rapid political realignment that gave birth to the Republican Party in 1854 provided the kind of revolutionary circumstance Douglass sought. He exploited every opportunity to expose the growing hostility between North and South, employing the concept of "irrepressible conflict" considerably before the Republican William H. Seward made it famous in 1858. Douglass strove not to assuage fears of the impending crisis but to hasten its coming. By 1855 he proclaimed, "The hour which shall witness the final struggle is on the wing. Already we hear the booming of the bell which shall yet toll the death knell of human slavery." As the old prophets had foretold for their own decadent and lost age, a vengeful and just God, and Douglass would add natural law, made this American conflict a certainty. His message was—people, get ready. "As a nation," Douglass exhorted, "if we are wise, we will prepare for the last conflict… in which the enemy of Freedom must capitulate." His fondest hope was that the new politics would bring an age of "Truth and Error, Liberty and Slavery, in a hand-to-hand conflict." In the old stories, Douglass told his readers, they would find the vision to end all compromises. He performed in editorials as a prophet with an ultimate duty of hope. "The disintegration of the once powerful political parties," he announced, "is a cheering and significant sign of the times. The throne of the despot is trembling to its deep foundations. There is a good time coming."

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.065

# Free Soil, Free Labor, Free Men: The Ideology of the Republican Party before the Civil War

Eric Foner

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| WORK | Free Soil, Free Labor, Free Men: The Ideology of the Republican Party before the Civil War |
| SELECTION | 3 Salmon P. Chase: The Constitution and the Slave Power |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 79–80 · Oxford University Press, 1970. |

## Excerpt

Because of his eagerness to work in the Liberty party and his legal ability and prominence, Chase was chosen to write most of the important Ohio and national Liberty platforms and addresses. Through them, he developed a purely political approach for the party to follow. Without abandoning the goal of eventual abolition, Chase shifted the immediate attention of the Liberty party to all the places where slavery could constitutionally be reached and challenged by the federal government—the District of Columbia, the territories, the interstate slave trade, and the fugitive slave law. He coined the phrase "the absolute and unconditional divorce of the Government from slavery," which meant abolition wherever the federal government had the power to accomplish it, the admission of no more slave states, and the expulsion of slaveholders from control of the government. As this had been the intention of the founding fathers, it became the political program of the Liberty party. "It was his pen and influence," an anti-slavery newspaper said of Chase, "which gave body and popular consistency to the doctrines of the Liberty party."[18]

Chase also did what he could to cleanse the Liberty party of the taint of extremism. Though he never denied that the party's ultimate goal was the extinction of slavery, he took great pains to differentiate between moral arid political anti-slavery action—or, more precisely, between abolition and anti-slavery. "Abolition," he wrote to Thaddeus Stevens in 1842, "seeks to abolish slavery everywhere. The means which it employs correspond with the object to be effected—they are of a moral nature—argument, persuasion, remonstrance and the like." Abolitionists' aims "cannot be effected by political power." But antislavery aimed at the separation of the federal government from slavery, and its deliverance from control by the Slave Power. As a result, "while abolition is not properly speaking a political object, antislavery is." Chase even suggested that the Liberty party publicly disown the label abolitionist, but eastern leaders would not hear of it. "In the first place," Joshua Leavitt complained to Chase, "I am an abolitionist, and expect to be one... until slavery is actually abolished." He went on to point out that there would be more abolitionists alienated by such a disavowal than non-abolitionists who would be convinced.[19]

## Author's Notes

18. Hart, Chase, 66; Theodore C. Smith, The Liberty and Free Soil Parties in the Northwest (New York, 1897), 88; Wm. G. Lewi.s, Biography of Samuel Lewis (Cincinnati, 1857), 286, 311; Chase and Cleveland, Antislavery Addresses, 96, 100; Porter and Johnson, comps., forty Platforms, 4—5; "Diary and Correspondence," 184—85; Bangor Platform, March 6, 1849, clipping, Scrapbook, Chase Papers, LC. Cf. Henry Wilson, History of the Rise and Fall of the Slave Power in America (3 vols.: Boston, 1875-77), H, l(>7-

19. Chase and Cleveland, Antislavery Addresses, 108; Chase Diary, June 26, 1843, Chase to H. B. Stanton and Elizur Wright, September 23, 1845, news clipping, Scrapbook, Chase to Charles D. Cleveland, October 22, 1841, Chase Papers, LC; Chase to Thaddeus Stevens, April 8, 1842, Thaddeus Stevens Papers, LC; Joshua Leavitt to Chase, December 6, 1841, Chase Papers, HSPa.

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Foner, *Free Soil, Free Labor, Free Men*, 79–80.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.066

# Gateway to Freedom: The Hidden History of the Underground Railroad

Eric Foner

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| WORK | Gateway to Freedom: The Hidden History of the Underground Railroad |
| SELECTION | IV |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 145–146 · W. W. Norton & Company, 2015. |

## Excerpt

Despite abolitionists' success in winning the liberty of the Lemmon slaves, Jane Johnson and her children, and other slaves brought to the North by their owners, the freedom principle had no bearing on fugitive slaves. For them, especially after 1850, the only sure avethef ugi tive sl av e l aw andthe bl ac k com munity 14 5 nue to freedom involved seeking refuge in Canada. And at the same time that it inspired heightened efforts to aid fugitives in the courts, the passage of the Fugitive Slave Law reinvigorated and radicalized the underground railroad. New local vigilance committees sprang up, and increasing numbers of abolitionists abandoned moral suasion to embrace the use of force.

At public meetings throughout the North, speakers, black and white, invoked the heritage of the American Revolution to justify violent resistance to an unjust law. At the 1852 national convention of the Free Soil party, an organization devoted to stopping the westward expansion of slavery, Frederick Douglass proclaimed, "The only way to make the Fugitive Slave Law a dead letter [is] to make half a dozen or more dead kidnappers." A New Bedford abolitionist urged fugitives to "practice the art of using firearms" so that they could shoot slave catchers. New York City was no exception. Speakers at the public meeting that raised money to free James Hamlet called for resistance. "Liberty is worth fighting for," declared one member of the audience, and the gathering advised fugitives to "arm themselves with the surest and most deadly weapons, to resist unto the death." White abolitionists, the Brooklyn Eagle complained, "were foolish enough to endorse the frenzied ravings of the negroes."

Rhetoric advocating armed resistance to the new law often amounted to little more than bravado. In parts of the North, however, efforts to assist fugitives took a violent turn. Dramatic attempts to rescue runaway slaves punctuated the 1850s—one study counts over eighty such confrontations. Before 1850, altercations of this kind had mostly been confined to the borderlands between slavery and freedom; now they occurred in many parts of the North. In October 1850, hundreds of armed blacks gathered at a jail in Detroit where a fugitive was being held. The frightened owner quickly agreed to allow his freedom to be purchased.

1851, a predominantly black crowd in Christiana, Pennsylvania, routed a group of slave catchers that included a federal marshal and a Maryland owner, who were attempting to apprehend four fugitives. The crowd, which numbered over 100 men and women, many of them armed, was led by William Parker, a runaway slave at whose home two of the fugitives were hiding. The slaveowner died in the affray, Parker and the fugitives fled to Canada, and the Fillmore administration obtained indictments for treason— a capital crime—against forty-one men, the largest such mass indictment in American history. But pursuing the case proved almost impossible in an area with strong sympathy for fugitives. Only one person, a white miller who claimed to have been an innocent bystander, was brought to trial. After deliberating for only fifteen minutes, the jury returned a verdict of not guilty.

The following month, similar events unfolded in Syracuse, a city in the heart of upstate New York's burned-over district. A vigilance committee formed after the passage of the Fugitive Slave Act openly vowed to resist enforcement. On October 1, 1851, a federal marshal arrested Jerry McHenry, who had escaped from North Carolina eight years earlier and settled in Syracuse. A Liberty party convention happened to be meeting in the city; it adjourned to besiege the commissioner's office. A group that included the abolitionists Gerrit Smith and Samuel J. May and the fugitive

slave Jermain W.

## Chicago Citations

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Foner, Eric. *Gateway to Freedom: The Hidden History of the Underground Railroad*. New York: W. W. Norton, 2015.

**Footnote citation:**

Eric Foner, *Gateway to Freedom: The Hidden History of the Underground Railroad* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2015), 145–146.

**Shortened citation:**

Foner, *Gateway to Freedom*, 145–146.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.067

# The Antislavery Impulse, 1830-1844

Gilbert Hobbs Barnes

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| WORK | The Antislavery Impulse, 1830-1844 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages -15—-14 · D. Appleton-Century, 1933. |

## Excerpt

Weld's papers and studying his career, Barnes could not help but admire him. And he expressed his admiration freely, not only by the heroic portrait he drew of Weld and those who followed him, but by contrasting his "modesty," "his magnetic presence," his leadership, his self-sacrificing selflessness with the total absence of all of these ennobling qualities in Garrison. If Barnes was harsh in his debunking of Garrison, this was largely the result of his ill-concealed sense of outrage that Garrison should for so long have received all of the credit which rightly belonged to Weld.

. . uttered no malice "Hequotation from one who heard him sharpened no phrase so that its venomed point might rankle in another's breast. . . . His great soul was full of compassion for the oppressor and the oppressed." Barnes's own estimation was just as strong : "Selfless and all the abolitionists in later lovable—among years only Weld and the gentle Whittier, his beloved friend, were unslandered by their co-workers. . . ."

Birney, Henry B. Stanton, the Grimke sisters, Joshua Giddings, Orange Scott. All of them were presented with their best sides forward. One of the highlights of the book was Barnes's magnificent re-creation of that great battle which crusty old John Quincy Adams waged singlehanded in the halls of Congress for the right of petition, not only in the teeth of raging Southerners but against the bitter anger of all the members of his own party.

Barnes's ambivalence toward the antislavery impulse was equally obvious in his treatment of Charles Grandison Finney and the Great Revival. While he had no use for Finney's hysteria-arousing sermons and his manipulatory "new measures," he could not help but admire the way the forthright western preacher demolished the cruel doctrines of Calvinism and defied the imprecations of Lyman Beecher.

"Finney was a portent, one of the notable figures in the moral history of the nineteenth century, and one of the greatest of modern evangelists. ' And what made him epochal was not those aspects of his revivalism which the Menckenites ridiculed, but the doctrine of "disinterested benevolence" which he doctrine which "released the mighty preached—the impulse toward social reform" and paved the way for the new antislavery impulse. If Weld and his followers were heroes, the fact that Finney was their spiritual father and greatest source of inspiration and strength surely reflected to Finney's credit. Furthermore, Barnes gave Finney credit for opposing the denunciatory aspects of some of Weld's abolitionist followers. Finney feared that "a censorious spirit" such as that of Garrison and some western radicals would "roll a wave of blood over the land." Barnes clearly regretted the fact that the Great Revival declined and "the antislavery impulse ceased to be a missionary movement to save the slaveholders." It was at this point, in 1839, that Barnes believed the war became irrepressible : "The decline of the Great Revival and the rise of Southern resentment made inevitable what he [Finney] feared."

There is one final but important point in Barnes's analysis of the antislavery impulse to which the Southern revisionists failed to pay due attention. This was his frontal attack upon the economic interpretation of the coming of the Civil ar. The economic argument was W central to the revisionist interpretation of the war because the revisionists held not only that it was economic differences which produced the different cultures and philosophies between the North and the South but also that these economic differences would never, by themselves, have brought a war. For prior to the furor aroused by the abolitionists, with their irrational fanaticism, the conflicts between Northern and Southern views had often been settled by compromises: in 1787, in 1815, in 1820, in 1828, in

1832.There was no reason to believe, said the revisionists, that rational men could not have continued amicably to compromise (as Henry Clay and Stephen A. Douglas tried to do) until slavery died out of its own accord or was gradually abolished by some mutually convenient arrangement (The revisionists incidentally, were by all odds the most disillusioned intellectuals following World War I and the most ready to denounce all wars as the result of irrational propaganda. Arthur Schlesinger, Jr.

## Chicago Citations

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Barnes, Gilbert Hobbs. *The Antislavery Impulse, 1830-1844*. New York: D. Appleton-Century, 1933.

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Gilbert Hobbs Barnes, *The Antislavery Impulse, 1830-1844* (New York: D. Appleton-Century, 1933), -15–-14.

**Shortened citation:**

Barnes, *The Antislavery Impulse, 1830-1844*, -15–-14.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.068

# Holy Warriors: The Abolitionists and American Slavery

James Brewer Stewart

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| WORK | Holy Warriors: The Abolitionists and American Slavery |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 57–58 · Hill and Wang, 1997. |

## Excerpt

Arthur Tappan had already invested heavily in an Ohio reform project, Lane Seminary, which had been established by New York evangelicals as an outpost of revivalism in Cincinnati. Lyman Beecher, one of New England's most august evangelical ministers, had already agreed to leave Boston and assume Lane's presidency. Now resolving to make the seminary a citadel of Yankee abolitionism, the Tappans dispatched Weld to Cincinnati in early 1834, and results were not long in coming. Weld took with him Oneida students like Henry B. Stanton who were already well-schooled in the formulas of immediatism. Others, likewise destined for leadership in abolition, also converged on the seminary, attracted by an admissions policy which encouraged "people of color" to apply. Under Weld's direction, the students at once initiated public discussions on the merits of immediate emancipation.

Eighteen days later, after prayerful evenings and "protracted sessions," the students and faculty endorsed immediatism and vowed their implacable opposition to colonization. "The Lord has done great things for us here," Weld reported to Lewis Tappan. "Eight months ago there was not an immediate abolitionist in this seminary . . . and abolitionism was regarded as the climax of absurdity, fanaticism and blood." Thus displayed, in all their purity, were the fruits of moral suasion. After organizing an antislavery society, the students affirmed their liberation from prejudice by working to spread literacy and piety within the local black community. Augustus Wattles and Marius Robinson even suspended their studies for a year of full-time service in a black elementary school.

Cincinnati's white citizens, some of whom had only four years earlier turned viciously against their black neighbors in bloody riot, were incensed. The worried trustees, in turn, ordered students and faculty to disband their antislavery society. President Beecher assured Lewis Tappan of his commitment to "free discussion," but could effect no compromise between the trustees and the rebels. Forty students led by Weld thereupon renounced their affiliation with the seminary and pursued their activities in Cincinnati with even greater zeal. Abolitionists had turned upon their evangelical fathers. In Lyman Beecher's case, the rebellion entered his own family. Only Catherine, his eldest daughter, supported her father's efforts at compromise. Harriet Beecher expressed her entire sympathy with the seceding students. She was not yet married to Lane's Professor of Biblical Literature, Calvin Stowe.

Ultimately the Lane rebels found a congenial home in Oberlin, a small town in northwest Ohio, and once again the Tappans supplied initial funding for a new college. For the first time in the history of higher education, instruction was open equally to men, women, and blacks, and "free discussion" was upheld in the college charter. Charles G. Finney joined the faculty, but Weld declined a professorship in theology, preferring to evangelize the countryside against slavery. Still, he retained close ties with Oberlin, which soon became the hub of Western abolitionism and the nation's finest example of integrated learning. Throughout the 1830's Weld and his associates lectured and passed out tracts to spread the message of abolition in hundreds of Ohio and upstate New York communities.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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**Footnote citation:**

James Brewer Stewart, *Holy Warriors: The Abolitionists and American Slavery* (Rev. ed. New York: Hill and Wang, 1997), 57–58.

**Shortened citation:**

Stewart, *Holy Warriors*, 57–58.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.069

# Until Justice Be Done: America's First Civil Rights Movement, from the Revolution to Reconstruction

Kate Masur

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| WORK | Until Justice Be Done: America's First Civil Rights Movement, from the Revolution to Reconstruction |
| SELECTION | The Liberty Party and Repeal of the Ohio Black Laws in the 1840s |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages reflowed ebook; no fixed page numbers · W. W. Norton & Company, 2021. |

## Excerpt

The 1848 election season also proved the final straw for the many antislavery Whigs who loathed their party's nominee for president: slaveholder and Army General Zachary Taylor of Kentucky. Intended as a safe choice in a polarized time, Taylor was anathema to many antislavery or "conscience" Whigs who were tired of yielding to the southern wing of their party. Joshua Giddings, who had heretofore insisted that the goals of the antislavery movement were best advanced within the Whig Party, now joined the third-party movement and campaigned for Free Soil candidates in the Western Reserve and across Ohio. Likewise in Massachusetts, antislavery Whig politicians who were committed to dismantling racist policies at home —including Henry Wilson and Charles Sumner—joined the Free Soil movement in 1848.

The Free Soil Party was larger and more diverse than the Liberty Party, and its stance on racial equality before the law was more opaque. Some of its adherents, particularly northern Democrats such as David Wilmot himself, were uninterested in questions of racial equality in the free states—or were outright opposed. Wilmot had told the House his goal was to preserve the territory acquired from Mexico for "the sons of toil, of my own race and own color." To knit the movement together at the national level, leaders emphasized opposition to the Slave Power and slavery's extension; the party's catchy slogan was, "Free Soil, Free Speech, Free Labor, Free Men." Unlike the Liberty Party platform of 1844, the Free Soil platform of 1848 made no mention of the rights of free African Americans, the repeal of antiblack laws, or Black men's right to vote.

At the state level, however, many Free Soilers continued to work for repeal of the black laws, and this was nowhere truer than in Ohio. In 1848, Norton Townshend was a candidate for the Ohio House of Representatives, running on the Free Soil platform. As a medical student in 1837, Townshend had met Salmon Chase and his abolitionist allies in Cincinnati. Townshend had helped organize the Liberty Party in the Western Reserve, and in 1844 he stumped for the party's agenda of repealing the Ohio black laws and ending federal support for slavery. In 1848, Ohio Free Soilers campaigned on both national and local issues. Defining his position on state policy, Townshend emphasized: "First of all, I desire the repeal of the disgraceful Black Laws, no vestige of them ought to remain, and for the honor of our noble State, I wish all record of them could be blotted from the otherwise fair Whig leaders recognized the significance of the black laws as they deployed heavy hitters in the Western Reserve to try to shore up support. Visiting Cleveland in 1848, William Seward sought to persuade his audience that the Whigs, not a small and untested third party, remained the best conduit for bringing the antislavery movement into politics and for repealing the black laws. Sounding much like Liberty Party leaders, Seward put equality at the center of his argument. Whigs recognized that "our democratic system ... is founded in the natural equality of all men—not alone all American men, nor alone all white men, but all MEN of every country, clime, and complexion, are equal—not made equal by human laws, but born equal." The black laws of Ohio, he said, like the laws requiring Black voters to meet a property requirement in his home state, reflected continuing "corruption" of the free states by slavery. He called on Ohio Whigs to stick with their party, to "inculcate ... the love of freedom and the equal rights of man" in their homes, to see that such values were taught in schools, and to reform their "own code" of laws.

Seward and the Ohio Whigs were right to worry about defections to the Free Soilers. When the election results were tallied, it became clear that Ohioans had sent eight Free Soilers to the legislature, most from the Western Reserve. The vote suggested that many antislavery Whig voters were now, like Giddings himself, tired of compromising. Most of the newly elected Free Soilers were former Whigs who retained strong Whig attachments, but two— Norton Townshend and John Morse—turned out to be genuinely independent. Morse was a former Whig and had even served in the legislature as a Whig, whereas Townshend, the longtime admirer of Chase, had been a Libertyite for as long as he had been involved in politics. Their distinct backgrounds notwithstanding, both men were prepared to stake their political reputations on using the third-party "balance of power" strategy to secure repeal of Ohio's black laws.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.070

# The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition

Manisha Sinha

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition |
| SELECTION | FOURTEEN: The Politics of Abolition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 464–465 · Yale University Press, 2016. |

## Excerpt

The political infl uence of the abolitionist Liberty Party on northern politics cannot be gauged by electoral bean counting. While it signifi cantly improved its national vote count in the presidential elections, growing steadily between 1840 and 1844 from 6,225 to nearly 62,000, it never came close to winning. Some Libertyites were better abolitionists than politicians, urging "moral action at the ballot box," and their perennial presidential nominee, James Birney, a reluctant candidate in 1840 who avoided campaigning, was not a huge electoral draw. Renominated in 1841, Birney started campaigning more, his letter of acceptance drawing attention to how slaveholders had used the federal government and Constitution to perpetuate their power as well as the persecution of African Americans, Native Americans, and Mormons. But as early as 1842 he avowed that not only the government and church but also the people themselves were corrupt. Birney's questioning of universal suffrage and his notion of giving immigrants the right to vote with "parsimony" made most abolitionists uncomfortable. Birney was specifi cally repudiating the "white man's democracy," swelled by the fi rst great wave of European immigration, which did not hesitate to trample on the rights of racial minorities. The attempt to expand the Liberty platform from the "one idea" of abolition by adding a variety of other economic and political issues resulted in further confusion. As Garrison argued, partisan politics proved to be uncongenial to abolitionism pure and simple. But as a political pressure group, abolitionists of all factions did infl uence northern politics.

Notwithstanding Libertyites' accusation that Garrisonians voted for "proslavery parties," many Liberty Party voters were rank-and-fi le Garrisonians who paid little heed to abolitionist organizational divisions. In 1841 the Liberty Party in Massachusetts even nominated the Garrisonians Francis Jackson as mayor, Nathaniel Rodgers and Wendell Phillips as aldermen of Boston, while Samuel Sewall, the Liberty Party gubernatorial candidate in Massachusetts, remained with the old organization. Many old organization men, Edmund Quincy complained, voted for the Liberty Party. The strongholds of abolition, Massachusetts, upstate New York, and Ohio, gave the Liberty Party its largest vote counts. Despite Garrison's personal aversion to electoral politics and public debates between Garrisonians and Libertyites, AASS lecturing agents helped to increase the new party's vote count. Abby Kelley and Douglass debated political abolitionists in upstate New York and Ohio, Kelley trying even, in copious letters, to convince the stalwart Libertyite Gerrit Smith to see the error of his ways. The lines between Garrisonians and the Liberty Party were still not well drawn in upstate New York or Ohio, Kelley reported. Giles Stebbins wrote to Gay that many Liberty men subscribed to the Garrisonian NASS.

Garrison thought Adams and Giddings took antislavery stances far ahead of those of most northern politicians and was thus more complimentary of them than of his abolitionist rivals in the Liberty Party, who, he argued, lowered the abolitionist standard by entering partisan politics. So carried away were Garrisonians in their praise of Adams, wrote Birney, that they had forgotten he was not an abolitionist. Garrison conceded the "purity of purpose" of Libertyites in private but strongly resisted converting the abolition movement into a political party. That did not prevent him from supporting antislavery politicians. In 1845 he sent MASS agents to work for the reelection of the antislavery Democratic representative John P. Hale in New Hampshire, who was read out of his party for his opposition to the annexation of Texas. To Garrison, the political place of abolitionists lay in agitation, to move the political center to the left, rather than in party politics. Smarting under Garrison's criticism for confi ning abolitionism to the ballot box, Libertyites accused the nonvoting Garrisonians of harboring a "covert design" to vote for the Whigs.

The abolitionist ideology of the Liberty Party converted Democratic rhetoric against the "money power" into a critique of the Slave Power and harnessed Whigs' statist beliefs to demand action by the federal government against slavery. Appearing as vice presidential nominees on its presidential ticket were antislavery Democrats such as Thomas Earle in 1840 and Thomas Morris in 1844. But Morris's reluctance to endorse black citizenship discomfi ted abolitionists. While antislavery Whigs stole the party's abolitionist thunder, the presidency of the proslavery "His Accidency" John Tyler after the death of the Whig president William Henry Harrison in 1841 vindicated the case for independent abolitionist politics. As Leavitt noted, South Carolinian and Virginian slaveholders such as Calhoun, Abel T. Upshur, and Waddy Thompson dominated Tyler's administration and plotted the annexation of Texas.

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Sinha, Manisha. *The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 2016.

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**Shortened citation:**

Sinha, *The Slave's Cause*, 464–465.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.071

# Ballots for Freedom: Antislavery Politics in the United States, 1837-1860

Richard H. Sewell

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|---|---|
| WORK | Ballots for Freedom: Antislavery Politics in the United States, 1837-1860 |
| SELECTION | “the right sort of politics” |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 8–9 · Oxford University Press, 1976. |

## Excerpt

There were many reasons for this willingness, shared by the vast majority of Liberty party pioneers, to support so inauspicious an enterprise. Foremost among them was the conviction that third party action was necessary to give point and purity to moral suasion. Slavery, as a moral evil entrenched in a political system, had to be attacked simultaneously on two fronts. To shun political weapons was morally irresponsible; to work within the major parties was morally contaminating. Hence the best course seemed to be to combine moral appeals with an independent politics designed to seek legislative cures for legislated evils. For voting abolitionists to come out from established “proslavery” parties would exalt their moral influence and greatly enhance the power of political abolitionism. “Such a universal sacrifice of party preferences among anti-slavery men,’ urged Bailey’s Philanthropist during the 1840 campaign, “would prove them possessed of the true martyr spirit. It would win for their cause a consideration that could be attained in no other way, and multiply adherents to it far more than a thousand lectures or high-sounding resolutions.... To vote right will be to proselyte.”® Once the Liberty party entered the field, its backers increasingly stressed its role as purifier of the political process. Far from corrupting those who endorsed it, the new party, by its adherence to lofty principle and disregard for boodle and swag, brought probity back to politics. Indeed, many argued that support for the Liberty party might regenerate individuals as well as political groups. “He who votes the liberty ticket,” insisted the Signal of Liberty, “and by the force of moral principle bids adicu to his old party influences, and in the face of opposition gives his suffrages for the cause of human rights, greatly benefits himself. He raises himself in the estimation of [his] community.” The notion that abolitionists would themselves become corrupted and lose moral power by engaging in party politics was the specious invention of “cunning and profligate officeseckers,” claimed the Boston Free American. It was designed “to keep honest men away from 4 Joseph P. Gazzam to James G. Birney, Feb. 7, 1843, Dumond (ed.), Birney Letters, II, 712.

5 Philanthropist, July 21, 1840. Sce also Philadelphia Pennsylvania Freeman, Feb. 1, 1844; Ann Arbor (Mich.) Signal of Liberty, Feb. 19, 1844; Edwin W. Clarke to Oswego Union Herald, Feb. 17, 1841, Slavery Manuscripts, Box I, NYHS. tain portion of the clergy, who unwisely took it as a high compliment to their religion—a religion too pure for any day but the Sabbath.” This theme of regeneration—regeneration of abolitionist souls and political standards as well as of collective morality on the slavery question—helped to bind many abolitionists to the Liberty party and to give it something of the flavor of a religious crusade.

Yet it is misleading to say that “the Liberty party had been created more as a religious crusade than as a political party,” or that the Bible was its “political textbook.”? For although religious conviction unquestionably underlay many men’s attachment to the new party, and scriptural quotations studded Liberty pronouncements, by no means all of the Liberty men were impractical moralists or political babes in the woods. Most possessed some understanding of political realities, and the hopes they held for their party, while often extragavant, were those of intelligent reformer-politicians, not those of doctrinaire visionaries unfit for the cold world of politics.

Nowhere was this realism more clear than in Liberty men’s conception of what their party ought to be. A few dreamed heady dreams of a party of freedom which in no time could elect up to a hundred antislavery Congressmen and intimidate the South into voluntary emancipation. “Every thing wears a new & glorious aspect,” gushed Alvan

Stewart in 1841. “The matter is absolutely settled that we must abolish slavery, & as sure as the sun rises we shall in 5 or 6 years run over Slavery at full gallop unless she pulls herself up & gets out of the way of Liberty’s cavalry.”® Most carly Liberty supporters, however, took a more modest view of their party’s potential.

6 Signal of Liberty, Sept. 22, 1841; Boston Free American, July 1, 1841. See also Philanthropist, Jan. 6, 1841; Signal of Liberty, Sept. 29, 1841. For a view of the Liberty party as a manifestation of “political come-outerism” explicitly designed “to enable the virtuous to symbolize their allegiance to God,” see Lewis Perry, “Versions of Anarchism in the Antislavery Movement,” American Quarterly, XX, No. 4 (Winter 1968), 779-80.

7Eric Foner, Free Soil, Free Labor, Free Men: The Ideology of the Republican Party Before the Civil War (New York, 1970), 78. For similar views see Dumond, Antislavery, 301; Wyatt-Brown, Tappan, 282n2; Perry, Radical Abolitionism, 166-87. 8 Stewart to Samuel Webb, Nov. 13, 1841, Stewart Papers, NYHS. A year later, after his strenuous labors had produced only meager gains for the Liberty party in New York, Stewart showed a gloomier side: “Slavery has undone us. She has crawled into the Constitution, has paralized [sic] the church, broken the compact, silenced petition, overthrown morality, blotted out humanity, really dissolved the confederacy & left the Nation undone.” Ibid. Oct. 10, 1842.

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**Footnote citation:**

Richard H. Sewell, *Ballots for Freedom: Antislavery Politics in the United States, 1837-1860* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1976), 8–9.

**Shortened citation:**

Sewell, *Ballots for Freedom*, 8–9.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.072

# Freedom's Ferment: Phases of American Social History from the Colonial Period to the Outbreak of the Civil War

Alice Felt Tyler

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|---|---|
| WORK | Freedom's Ferment: Phases of American Social History from the Colonial Period to the Outbreak of the Civil War |
| SELECTION | A Fire-Bell In The Night |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 489–490 · University of Minnesota Press, 1944. |

## Excerpt

When the third decade of the century opened, the antislavery movement had become an integral part of the larger humanitarian movement that was sweeping through the North. The condition of the free Negro in their midst, the plight of the fugitive slave, and the degradation of the slave in the South were all matters of concern to countless men and women who were filled with the spirit of the time. The humanitarian was preacher as well as social worker, dogmatist as well as pragmatist, and concerned with his own soul's salvation as well as with the well-being of his fellows. Slavery was a sin; from that original premise, progress to the doctrine that this sin must rest upon the consciences of all true Christians was inevitable.

At the same time these religious humanitarians were democrats with a deep conviction of the worth of the individual and of the equality of all men. There could be no greater violation of democracy than the institution of human slavery, no greater degradation for the individual than the auction block. Slavery was a denial, too, of the most elementary human rights, and in defense of slavery the South had attacked the safeguards that had been placed in the Constitution and in every Revolutionary bill of rights to protect the civil liberties which alone could guarantee the democratic way of life. Freedom of discussion was the lifeblood of democracy, and the denial of that freedom in respect to slavery was regarded as an attack upon liberties too vital to be surrendered without a struggle. Slavery thus became a menace to the white citizen and to the nonslavery North as well as to the South.

The abolitionist, when he showed any interest in the economic welfare of the Negro, contented himself with trying to establish his black protege in a position where he might earn his livelihood and with protecting him from too obvious exploitation. It was not until late in the pre-Civil War period, and then but dimly, that the white laborers of the North began to see that Negro slavery and wageslavery had something in common and that freeing the Negro would be of significance in the cause of labor. Lincoln seems to have had some idea of this when he wrote in 1863, "The strongest bond of human sympathy, outside the family relation, should be one uniting of all working people, of all nations, and tongues, and kindred"; and yet Lincoln even then was working for the colonization of the freedmen outside the United States.

The true significance of slavery in the United States to the whole social development of America lay in the ultimate relation of slaves to democracy. What were to be the limits of democratic control in the United States? If all labor, black as well as white, became free — were given schools and the right to vote — what control could or should be set to the power and action of these laborers? Was the rule of the mass of Americans to be unlimited, and the right to rule extended to all men regardless of race and color, or if not, what power of dictatorship and control; and how would property and privilege be protected?

For much of the period before the Civil War, however, Northern laborers resented black competition, and Western farmers were determined that the territories should be closed to slavery. "Free Soil" meant to them the absence of the Negro farmer and farm laborer.

From whatever sources the antislavery movement came, it was heavily tinged with the Puritan's somewhat sanctimonious concern with the conduct of others. The "holier than thou" attitude of the abolitionist, who insisted that slavery was a sin and the slaveowner a sinner of the deepest dye, was irritating to say the least. The composite picture of the slaveowner to be drawn from the "revelations" of the abolition tracts was that of a cruel and ruthless man, wielding the lash over helpless slaves, indulging his basest passions at the expense of the virtue of his female slaves, and selling his own offspring for profit. The injustice of the portrait and its effect in increasing the antagonism of the South did not deter the grim Puritans who drew it.

Fortunately not all the antislavery crusaders were of that kind. Revivalists coupled a practical interest in social betterment with their concern over the souls of their flocks. Charles G. Finney, greatest of the preachers of the Great Revival, declared that his converts "should set out with determination to aim at being useful in the highest degree possible."2 It is as difficult to depict a typical abolitionist as it is to picture a typical slaveowner.

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**Shortened citation:**

Tyler, *Freedom's Ferment*, 489–490.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.073

# Radical Spirits: Spiritualism and Women's Rights in Nineteenth-Century America

Ann Braude

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|---|---|
| WORK | Radical Spirits: Spiritualism and Women's Rights in Nineteenth-Century America |
| SELECTION | “Thine for Agitation” |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 7–8 · Beacon Press, 1989. |

## Excerpt

Although woman’s rights agitators held their own conventions during this period, the women who led these meetings remained a subgroup within the abolition movement. Although many of them had faith in spirit communication, with the exception of those who organized the very first conventions in New York State, most of these women did not publicly identify themselves with Spiritualism and did not contribute to its progress as a movement.® They perceived themselves as working for equal rights for all people, black and white, male and female, but their concerns remained secondary in the larger movement, which was aimed primarily at the abolition of slavery. The full implications of this subordinate status within the abolition movement did not become clear until after the Civil War, when women were asked to set aside their claims until full rights were secured by black men.

Because the woman’s rights movement was essentially ancillary to the abolition movement, internal and external developments affecting antislavery determined its course. Abolitionists set the agenda, and woman’s rights activists either followed their lead or reacted against it. During the Civil War period, non-Spiritualist woman’s rights advocates abandoned agitation for women. When Abraham Lincoln signed the Emancipation Proclamation, Elizabeth Cady Stanton and Susan B. Anthony immediately formed the Women’s Loyal League to lobby for a constitutional amendment outlawing slavery. Following the war, the struggle over the Fifteenth Amendment to the Constitution, granting voting rights to freed slaves, convinced the abolitionist woman’s movement that voting was the most important right for women to obtain and transformed the woman’s rights mover ment into the woman suffrage movement.™ Spiritualist agitators did not depend on the antislavery movement for resources or networks and did not determine their reform program in response to abolition. In contrast to their non-Spiritualist sisters, they did not abandon woman's rights agitation during the Civil War, nor did they assume a narrow focus on suffrage after the war. They continued to pursue the broad woman’s rights agenda of the 1850s, pressing for dress reform, marriage reform, and economic rights, all of which disappeared from the postwar suffrage movement.

Although Spiritualists universally condemned slavery, their organizational independence from abolition allowed them to assert that woman's rights should be the preeminent reform. Like other abollitionists, Spiritualists believed that the oppression of African Americans and of women stemmed from the same cause. A typical speaker “protested against the ownership of souls” and called for “freedom for the black man and the white woman.” While most abolitionists felt that the dire conditions of freed slaves required that their cause take priority even after the Civil War, some Spiritualists asserted that white women suffered the worst slavery. Both groups ignored the double disabilities of black women. As one male Spiritualist put it, he wanted “equality for all before the law, regardless of sex or color (and I place woman before the Negro).” Even a speech by “a colored gentleman,” an unusual event at a Spiritualist convention, endorsed universal suffrage, enfranchising African Americans and women simultaneously.

## Chicago Citations

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Braude, Ann. *Radical Spirits: Spiritualism and Women's Rights in Nineteenth-Century America*. Boston: Beacon Press, 1989.

**Footnote citation:**

Ann Braude, *Radical Spirits: Spiritualism and Women's Rights in Nineteenth-Century America* (Boston: Beacon Press, 1989), 7–8.

**Shortened citation:**

Braude, *Radical Spirits*, 7–8.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.074

# Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life: Vol. 2, The Public Years

Charles Capper

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|---|---|
| WORK | Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life: Vol. 2, The Public Years |
| SELECTION | 5. Concords and Discords |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 191–192 · Oxford University Press, 2007. |

## Excerpt

Nor in calling Fuller's book "the precursor of the Woman's Rights agitation of the last thirty-three years" (in Stanton's words) were these early feminists speaking in an intellectual vacuum; they were responding to real resonances between her outlook and theirs. First, there was the religious resonance: the book's liberal post-Christian perfectionism would broadly coincide, as the evangelically infused and Bible-centered abolitionists' rhetoric would not, with the almost uniformly liberal Protestant and freethinking views of most post–Civil War women's rights leaders. Second, there was the ideological tie. The book's central argument—that individual women had a right to autonomy not because the authority they would exercise was socially useful or uniquely benevolent but because they had universal rights as humans—was precisely the liberal principle whose espousal distinguished these feminists from their antebellum prefeminist predecessors. Third, while overlooking women's suffrage, her book's otherwise capacious application of those rights to women's education, employment, sexuality, and political discourse was also in harmony with the broad platform of the nineteenth-century's feminist movement. Fourth, there was Fuller's gender strategy: in her strong claim for the need for women's collective self-reliance, she prefigured the independent women's rights movement. And fifth, even the style of these early feminists, as displayed in their yearly conventions, mimicked the oratorical, testimonial, argumentative, and exuberant style of Fuller's book.[66]

Finally, there is the most intellectually important and underappreciated resonance of all: Fuller's Romantic idiom. Of course, like most nineteenth-century liberals, these early feminists intermixed a variety of warrants for their claims, from Enlightenment natural rights to utilitarian happiness and possessive individualist political economy. But especially in the feminist takeoff decade of the 1850s, during which a new edition of Woman in the Nineteenth Century sold in a few weeks in 1855 over three times as many copies as the first one had ten years earlier, the liberal Romantic strain vied, as never before or after, with these others. And to this strain Fuller contributed three critical concepts: individual self-development through studied introspection and boundless experience, social reform facilitated by organic spiritual conduits linking self and society, and transcendence through the infinitely contingent promise of the divinity's presence in the natural and historical world. Indeed, in various ways these concepts suffused several of the foundational feminist texts of the era. Stanton's "first 'set speech'" of 1848, a fiercely rationalist republican plea for woman's rights, concludes with Woman in the Nineteenth Century's final embattled chiliastic poem: "Though rabble rout may rush between,… / So shalt thou see what few have seen, / The palace home of King and Queen." "'Give me Truth. Cheat me by no illusion,'" the later (and by then religiously liberal) Sarah Grimké quoted from Fuller's recently published Memoirs in Grimké's remarkably Romantic-minded letter to the 1852 Woman's Rights Convention. "If our movement will adopt this slogan as its watchword," Grimké said, "it will overcome all obstacles, outlive all opposition." Although exevangelical ultraists like Grimké and political feminists like Stanton were hardly Romantics, insofar as they used Romantic concepts and tropes to defend women's rights and progress, Fuller's book was unquestionably the principal reason.[67]

These accents continued to resonate. Even in the later nineteenth-century era of spiritualism, positivism, and social science, Woman in the Nineteenth Century would be reprinted in substantial (if diminished) runs once or more every decade until the end of the century, after which it would not be published again until the beginning of revived interest in Fuller seventy-five years later. Indeed, the aged Stanton's last suffrage movement presidential address in 1892,

"The Solitude of the Self," rested her case for women's justice not on her age's Victorian pieties but on the lonely "individuality of each human soul"—a stoic harking back to the Romantic ethical core of Fuller's book. And even in these years, when younger feminist leaders often called for granting women the vote to counterbalance the votes of ignorant immigrants and workers, the feminist stream continued to bend in surprising Fullerlike ways. What, after all, were modernist feminist demands for men and women's "terrible honesty" in the 1920s, personal "liberation" in the 1960s, and, after that, the still salient integration of female "difference" and human "equality," if not a worldly return to the individualist and androgynous gender concerns that animated Fuller's restless Romantic seeking? It was a long swoop that the Romantic Fuller, who proclaimed "the soul is ever young, ever virgin," would have enjoyed.[68]

## Author's Notes

66. Quoted in to LGL, Oct. 21, 1849, ChiL, 250 ("She bought the boy"); to JFC, Jan. 9, 1845, FL, VI, 357 ("exceedingly disagreeable"); FL, V, 303 ("meddling curiosity"); Feb. 5, 1850, FL, VI, 53 ("not care for him"); ibid., 76–77 ("good deal of contempt").

67. July 19, 1850, "ON," 257 (de Staël); to SGW, Feb. 24, 1850, EL, VIII, 237 ("Margarita Marchesa"); Apr. 17, 1850, FMW, XI, 136 ("business & politics"); Love Marriage, and Divorce and the Sovereignty of the Individual: A Debate between Henry James, Horace Greeley, and Stephen Pearl Andrews, ed. Stephen Pearl Andrews (New York, 1853), 178 ("indissoluble"); EPP to Ellen D. Conway, June 28, 1880, PL, 402 ("a virgin still"); Feb. 6, 1850, FL, VI, 57 ("cloud of false rumors"). For the Duyckinck-Jones quarrel, see EAD to William A. Jones, William A. Jones to EAD, and Mrs. William A. Jones to EAD, August and September 1848, Duyckinck Family Papers, NN-M.

68. July 19, 1850, "ON," 256 ("What shall we do?"); MS to RWE, Apr. 7, 1850, Spring Papers, NjHi ("Marchioness Ossoli" and contacted Emerson); Apr. 25, 1848, EL, IV, 61 ("take the first steamer"); Apr. 11, 1850, ibid., 199 ("proposed book").

## Chicago Citations

### Bibliography entry:

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Capper, *Margaret Fuller*, 191–192.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.075

# Feminism and Suffrage: The Emergence of an Independent Women's Movement in America, 1848-1869

Ellen Carol DuBois

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|---|---|
| WORK | Feminism and Suffrage: The Emergence of an Independent Women's Movement in America, 1848-1869 |
| SELECTION | Feminism and Suffrage |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 32–33 · Cornell University Press, 1978. |

## Excerpt

Certainly women's rights leaders made liberal use of the slave metaphor to describe women's oppression. Yet women's discontent with their position was as much cause as effect of their involvement with the antislavery movement. What American women learned from abolitionism was less that they were oppressed than what to do with that perception, how to turn it into a political movement. Abolitionism provided them with a way to escape clerical authority, an egalitarian ideology, and a theory of social change, all of which permitted the leaders to transform the insights into the oppression of women which they shared with many of their contemporaries into the beginnings of the women's rights movement.

Women's involvement in abolitionism developed out of traditions of pietistic female benevolence that were an accepted aspect of women's sphere in the early nineteenth century. The feminist militance of Sarah and Angelina Grimké and the women who succeeded them was rooted in this common soil. The abolitionist movement was one of the many religious reforms that grew out of evangelical Protestantism. For the movement's first half-decade, the role women had in it was consistent with that in other benevolent religious efforts such as urban missionary activities and moral reform. Women organized separate antislavery auxiliaries, in which they worked to support men's organizations and gave particular attention to the female victims and domestic casualties of slavery. The Grimkés entered abolitionism on these terms."® Unlike other pious activisms, however, abolition had an unavoidably political thrust and a tendency to outgrow its evangelical origins. As the movement became secularized, so did the activities of benevolent women in it. "Those who urged women to become missionaries and form tract societies... have changed the household utensil to a living, energetic being," wrote domestic author and abolitionist Lydia Maria Child, "and they have no spell to turn it into a broom again."*" The emergence of the Garrisonian wing of the abolitionist movement embodied and accelerated these secularizing processes. In 1837 William Lloyd Garrison was converted by utopian John Humphrey Noyes to the doctrine of perfectionism, which identified the sanctified individual conscience as the supreme moral standard, and corrupt institutions, not people, as the source of sin. In particular, Garrisonians turned on their churchly origins and attacked the Protestant clergy for its perversion of true Christianity and its support of slavery."® Garrisonians' ability to distinguish religious institutions from their own deeply-felt religious impulses was an impressive achievement for evangelicals in an evangelical age. The reformulation of antislavery strategy around these beliefs drew Hicksite Quakers, liberal Unitarians, ultraist come-outers, and a disproportionate number of women activists.

The clergy was the major force that controlled women's moral energies and kept pietistic activism from becoming political activism. Garrisonian anticlericalism was therefore critical to the emergence of abolitionist feminism and its subsequent development into the women's rights movement.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

DuBois, Ellen Carol. *Feminism and Suffrage: The Emergence of an Independent Women's Movement in America, 1848-1869*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1978.

**Footnote citation:**

Ellen Carol DuBois, *Feminism and Suffrage: The Emergence of an Independent Women's Movement in America, 1848-1869* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1978), 32–33.

**Shortened citation:**

DuBois, *Feminism and Suffrage*, 32–33.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.076

# The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement

Julie Roy Jeffrey

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement |
| SELECTION | feared her work might be harmful to her newborn baby, whom she was |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of North Carolina Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

rier commitment had personal and familial costs. She found organizing the fair a “physical drudgery” and feared her work might be harmful to her newborn baby, whom she was nursing. “Sleepless nights and anxious distressed days are not calculated to give a healthy constitution to my baby,” she worried. Moreover, the storage of fair items in her home disrupted domestic life and was contrary to her husband’s “wishes—his pride.” As Sarah discovered, stress was part and parcel of abolitionism.?’

Mary Stil (1808-89), an African American who left traces of her abo- > litionist activities, was the daughter of a former slave from Maryland and‘ his fugitive wife. She grew up in New Jersey and, like four of her siblings, moved to Philadelphia. In the late 1840s, she kept a school for black children there and became involved in the life of Philadelphia’s black community. As a member of the Female Union Publication Society of Philadelphia, an organization affiliated with the African Methodist Episcopal Church, she helped raise money for publications that contributed “to the improvement and elevation of our people.” Her professional and organizational commitments, like her abolitionism, helped to establish her place in the city’s black middle class. During the war, she volunteered to teach freed slaves. Heading south, she found her “heart... very sad” and realized that “T have desided hastily about going so far from home alone.” Although the climate in South Carolina proved problematic for her health, the enthusiasm of her pupils lifted her spirits. She adapted so well to her important work that in 1869 she moved to another American Missionary Association school in Florida, where she remained until 1872.24

The contributions of these and countless other women to abolitionism’ reveal the varied and important part they played in the most significant reform before the Civil War. Herbert Aptheker points out that abolitionism was the first major social movement to involve women in all aspects of the work. What he does not emphasize enough, however, is what many of the ean ates Sanne 6 leaders realized: without women abolitionism would have been far more Jeaders realized: without women, marginal a movement for change than it was.’ = This book follows a thematic and T roughly c chronological approach. he an poem eam - ~Chapter. 1 focuses.on the 1830s and the efforts abolitionist leaders made t to_ n had already demong free produce movements or ‘Geb writing iting antislavery nee for p publication, William Lloyd Garrison _did not initially expect women to play a great part in abolitionism. Gradually he became aware of the benefits of their assis —— ann, e and began to urge — ee ee eee ee 5 _and 1 joined female antislavery societies. Chapter 2 explores women *S EX- _perience in abolitionist organizations in the 1830s and the ways in which enous a “they 1 met the challenges of organizational life. Active membership in an “antislavery society and involvement in its projects demanded skills and attitudes that moved women beyond the conventional boundaries of middleclass female life. Petitioning, the central work for many antislavery societies, exemplifies the ways in which women confronted social norms in the cause of duty.

The division of the national antislayery movement in 1840 created a new set of circumstances for abolitionist women. Chapter 3 focuses on en ene _the i impact of dissension and disunion on women working for immediate emancipation in the 1840s and 1850s. S Some societies disbanded, while others managed to struggle along, often with reduced numbers. Women often felt beleaguered and isolated, although they may have felt more isolated than they were in fact. During these decades, the communications network, initiated in the 1830s, played a crucial role in

connecting women to one another and to abolitionism. This network also facilitated the antislavery fair, the great work of the 1840s and 1850s. Chapter 33 argues that women's fairs made an important contribution to the survival of antislavery and enmeshed women in the commercial world. The 1 role of work, especially handwork, in sustaining enthusiasm i is a significant theme i in the "discussion of fairs and women's assistance to ) fugitive slaves.

Chapters 4 and 5 explore different aspects of female activism in the _1840s and 1850s. Chapter 4 follows women's paths in Christian and politi "cal abolitionism and shames slsows they spoke: out it against "proslavery" reli- ~ duty allowed them to redefine what was "required of them as abolitionists and as women. Chapter 5 describes the response of women to the __crises of the 1850s. By the 1850s, female activism included working in the underground railroad and lecturing for the antislavery cause. Sources are abundant enough for this period to demonstrate the involvement of black women in all aspects of antislavery, including public lecturing. During a decade of continuing crises over the expansion of slavery, northerners proved more tolerant of women's public participation in the antislavery crusade than they had been during the 1830s.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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**Footnote citation:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Jeffrey, *The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism*, no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.077

# The Myth of Seneca Falls: Memory and the Women's Suffrage Movement, 1848-1898

Lisa Tetrault

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Myth of Seneca Falls: Memory and the Women's Suffrage Movement, 1848-1898 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of North Carolina Press, 2014. |

## Excerpt

WHEN, THEN, DID SENECA FALLS EMERGE as the main story with a codified, familiar structure? And why? How did the meeting at Seneca Falls become the myth of Seneca Falls? In what ways did that story, that origins myth, serve as a collective political resource for post-Civil War feminists? And—if stories are actors, essential to mounting resistance campaigns — what type of movement did it help produce? Lastly, how and why did Stanton and Anthony use this story to intervene in broader national memory debates after the Civil War, and with what outcome? These are the central questions of this book. It unravels the tangled skeins of suffragists' collective memories to recover the politics behind this creation legend and its ultimate effects.

It examines how suffragists responded to the fraught politics of the late 1860s by creating a trial in 1850, not Seneca Falls in 1848, as the origin of the campaign, revealing how fungible the question of beginnings still was. Chapters two and three explore the sprawling, expanding, and chaotic movement politics over the early 1870s, which left Stanton and Anthony on the defensive more often than they would have liked. So they began tentatively, and then more decisively, sketching out a Seneca Falls origins narrative to try gaining traction in the sprawling postwar movement. Partly because of the eventual triumph of a Seneca Falls origins narrative, which foregrounded woman suffrage and a federal strategy as the pinnacle of a rights agenda, much of the vital debate over what a women's rights agenda should be in the postwar era has been lost—or at least scattered into a host of separate, unconnected stories. Chapters two and three integrate that history back into the story of how a postwar women's suffrage agenda developed and examine how Stanton and Anthony, who faced challenges in every direction, used an increasingly codified Seneca Falls narrative to intervene in that process.

Those magisterial volumes were their most definitive statement of a Seneca Falls origins myth, their most robust intervention in post-Civil War memory politics, and their most righteous insistence that the deeds of women would not go unrecognized or unrewarded by anything less than full citizenship. Here, they used Seneca Falls to lay out an alternative memory of the Civil War, a hitherto unrecognized suffragist memory, which defies scholars' efforts to map memory politics of this era as defined by a battle between an emancipationist memory, on the one hand, and a white supremacist memory, on the other. Chapter five argues that the maturation of a Seneca Falls mythology by 1890 helped to fundamentally transform the movement and lift Anthony to the pinnacle of that reorganized movement. After this, it would be harder and harder to see these middle decades without the veil of the collective memories that suffragists built around them. To see through that veil, we must first recover the history of those memories themselves, memories that were born in the immediate, tension-filled aftermath of the American Civil War.

## Chicago Citations

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**Footnote citation:**

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.078

# Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872

Nancy A. Hewitt

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 170–171 · Cornell University Press, 1984. |

## Excerpt

Corinthian Hall was “nearly filled” as Rose extolled the virtues of the ‘“woman’s rights movement, which claims equality for all the sons and daughters of man” and proclaimed it ‘“one link in the chain of progressive reform.” She then claimed for women not only the right to vote but also “the privilege of being voted for.’

On November 30 and December 1, woman’s rights advocates again met in Rochester, devoting their attention to “Woman’s legal and civil disabilities.” This time they adopted a plan for a massive petition campaign to extend the reforms already made in the “barbarous usages of Common Law .. . until every vestige of partiality be removed” from New York State law.” For the remainder of the decade, woman’s rights activities centered around the universal improvement of women’s political and property rights through legislation and on individual women’s achievements in new fields of endeavor. Thus local feminists, who had applauded Elizabeth Blackwell's graduation from medical school at their 1848 convention, were pleased to note in 1851 that the nation’s second woman medical school graduate was Rochesterian Sarah R. Adamson. In September 1853 Antoinette Brown became one of the first ordained women pastors in the country, occupying a pulpit in South Butler near Rochester. Her ultraist neighbors invited her to address their convention in November, the same month that she presided at the marriage of Rhoda DeGarmo’s daughter.“ While receiving less widespread attention, Sarah Anthony Burtis’s pioneering efforts affected the lives of greater numbers of women: she broke the male-dominated ranks of store clerks and thereby opened a whole new field of employment to local women.”

As ultraist women became more outspoken on their own behalf, they lost some of their early coworkers. This time the women who retreated from ultraist circles did not also retreat from the antislavery cause, but they refused to combine abolitionism with feminism. One such woman was Phoebia Pickard, whose husband, Daniel, had been a vocal critic of woman’s equality within the family at the Rochester Woman’s Rights Convention of 1848.

The women themselves were generally younger than their more militant counterparts who remained in the WNYASS. ‘They were more likely to have been raised outside agrarian Quaker communities, to reside outside farm families, and to attend the | Unitarian Church rather than the Congregational Friends meeting.”

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Hewitt, Nancy A. *Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1984.

**Footnote citation:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Hewitt, *Women's Activism and Social Change*, 170–171.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.079

# American Reformers, 1815-1860

Ronald G. Walters

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|---|---|
| WORK | American Reformers, 1815-1860 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 23–24 · Hill and Wang, 1997. |

## Excerpt

Evangelicals also battled one another. In 1827 things reached such a bad pass between Western revivalists led by Finney, and Easterners clustered around Lyman Beecher, that they held a nine-day peace conference. It failed. With his customary vigor, Beecher warned Finney not to enter Massachusetts. He recalled saying, "As the Lord liveth, I'll meet you at the State line, and call out all the artillerymen, and fight every inch of the way to Boston, and then I'll fight you there."

Despite hostility and dissension in its own ranks, revivalism was the core of antebellum Protestantism. It was the faith of people as far apart socially and geographically as rude Kentucky backwoodsmen and wealthy New York merchants. It flowed across denominational lines and appeared in all the major Protestant sects, muddling distinctions between them. In times of awakenings, Baptists, freewill Methodists, and predestinarian Presbyterians muted their disagreements and became brothers and sisters in spirit. Laypersons and clergy changed from one denomination to another, with little effort. What counted more to believers than creeds and doctrines was whether a church was for or against revivals. In some guise or another, evangelical Protestantism was the religion of most Americans.

Connections between revivalism and reform were obvious at the time and have been much emphasized by historians ever since. Evangelical clergy and laity engaged in moral crusades of their own and led secular ones, for example, temperance and antislavery. Revivalistic institutions such as Lane Seminary and Oberlin College were breeding grounds for reformers, many of whom had been inspired by Beecher and Finney. In regions like the Western Reserve of Ohio and the Burned-Over District of New York, reform movements followed close on the heels of hellfire preaching. Even voting statistics bear out the correlation, with, for instance, the abolitionist Liberty Party doing best in areas where religious enthusiasm had run high.

Not only that: many reforms had strong support from such nonevangelical sects as the Quakers and Unitarians. Some crusades, notably communitarianism and spiritualism, were especially attractive to freethinkers and atheists. Deism, with its mechanistic God and skepticism about doctrine and clergy, had a following in labor reform, where an eighteenth-century tradition of artisan radicalism and rationalism remained vital.

Even among evangelical reformers, Christianity was not the only source of intellectual and emotional stimulation. Many looked to science, natural law, and American political traditions, as well as the Bible, for inspiration. All reformers buttressed their arguments with enlightenment humanitarianism, the republican rhetoric of the American Revolution, and the sentimental conventions of the day. Yet it was evangelical Protestantism that provided much of the ideological and organizational foundation for antebellum reform.

Beginning in the early twentieth century, popular critics of revivalism such as H. L. Mencken made it seem the simple-minded epitome of anti-intellectualism. This gulf between intellectuals and radicals on one side and revivalism on the other, however, made it easy to forget the complex and sophisticated role evangelical Protestantism played in the history of ideas. It grew out of—and produced—impressive theological debates and permeated much eighteenth- and nineteenth-century social, moral, economic, political, and scientific thought. What mattered most for reform, nonetheless, was a handful of highly generalized beliefs, held in one form or another by all evangelicals. These were usually not formal doctrines (although they could be); more often, they were half-articulated

assumptions about society, human beings, and the future.

The Second Great Awakening raised expectations that the Kingdom of God on earth was imminent. Similar notions appeared during the first Great Awakening and had surfaced throughout the centuries, but the quickening of religious fervor after 1800 seemed a sure sign to many Americans that the new day was dawning.

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**Shortened citation:**

Walters, *American Reformers, 1815-1860*, 23–24.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.080

# The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement

Julie Roy Jeffrey

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Great Silent Army of Abolitionism: Ordinary Women in the Antislavery Movement |
| SELECTION | the villages—and the smaller cities in the interior." |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of North Carolina Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

1835, after Theodore Weld's lecture in Austinburg, Ohio, 150 women were so solemnly impressed by "the reality, extent, & unspeakable evils of the system of Slavery" that they formed the Ashtabula County (Ohio) Female Anti-Slavery Society and formally signed their names under the society's constitution. Less impressive in terms of numbers but similar in terms of dynamics was the experience of women in Dighton, Massachusetts. Although "their was not more than three or four who had thought much on the subject of slavery," the eloquence of English lecturer George Thompson was so moving that twenty-three women formed an antislavery society.* Such public rites had overtones of an evangelical revival meeting. Given the background of antislavery lecturers, many of whom were ministers or had contemplated entering the church, the evangelical atmosphere was predictable. Like sinners poised on the anxious seat, exhorted to come forward and be saved, those listening to antislavery lectures were urged to come forward and commit themselves to the holy cause of abolitionism.? Though a spellbinding outside lecturer could act as the catalyst for the ceremony of commitment, local women might orchestrate the event.

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.081

# Women and the Work of Benevolence: Morality, Politics, and Class in the Nineteenth-Century United States

Lori D. Ginzberg

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Women and the Work of Benevolence: Morality, Politics, and Class in the Nineteenth-Century United States |
| SELECTION | + “Her Strongest Moral Organ” * |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 18–19 · Yale University Press, 1990. |

## Excerpt

Furthermore, no matter what the goals of women, an analysis that conflated femininity and morality contained within it both conservative and radical implications for the work of female activists themselves. As Nancy Cott, Barbara Berg, and others have shown, the insistence on women’s shared characteristics and experience could constitute a conservative defense of existing sexual inequality but it could also provide the basis for women’s organizing on their own behalf.[18] These radical and conservative possibilities were always in tension: the very assertion of an identity based on female morality carried within it both the conservative imperative to conform and a more radical call to define and act upon women’s needs.! Within the same movement, organization, or, indeed, individual, the contradictory implications of female benevolence tangled its adherents (and later historians) in a web of ideology and interest that included, in the context of the antebellum period, not only identities of gender but those of class and cause as well. The female moral reform movement of the 1830s and 1840s illustrates explicitly how the ideology of benevolent femininity could convey the need and strategy for fundamental change in sexual behavior and standards in the antebellum United States even as it expressed an emerging class identity. In this case, a campaign against “vice” underpinned an attack on a wide range of social ills, including a transformation of male- and money-dominated society itself on the basis of traits that were supposedly characteristic of women. Founded in 1834, the New York Female Moral Reform Society and its hundreds of branches sought on one level simply to end prostitution, a campaign at which they were extraordinarily ineffective. More broadly, the movement advocated a single—“female”—standard of sexual behavior and urged its adherents to ostracize “licentious” men as they did “fallen” women.20° Moral reformers’ descriptions of their visits to women provide a glimpse of the radical potential of women’s assertion of their own supposed difference from men, not so much because they identified with poor women and prostitutes as because of the way in which they understood worth by a different standard from that presumably adhered to by men. By describing women as victims in a lustful society—and men as the very personification of that lust—they sought to define respectability itself not by wealth, which they insisted was tenuous and under men’s control, but by women’s own virtues. Female moral reformers blamed a bewildering array of societal circumstances for the seeming spread of licentiousness. Dancing, theater, long visits with men, foreigners, masturbation, and, especially, love for dress were constant temptations. Sarah R., for example, refused to abandon life as a prostitute: “The passion for dress was too strong to permit her to hesitate long about the means of gratifying it,” explained the Advocate of Moral Reform. “Popery,” idleness, and drink added fuel to an explosive moral situation.?!

## Author's Notes

18. Cott, Bonds of Womanhood; Barbara J. Berg, The Remembered Gate: Origins of American Feminism: The Woman and the City, rt800—1860 (New York: Oxford University Press, 1978). This is not to suggest that women who organized for moral reform would later become advocates of woman's rights. As Anne Boylan has demonstrated convincingly, participation in conservative benevolent work did not lead women into more radical, or feminist, activity. The development of a feminist strain of reform was ideologically distinct and reflected a different social group's political interests rather than a linear transition. See her "Women in Groups: An Analysis of Women's Benevolent Organizations in New York and Boston, 1797—1840," Journal of American History 71 (December 1984): 497-523.

## Chicago Citations

### Bibliography entry:

Ginzberg, Lori D. *Women and the Work of Benevolence: Morality, Politics, and Class in the Nineteenth-Century United States*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1990.

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Ginzberg, *Women and the Work of Benevolence*, 18–19.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.082

# Cradle of the Middle Class: The Family in Oneida County, New York, 1790-1865

Mary P. Ryan

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|---|---|
| WORK | Cradle of the Middle Class: The Family in Oneida County, New York, 1790-1865 |
| SELECTION | The era of association |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 123–124 · Cambridge University Press, 1981. |

## Excerpt

Under cover of privacy, without benefit of official encouragment, in association with one another, women exerted real social power and engineered major social change. This was especially true of the groups like the Female Moral Reform Society and the Maternal Association that arose during the 1830s in the wake of revivalism. The social consequence of these women's associations is nowhere more convincingly evidenced than in the fearful reactions of the Universalists. In 1827 the Evangelical Magazine and Gospel Advocate was almost jocular in its attack on women reformers. They were simply comical village do-gooders. By 1835 the editor had changed his tune considerably. Female associations now appeared as dangerous weapons of religious conservatives.

Universalists were being seduced into attending gatherings arranged by benevolent evangelical women. Once within the viselike grasp of the Presbyterian faction, these young women lured their sisters, brothers, beaux, and even parents in the same direction. Such, according to the alarmist Universalists, was the nefarious web of the women's reform network: "The circle spreads and enthey are opposed to liberal principles but because they love society and prefer going with the multitudes."

Advocate, were responsible for the "overwhelming balance of numbers" maintained by conservative churches: "The secret is contained in the well-directed energies of some half-dozen active and zealous females."

Universalism asked every mother to "put the question seriously and concisely to themselves - whether they had rather devote a few hours once or twice a month to social and religious purposes or con- The sources of this power deserve more historical attention than a single community study can provide. The bits of biographical information about the three major leaders of Utica's women's groups do, however, offer some important clues. All three leaders were married, but none of them were burdened with the full set of duties of the mistress of a large household. Neither Fanny Skinner nor Paulina Wright bore any children. Sophia Clarke was a mother of three, but an independently wealthy widow. More important, all three women must have gained support from one another, for they were part of the same circle of active Presbyterian women that had well. Sophia Clarke worked through family contacts that extended back to Connecticut, and then carried her influence on to a second generation in the activities of her children Erastus and Susan, as well as her nephews Edward Vernon and, of course, Theodore Weld. Sophia Clarke also lived conveniently next door to the First Presbyterian Church and parsonage. Fanny Skinner parlayed her connections as a boardinghouse keeper into the major support group for moral reform. Fanny Skinner's resourcefulness was forged amid family necessity. Her husband, as the local histories tell it, was once a promising young lawyer who quickly fell upon bad times and was largely supported by his wife. Fanny Skinner, interestingly enough, proselytized quite effectively for moral reform among the young law students who boarded with her.

The third major leader of women's association in Utica, Paulina Wright, came to the cause almost a generation later than Clarke and Skinner. She arrived in Utica to begin her reforming career buoyed up by the reform beliefs and merchant wealth of her husband, Francis Wright. She immediately familiarized herself with the women's network that had been built up by her sisters in the Presbyterian Church. Paulina Wright pumped that network for every reforming supporter she could find. She went the familiar women's route from door to door, promoting moral reform, distributing temperance tion in support of the Married Women's Property Act. The women's network of

Oneida County could, in the end, even lead to the borders of conscious feminism.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Ryan, Mary P. *Cradle of the Middle Class: The Family in Oneida County, New York, 1790-1865*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1981.

**Footnote citation:**

Mary P. Ryan, *Cradle of the Middle Class: The Family in Oneida County, New York, 1790-1865* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1981), 123–124.

**Shortened citation:**

Ryan, *Cradle of the Middle Class*, 123–124.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.083

# Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872

Nancy A. Hewitt

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 55–56 · Cornell University Press, 1984. |

## Excerpt

As they entered public paths on errands of mercy, few fellow townsmen would accuse them of stepping outside their sphere, for Rochester's early ladies bountiful were precisely those women who were chargd with defining the proper place of their sex In community life.

For men, business and political networks based on kinship declined under economic and party pressures in the 1830s.* For women, the strength of associated effort prevailed. In the face of turmoils among male kin that rent the fabric of local economic and political life, benevolent women forged bonds of community that bridged differences of nativity, faith, and family. For benevolent women, who were largely removed from direct participation in productive labor and political office, commonalities of wealth and status overshadowed competition for profits and party leadership. It was in large part through these woman-based kin networks that patterns of activism were replicated and extended across time and into new organizations. Finally, these family networks, which in benevolent activity joined together women of the professional and merchant class in ameliorative efforts, would be reproduced by kinswomen of other social and economic strata in pursuit of other social goals during the 1830s, 1840s, and 1850s."

The Finney-led revivals of the early 1830s, for instance, inspired large numbers of men and women to join in movements to eradicate immorality and thereby hasten the millennium. The female leaders of these perfectionist campaigns often had ties of membership and kinship to the CS, yet they represented a distinct economic and social sector. Susan Farley Porter, a CS member from her arrival in Rochester in one such leader. Samuel D. Porter moved to Rochester in 1827 to clerk in Everard Peck's store. He traveled to Waldoborough, Maine, in 1835 to marry Susan Farley, and the couple returned to a comfortable life among Rochester's younger and upwardly mobile second generation of settlers."

9For a very suggestive analysis of the role of family networks in reproducing social order, see Pierre Bourdieu, "Marriage Strategies as Strategies of Social Reproduction," in Orest Ranum and Elborg Forster, eds., Family and Society: Selections from the Annales (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1976), pp. 117-44.

# Generation refers partly to age since many of the settlers of the 1830s were younger members of first-settled families; but more generally, it indicates families who moved to Rochester after 1825 when the pioneer familial, economic, and political network had clearly been established.

The Porters, like the Pecks, were active in church affairs but were more closely tied to the newer evangelical congregations than to Rochester's first churches. Samuel converted under Charles Grandison Finney in 1831; Susan appears to have undergone conversion upon her arrival in Rochester. In 1836 both Samuel and Susan joined other dissenters from First and Third Presbyterian churches to form a Bethel Free Church. The "active Christianity" advocated by the Bethel founders was grounded in the perfectionist tenets of Finneyite Evangelicalism, tenets that were also reflected in perfectionist campaigns for temperance, abolition, and moral reform.*!

The women who led these campaigns mirrored the kin networks of their benevolent counterparts, although because they were younger and more recently arrived in Rochester, the extent of their networks was more circumscribed in the early 1830s. By 1837 when the women of the Rochester Female Anti-Slavery Society circulated two massive

antislavery petitions throughout Monroe County, female family groups were clearly at the center of perfectionist activism. The name of Mrs. Susan Porter was joined by those of her sisters Martha Farley Peck, Elizabeth Farley, and Delia Farley and sisters-in-law Almira, Mary Jane, and Maria G. Porter. Mrs. Chloe Bullen signed beneath her daughter, Mrs. Mary Hoyt, on the 1837 petition as she had on the FASS's 1835 constitution. Mrs. Abigail Moore, Mrs. Silas Cornell, and Mrs. Russell Green also joined daughters on the 1837 petition, while Martha Bullen, Phebe Cornell, and Mrs. Almira Galusha joined sistersin-law. Clusters of Greens, Wests, VanHoustons, Seelyes, Allings, Allyns, Goulds, Reids, and Underhills also appeared. Though some of these names were common in Rochester, clustering suggests at least residential proximity, visiting, or shared sites of worship since those were the circumstances in which petitions were likely to circulate."

'Samuel Drummond Porter to Pastor, Washington Street Presbyterian Church, 29 September 1845, SDPFP. Detailed information of FASS and FMRS participants exists only for the leaders of the associations, thus generalizations here are based primarily on their characteristics.

"The local 1837 women's petition campaign contained signatures from throughout Rochester and the surrounding county of Monroe: presented 30 January 1837 and 19 September 1837, House of Representatives Document HR25A-H1.8, Library of Congress, Box 83. I thank Paul Johnson for reference to this source.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Hewitt, Nancy A. *Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1984.

**Footnote citation:**

Nancy A. Hewitt, *Women's Activism and Social Change: Rochester, New York, 1822-1872* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1984), 55–56.

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Hewitt, *Women's Activism and Social Change*, 55–56.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.084

# Strangers and Pilgrims: Female Preaching in America, 1740-1845

Catherine A. Brekus

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Strangers and Pilgrims: Female Preaching in America, 1740-1845 |
| SELECTION | 3 Female Preaching in the Early Nineteenth Century |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 157–158 · University of North Carolina Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

This concern with plain clothing was symbolic of a far greater quarrel with the values of the world. Most of the early Freewill Baptists, Christians, Methodists, and African Methodists belonged to the lower or lower-middling classes, and they were deeply ambivalent about the social and economic changes wrought by the market revolution. By preaching an ethic of Christian love over economic ambition, these sects tried to resist the incursions of capitalism. Although they were far less radical than the Shakers, who abolished private property in favor of communism, they still tried to shield their members from the worst excesses of the market. When the first Freewill Baptist church was founded in 1780, the "brothers" and "sisters" signed a covenant pledging that "they should not follow the customs of the world in trade, but do as they would be done by, and not as they are done by." Modeling themselves on the early Christians, they also agreed not to sue other believers and to "admonish the covetous." Above all, they swore to preserve the element of "protest" in Protestantism by renouncing all of the vanities and temptations of the world. Preaching an ethic of resistance rather than accommodation, they solemnly swore not to "conform to the world in its customs, fashions, and idle conversation; nor countenance them who do, but rather reprove them.'

## Chicago Citations

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Catherine A. Brekus, *Strangers and Pilgrims: Female Preaching in America, 1740-1845* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1998), 157–158.

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Brekus, *Strangers and Pilgrims*, 157–158.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.085

# The Myth of Seneca Falls: Memory and the Women's Suffrage Movement, 1848-1898

Lisa Tetrault

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Myth of Seneca Falls: Memory and the Women's Suffrage Movement, 1848-1898 |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | supplied PDF 150–151 · University of North Carolina Press, 2014. |

## Excerpt

For example, the History included a rendition of Sojourner Truth's speech before an 1850s Ohio women's rights convention. The speech is recounted by a white woman, Frances Dana Gage, who recalls a supposedly thrilling moment when Truth stood and spoke, salvaging the cause of women's rights.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Tetrault, Lisa. *The Myth of Seneca Falls: Memory and the Women's Suffrage Movement, 1848-1898*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2014.

**Footnote citation:**

Lisa Tetrault, *The Myth of Seneca Falls: Memory and the Women's Suffrage Movement, 1848-1898* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2014), supplied PDF 150–151.

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Tetrault, *The Myth of Seneca Falls*, supplied PDF 150–151.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.086

# White Women's Rights: The Racial Origins of Feminism in the United States

Louise Michele Newman

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | White Women's Rights: The Racial Origins of Feminism in the United States |
| SELECTION | Introduction °* |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 17–18 · Oxford University Press, 1999. |

## Excerpt

Second, white women, who previously had been seen by evolutionists like Charles Darwin and Herbert Spencer as inferior to white men—and thus held responsible for retarding the progress of white civilization—were suddenly transformed by theorists like Lester Ward, Otis Mason, and Charlotte Perkins Gilman into "racial conservators." White women now supposedly provided the racial stability that ensured the nation's future "racial progress," so the country could proceed with its imperial projects. This theoretical redefining of white women's role meant that white men were more free to cross the color line sexually, without there being any risk of white racial degeneration, as long as white women kept having adequate numbers of white offspring. Any decline in white women's fertility, however, was interpreted as a tremendous social problem, leading to "race suicide." (See figure 1-1 in chapter 1.) Miscegenation between white women and black men was deemed to be so threatening to whites' racial future that many whites found it inconceivable that white women would voluntarily have sex with black men. White women's traditional role as "mothers of the race" along with their new role as conservators of the race made them crucially important to the successful carrying out of US. colonial projects.

## Chicago Citations

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Newman, Louise Michele. *White Women's Rights: The Racial Origins of Feminism in the United States*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1999.

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**Shortened citation:**

Newman, *White Women's Rights*, 17–18.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.087

# The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition

Manisha Sinha

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Slave's Cause: A History of Abolition |
| SELECTION | FIVE: Black Abolitionists in the Slaveholding Republic |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 140–141 · Yale University Press, 2016. |

## Excerpt

To recognize Thatcher's lone effort in Congress to gain black Americans a hearing, Forten wrote a public letter to him in 1800. Forten was the third party of the triumvirate that included Jones and Allen that led black antislavery efforts in Philadelphia. Schooled at the Friends' Free African School, Forten rose from apprenticeship to acquire his master's sailmaking business. A wealthy sailmaker who had white and black apprentices working for him, he became a preeminent advocate for black rights and bankrolled Garrison's the Liberator. Forten's letter is notable not only because he recognized Thatcher's vote but also because he laid out the black abolitionist program of emancipation and black rights: "Seven hundred thousand [approximately the number of African Americans in the United States according to the Census of 1790] of the human race were concerned in our Petition; their thanks, their gratitude to you they now express... we derive some comfort from the thought that... there is one who shall use all his endeavours to free the slave from captivity... and preserve the free black in the full enjoyment of his rights." Challenging racist aspersions, he reasoned, "Though our faces are black, yet we are men; and though many of us cannot write, yet we all have the feelings and passions of men, and are as anxious to enjoy the birth-right of the human race."[23]

Blacks in New York matched the organizational and antislavery activism of those in Philadelphia. As early as the seventeenth century black New Yorkers sought to ensure the proper burial of their deceased, who were excluded from white church cemeteries. They formed a religious society that became the African Society in 1784. By 1795 the original Negro Burial Ground was destroyed. That year the African Society petitioned the New York Council for land to build a church and cemetery, and a year later black Methodists, including such prominent leaders as Peter Williams Sr., James Varick, and William Hamilton, began holding independent prayer meetings. In 1799 they seceded from the John Street Methodist Church and the next year built the African Methodist Episcopal (AME) Zion Church. Williams and the itinerant Methodist preacher George White, among others, signed its charter and articles of agreement. Despite an attempt led by White and Abraham Thompson to join Allen's denomination, Varick decided to form a new denomination, the AME Zion. It seceded from the Methodist Conference, was incorporated in 1820, established its own doctrine and discipline, and elected Thompson and Varick as elders. In 1828 Christopher Rush was elected superintendent and wrote a history of the church. The AME Zion's address explained, "When the Methodist society in the United States was small, the Africans enjoyed comfortable privileges among their white brethren in the same meeting-house, but as the whites increased very fast, the Africans were pressed back; therefore, it was thought essentially necessary for them to have meeting-houses of their own." While AME Zion cooperated with New York's black Asbury Church, which was still under the control of the Methodist Episcopal Conference, it established a history of rivalry with Allen's AME.[24]

The independent black church movement grew in New York after the establishment of the AME Zion. In 1808 New York's black Baptists formed the Abyssinian Baptist Church with help from Paul. Since 1792 black Episcopalians had repeatedly petitioned the Trinity Episcopal Church for land on which to build a church and school. By 1819 they had their own congregation, St. Phillip's Episcopal Church, pastored by Peter Williams Jr. Williams was ordained a priest in 1826 and became a leading black abolitionist until his death in 1840. His father was Peter Williams Sr., the founding member of the AME Zion. In 1821 the black abolitionist minister Samuel Cornish founded the city's First Colored Presbyterian Church. By 1826 African Americans in New York had founded ten black churches. As in Philadelphia, black women formed the backbone of these churches despite a male-dominated leadership. Women

composed two-thirds of the Zion congregation and 75 percent of the Abyssinian Baptist Church's. As early as 1802 they formed a separate Female African Benevolent Association.[25]

## Author's Notes

23. "Letter from James Forten to George Thatcher, January 1800," BAP; Julie Winch, A Gentleman of Color: The Life of James Forten (New York, 2002); Ray Allen Billington, "James Forten, Forgotten Abolitionist," in John H. Bracey Jr., August Meier, and Elliot Rudwick, eds., Blacks in the Abolitionist Movement (Belmont, Calif., 1971), 4–16.

24. A Short Account of the Rise and Progress of the African M.E. Church in America Written By Christopher Rush... (New York, 1843), 57; Carla Peterson, Black Gotham: A Family History of African Americans in Nineteenth-Century New York City (New Haven, 2011), 50–55; Leslie M. Alexander, African or American? Black Identity and Political Activism in New York City, 1784–1861 (Urbana, 2008), 8–13.

25. Craig Wilder, In the Company of Black Men: The African Infl uence on African American Culture in New York City (New York, 2001), chap. 2; Peterson, Black Gotham, 44–46; Leslie Harris, In the Shadow of Slavery: African Americans in New York City, 1626–1863 (Chicago, 2003), 82–85; John H. Hewitt, "Peter Williams, Jr.: New 694 of a Testimonial to S. P. Chase by the Colored People of Cincinnati (Cincinnati, 1845), 11, 27, 35; Betty Fladeland, James Gillespie Birney: Slaveholder to Abolitionist (Ithaca, 1955), 149–54; Stephen Middleton, Ohio and the Antislavery Activities of the Attorney Salmon Portland Chase, 1830–1849 (New York, 1990), 50–73, 92–113; Hagedorn, Beyond the River, 124–28, 140–93, 226–30; Hans Louis Trefousse, Benjamin Franklin Wade: Radical Republican from Ohio (New York, 1963), 32–38; Harrold, Border War, 79–93; Matthew Salafi a, "Searching for Slavery: Fugitive Slaves in the Ohio River Valley Borderland, 1830–1860," Ohio Valley History 8 (Winter 2008): 38–63.

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Sinha, *The Slave's Cause*, 140–141.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.088

# All Bound Up Together: The Woman Question in African American Public Culture, 1830-1900

Martha S. Jones

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|---|---|
| WORK | All Bound Up Together: The Woman Question in African American Public Culture, 1830-1900 |
| SELECTION | Introduction |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of North Carolina Press, 2007. |

## Excerpt

Still others, such as Glenda Gilmore, examine the interplay between the sacred and secular realms of women's activism.∞π These and other scholars suggest that the late-nineteenth-century emergence of black women into public culture is best understood as an extended process that spanned generations and nurtured the ambitions of young women through families and communities.∞∫ This book expands upon these insights about black women in the late nineteenth century by demonstrating the half-century-long debates that facilitated their public capacities.

In All Bound Up Together, readers from the field of African American history will discover the extent to which the woman question shaped nearly every dimension of black public culture from the 1830s forward. Nearly all African American activists were required to consider the nature of female influence and women's rights and grappled with the consequences of those ideas for the institutions of which they were a part. Here I use the term "activist" much in the same sense as scholars James and Lois Horton have, to capture a collective of individuals, some of whom were highly visible but many more of whom were working people for whom public activism was but a small facet of their lives. For many, activism, be it in politics, the church, or any one of a number of associations, was not a vocation but a part of a life's fabric that included work, family, and community building. Throughout this book, many such individuals come to the surface of the historical record for just a moment, mentioned in a newspaper report, conference minutes, or a letter. As individuals they often quickly recede from view, but as a cumulative presence they are highly suggestive of the extent to which the woman question permeated African American life.∞Ω Rather than patriarchal or maledominated, black public culture was an openly and often heatedly contested space in which activists self-consciously wrestled with the meanings of manhood and womanhood and the implications of those ideas for the structures and practices of institutions. Thus, this book o√ers new insights about familiar terrain, including free black communities of the North and the struggle against slavery; the Civil War and emancipation; the promises of Reconstruction; and the disappointments and degradations of Jim Crow.

For readers from the field of American women's history, which has taken the position of white women as its paradigm, this book o√ers striking new insights into the history of women's rights and the origins of feminism. Throughout the nineteenth century, there was a distinct movement for women's rights among black Americans, but this movement defined its objectives relative to the parameters of African American society rather than American society writ large. Black women did not privilege matters of race over those of gender. Rather, they were active at the intersection of these two salient social categories and fashioned their tactics and their aims to suit this circumstance. In a significant revision of earlier accounts and analyses, this work demonstrates that the di√erences long associated with the terms of the Fourteenth and Fifteenth Amendments were already present during the 1850s. African American activists, in the face of the increasing degradations that followed the Fugitive Slave Act, generally purged women's rights and women themselves from the realm of black politics. Looking forward from the moment of the Reconstruction-era constitutional amendments, women's historians will discover that among African Americans, agitation for women's rights increased. The evidence for this renewed commitment to women's rights issues is found not in politics but in churches, where black women seized upon three decades of women's rights discourse and transformed their roles in what was a most important institution. Thus, this book revises prevailing views of a well-studied past, including the emergence of Victorian domesticity; the Seneca Falls convention and development of

the women's rights movement; the work of the Civil War; the campaign for women's su√rage; and the club movement of the woman's era.≤≠

African American women, their ideas, their activism, and the contours of their lives, are at the core of this story. This book adopts a perspective that Elsa Barkley Brown has termed "pivoting the center."≤∞ Centered on black women, this book does not leave them to stand alone. The character of African American public culture, both its gender-integrated aspects and its frequent alliances with white activists and institutions, means that to pivot is to confront multiple voices: female as well as male and black as well as white.

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.089

# Vanguard: How Black Women Broke Barriers, Won the Vote, and Insisted on Equality for All

Martha S. Jones

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|---|---|
| WORK | Vanguard: How Black Women Broke Barriers, Won the Vote, and Insisted on Equality for All |
| SELECTION | INTRODUCTION Our Mothers' Gardens |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages reflowed ebook; no fixed page numbers · Basic Books, 2020. |

## Excerpt

Nineteenth in 1920—that promised them the vote. But lawmakers did not keep these promises, leaving many women to make their way in the face of rampant voter suppression: poll taxes, literacy tests, and intimidation. The long road to the 1965 Voting Rights Act was paved with Black women's organizing and courage. The result brought Black Americans, men and women, fully into the nation's political culture for the first time. That victory set the stage for how Black women today have assumed leadership: casting ballots, driving voter turnout, holding public office, and laboring in the trenches of precincts and parties.

The women of Vanguard built a movement for political rights that was never separate or for women only. Its foundation lay instead in the institutions they shared with men. Their politics unsettled these spaces with debates over what sorts of power women could exercise, and women placed real value on electing a bishop, sitting as a convention delegate, controlling finances, interpreting the Bible, running for a board, or commanding the podium. These same contests provided a training ground. Women honed their ideas while practicing leadership, the art of persuasion, and the necessity of compromise. They shouldered responsibility for the collective. They stood up to men and also won them as allies. Some women did go on to take part in suffrage associations and women's clubs. But Black women never limited their work to a single issue. Winning the vote was one goal, but it was a companion to securing civil rights, prison reform, juvenile justice, and international human rights.

Living at a crossroads, Black women developed their own perspective on politics and power. Their view was always intersectional. They could not support any movement that separated out matters of racism from sexism, at least not for long. Associations that asked Black women to set aside or subordinate one interest for another were never a good fit. They insisted, for example, that antislavery and women's rights were parts of one movement, and that civil rights included demands for women's liberty. Black women advocated for their interests as people doubly burdened by racism and sexism, and they reasoned that when society lifted them up as equals, everyone would rise. These insights led to a political philosophy rooted in a broad quest for freedom and dignity that extended to all of humanity.

The trouble of racism is one facet of this story, but for the women of Vanguard, their encounters with slights, exclusion, derision, and even violence were not the whole of their politics. Racism was a given, a constant. Some women risked being rebuffed in the interest of working in coalition with white women. Other women had no choice but to sustain the wounds of prejudice when their work or travel forced degrading confrontations. But oftentimes, Black women, with plenty of work to do in their own communities with one another, stepped around or turned their backs on racism. If white Americans too often cast a jaundiced eye upon Black women, it was not a look that they needed to return. Remaining at a careful distance from racism was essential to personal dignity and a self-defined approach to women's power.

The stories in Vanguard have often been overlooked. But not wholly so. Historians over the last half century have dug deep into African American women's pasts to recover their ideas, their organizations, and their distinct brand of politics. These efforts correct a record made more than a century ago by Susan B. Anthony, Elizabeth Cady Stanton, Matilda Joslyn Gage, and Ida Husted Harper, who dubbed themselves the historians of the early women's movement. Between 1881 and 1922, they published the six-volume, fifty-seven-hundred-page History of Woman

Suffrage. But they told only one part of the story and in that relegated Black women to the margins. Later historians relied upon these same volumes, producing new studies that, regretfully, repeated old omissions.

Vanguard corrects that record by retelling two hundred years of Black women's political history. It does not tell every story; no history can do quite that. But by recounting the lives of some of the many Black women who engaged in political fights, the picture of a whole comes into view. In some eras, Black women pursued power as singular, cutting-edge figures. At other times, they joined coalitions that included white women and Black men. Most often, Black women built political power in their own circles. There are as many stories as there are women, but those recounted in this book represent Black women's varied political lives and their many routes to the vote and beyond.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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Jones, *Vanguard*, reflowed ebook; no fixed page numbers.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.090

# American Heretic: Theodore Parker and Transcendentalism

Dean Grodzins

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | American Heretic: Theodore Parker and Transcendentalism |
| SELECTION | 7. I Can Stand Alone |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of North Carolina Press, 2002. |

## Excerpt

Parker found Brook Farm attractive, but aside from low moments in □□□□ and □□□□, when he feared being forced from the ministry, he never seriously considered living there. Besides, he may have been aware early—and he certainly came to see over time—that commitment to Brook Farm was a risk, because the community faced constant threat of bankruptcy. He knew some of those who had advanced to Brook Farm its working capital. His neighbors George Russell and Francis Shaw were among them; Aunt Lucy, possibly with his encouragement, also had loaned a small sum. He himself took out a mortgage on a piece of Brook Farm property (in effect giving the community another loan) when he sent Georgie there. Parker must have realized before too long that Brook Farm was hard pressed to pay its debts. As the son of a farmer and artisan, Parker could have guessed the key reasons why: the soil on which the community struggled to grow its crops was sandy (the previous owner of the fields had been sensible enough to use them only for grazing milk cows), while the community craft shops were not well enough organized to turn a profit. In short, the "Brook Farm Institute for Agriculture and Industry," as it officially was known, succeeded neither agriculturally nor industrially. The only profitable enterprise associated with it was the school.

More important, Parker came to realize that he dissented from the Brook Farm approach to solving social ills. For one thing, Ripley and his friends were more skeptical than he about the justness of private property. Brook Farm members shared living quarters and eating space, and turned over the money made by their individual labors to the community. Ripley himself (who had told Parker in □□□□he favored the abolition of inherited private property) wanted to make these cooperative arrangements more thoroughgoing. He admired the proposal of the French socialist Fourier that everyone should live in tightly planned "Phalanxes," with little private ownership; eventually, he would try to turn Brook Farm into a Phalanx. By contrast, Parker believed strongly in private property, as he makes clear in an □□□□sermon, which he may have preached with the "Associationist" contingent of his congregation in mind. Some of them undoubtedly heard it.

Parker here specifically criticizes the idea, which he is careful to say has been advanced by "pious & philanthropic persons," that property should be held in common. Parker sees this proposal as a natural reaction of the heart against the excessive desire for gain in modern society.

I Can Stand Alone □□□ private property is "an ontological fact, belonging to the Nature of man": man is a "hoarding animal"; mankind has a right to appropriate and hoard; the earth belongs to mankind; as mankind is made up of individuals, so property seems to belong to each individual. Parker's logic seems somewhat slippery, but for him, earning what you receive from life and paying as you go were strict moral imperatives.

How strict is evident in several other sermons, in which he denounces state debt repudiation as a grave political sin. The issue was an important one of the day. Many states, mostly in the South and West, had borrowed heavily during the speculative boom years of the early □□□□s, usually from English banks to pay for internal improvements. After the panic of □□□□, these states found themselves strapped to meet their repayment obligations. By the early □□□□s, a few states, in desperation, tried to repudiate at least part of what they owed. Some pro-repudiation politicians, all Democrats, argued that the debts were "held by rich and selfish foreign capitalists, who care for nothing so much as to wring money from the hard earnings of our people.'

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.091

# The Inner Civil War: Northern Intellectuals and the Crisis of the Union

George M. Fredrickson

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Inner Civil War: Northern Intellectuals and the Crisis of the Union |
| SELECTION | Conservatives In A Radical Age |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 29–30 · Harper & Row, 1965. |

## Excerpt

If the clergyman was not in a position to call Americans back to a traditional sense of community, it was still possible to conceive of a secular priesthood, a conservative intellectual class based on learning and culture. Elitist visions of this kind came naturally in New England where for generations there had been a definable group which had attempted to combine intellectual achievement and social leadership. This was the aristocracy that Oliver Wendell Holmes called "the Brahmin caste of New England"—the descendants of historic families which had long cherished scholarship and erudition and at the same time provided leaders in law, politics, and commerce.

The Brahmin intellectuals of the 1850s, however, were in a poor position to be the defenders of conservativism. Not only had their social and political power recently declined as the result of new wealth and the demand for a more democratic style of leadership, but even on the level of abstract thought they had little to offer. They found it hard to take sides in the debate on institutions because their instinctive conservatism on pressing social issues was accompanied by a philosophical and religious liberalism—an inherited penchant for Enlightenment ideas which hindered their embracing social organicism as an alternative to American individualism. Despite the fact that they had no use for egalitarian reform, they went at least part of the way with Emerson and Parker in rejecting revealed Christianity and other dogmas which had buttressed a conservative social order. Some of the younger Brahmins of the 1850s actually became disciples of Emerson and the transcendentalists and were deflected from their normal course as responsible citizens. But their transcendentalism was of an extremely individualistic variety which did not lead them into reform; its major effect was to add to the difficulty of finding a gentleman's vocation in a democratic age.

One Brahmin transcendentalist was Charles Russell Lowell, the nephew of James Russell Lowell. As a Harvard undergraduate in the early 1850s, Lowell found himself unable to resist the mysteries of self-culture, and his valedictory oration of 1854 repeated the doctrine of Emerson's "American Scholar' that high thinking and idealism are more important than practical activity. Lowell, however, did not become a hermit after graduation. Although a believer in the priority of thought, he remembered that Emerson had defined the American scholar as a man of action as well as "man thinking." In letters of 1855 and 1856, he acknowledged that while "'active life alone never made a man of anybody," he had always supposed that "action was necessary to complete my character.' When he came to realize that he was not a literary genius or a seer, the types that Emerson called "divine men," he decided that he would have to be one of the "heroes of the world'"—the other Emersonian type. He knew that "'the 'divine men'" have 'no need for work" but " 'Heroes' of the world have certainly needed work and had it and done it well, and it is Heroes that we must try to be."?°

In his effort to live according to the somewhat self-contradictory ideals of Emerson, Lowell was confronting directly a form of the transcendentalist problem of "double consciousness" or duality. How was he both to develop an inner life and play an "heroic" role in the world? His problem was compounded by the fact that America seemed to deny its heroic roles to members of Lowell's social class. He tried working as a common workman in an iron mill, acting as a kind of missionary to the workers, while at the same time preparing himself for a role in industry; but his health failed before he went very far in this direction. Then like so many young gentlemen of the time, he traveled

extensively in Europe to recover from his illness. While there, he thought of taking up farming but was afraid that for some transcendental reason, it was "'not quite a 'life'.'" After his return from Europe in 1858, he went to Iowa as a railroad agent, but found that 'The West may make a man strong, massy, rock-like— never large and generous and manly." By 1860, Lowell had still not found a vocation that combined self-culture with an active life. Part of his difficulty came from the lack of attractive positions for a young patrician in an egalitarian society, but equally important as a source of malaise was his Emersonian claim on the universe."

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.092

# Understanding Emerson: "The American Scholar" and His Struggle for Self-Reliance

Kenneth S. Sacks

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|---|---|
| WORK | Understanding Emerson: "The American Scholar" and His Struggle for Self-Reliance |
| SELECTION | Chapter |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 90–91 · Princeton University Press, 2003. |

## Excerpt

It was, in fact, only at Harvard where Emerson fulfilled his prophetic identity and his oath to speak candidly. In part motivated by a familiar audience and a familiar setting and in part to keep pace with friends who were so gifted in writing academic-style polemics, Emerson broke free from the constraints of lyceum oratory by evoking the tough language and forms of the revival and the jeremiad. Because, whether by design or fear, he wouldn't engage Harvard faculty in subtle philosophical disputes as had Ripley and Hedge, he introduced Transcendentalist thinking descriptively rather than analytically. Hedge had written about the necessity to synthesize the old and new ways, and Ripley and Brownson, as we'll see next, demanded that Transcendentalism stand in the service of social reform. To Emerson, the scholar ought to go where the heart leads: "Character is higher than intellect. Thinking is the function. Living is the functionary.... A great soul will be strong to live, as well as strong to think." It was Emerson's refusal to be more specific that so annoyed his foes and disappointed his friends. But Emerson's scholar struck an honest balance between experiential learning and the constant revelation of Reason. That scholar could neither be produced by traditional university pedagogy nor serve some utilitarian purpose. The American scholar could be conjured but not defined.

If Emerson would not or could not engage in the analytical aspects of the philosophical and theological debate between Transcendentalists and Unitarians, at least his sympathies were generally with his friends. But the question of social action, Brownson's third category that divided the Old and New Schools, also separated Emerson from many fellow Transcendentalists. The 1830s saw the rise of several movements designed to better humankind. Abolition, of course, led the way. Socialism, temperance, education of the physically handicapped, and anti-prostitution, dietary, and public school reform were among the many other movements that, commented one observer of the Boston scene, "worked their way from street to street like an epidemic." Because social causes required a willingness to subordinate personal belief to the greater good, Emerson struggled awkwardly. We have seen how Emerson, worried about scaring off his lyceum audience, suppressed his desire to speak out. It was only after and because of "The American Scholar" that by fits and starts he learned to offer his support without feeling a loss of self—or of revenue. Others, who were from the beginning bolder, helped force Emerson to define his position.[54]

Of those closely aligned to Transcendentalism, Orestes Brownson was the most politically committed. His activism caused some Transcendentalists to shun him so that by the summer of 1837 he was no longer invited to club meetings. Brownson had little patience with the extreme religious idealism of Emerson, believing that part of Jesus's mission was to unite Catholic spiritualism and Protestant materialism. Transcendentalism, Brownson wrote in 1836, helped serve this purpose by unifying the mind and body. He hailed Emerson's Nature in the Boston Reformer "as a proof that the mind is about to receive a new and more glorious manifestation," but worried that Emerson was retreating into the world of pure, self-referential thought: "To deny [the testimony of one's senses] is to set oneself afloat upon the ocean of universal skepticism."

Brownson had quickly been befriended by George Ripley, who saw Brownson's liberal politics as a way to extend the New School to the poor. By March, 1837, while Emerson agonized over his own indecisiveness, Ripley appreciated Brownson as a man of action: "Brownson is a true prophet, Heaven-anointed, and the age to come will build a regal

tomb for him, though he is now stoned," he wrote Clarke. He later asked John Sullivan Dwight about a recent Brownson essay: "Can you show a finer piece of philosophical composition than his article on Transcendentalism?" Brownson, in a letter to George Bancroft, expressed similar respect for Ripley and did so publicly in the pages of his Boston Quarterly Review: "Mr. Ripley's doctrine... rescues the mass from the power of the learned few, and places the truth of Christianity within the reach of every man." Brownson praised Emerson and Alcott as well, but was careful to qualify his support and define areas of difference. He had greater affection and sympathy for Ripley and his more democratic views. Ripley that very year resigned his ministry, telling his congregation that he must follow the two dynamic movements in his life: Transcendentalism and social reform.

## Author's Notes

54. George P. Lathrop, "Literary and Social Boston," Harper's New Monthly Magazine 62 (February, 1881), 383.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.093

# Virtue's Hero: Emerson, Antislavery, and Reform

Len Gougeon

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|---|---|
| WORK | Virtue's Hero: Emerson, Antislavery, and Reform |
| SELECTION | The Silent Years |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 49–50 · University of Georgia Press, 1990. |

## Excerpt

That the abolitionists had Emerson and "his" transcendentalists clearly in mind in such instances is suggested by Edmund Quincy's comment in a letter to a friend in 1841 regarding Theodore Parker's recent conversion to active abolitionism. "I do not know whether you have heard that Theodore Parker came out on Sunday before last with an Anti-Slavery sermon.... He has now recognized the A[nti]. S[lavery].

& N[on]. Resistance], movements as the Chief, if not the only, manifestations of Christianity in the present age, without any Emersonian or Channingian qualifications [emphasis mine].[22]

In an earlier letter that describes the appearance of a group of the transcendental Brook Farmers (with whom Emerson was at times associated) at an abolition picnic, Quincy notes that none of them spoke at the affair and concludes, "I do not think we have anything to hope from them."2 Last, the association between Emerson and Channing, and their pernicious effect on the abolition movement, are described clearly in a draft article on Emerson that Maria Chapman prepared as late as 1844. "His [Emerson's] character being rather contemplative than active, at least according to popular acceptation of those words, he has been a philosophical speculator rather than a reformer. His wisdom has therefore made fools of some, & his naturalness [has] been the occasion of affectation in others. Hundreds of young persons have made him their excuse for avoiding the Anti Slavery battle & talking about the clear light; just as thousands have refused their aid to the cause because Dr. Channing wrote essays against associations."

The entire question of the relationship of the transcendental and abolition movements is complex and resistant to generalizations, although many scholars have tried to discern it.[25] John Humphrey Noyes maintains that Brook Farm, the most famous experiment in living according to transcendental principles, "was the child of New England Unitarianism" and was suggested by Dr. Channing. He quotes Emerson as his source for this. Not surprisingly, because of the Unitarian/transcendental concern for universal rather than specific moral reform, the emphasis of abolitionism was seen by this group as myopic and undesirable.[26] While there were some abolitionists among the transcendentalists in the 1830s and early 1840s, the two were generally on divergent paths during this time, and there was often friction between them. Thus Lindsay Swift points out that when Frederick Cabot joined the transcendental community at Brook Farm in 1844 after being a member of the Massachusetts Antislavery Society, he was criticized for it by old abolitionist friends like Caroline Weston. Flis defensive response was that "while he loves the slave no less he loves humanity more."

For some this friction would prove enduring. One of the better-known Brook Farmers, George Curtis, in a letter to a friend written some seven years after that famous experiment ended, refers to "the remembrance of Brook Farm & the thousand memories that consecrate that place." The tranquil tone of his letter soon changes, however, when the subject turns to "stiffnecked" reformers who fail to realize "that the landscape stretches backward as well as forward & that because they are doing one thing they are not fulfilling all." Specifically, Curtis relates that the day before, he had "read an AntiSlavery resolution denouncing as damned, all churches & ministers that do not entirely & openly condemn Southern bondage." Curtis was outraged at this blanket condemnation and sadly observes that "these facts of AntiSlavery—& Slavery... cross the land, seeking whom they may devour, & their prey is the majority of men." For the former Brook Farmer, Americans in general and abolitionists in particular seemed to have forgotten, if they ever

knew, that “the sum of wisdom is the knowledge that things have two sides.”

## Author's Notes

22. Edmund Quincy to Caroline Weston, 9 February 1841, MS, Boston Public Library. Edmund Quincy (1808-77) was a Harvard graduate and the second son of Josiah Quincy, former president of Harvard. He joined the Massachusetts Anti-slavery Society in 1837, shocking his aristocratic peers, and eventually became vice president of the American Anti-slavery Society and was associated with several prominent antislavery publications.

25. For comments on specific works see chap. 10 of this volume.

26. Strange Cults and Utopias of 19th-Century America (1870; reprint. New York: Dover Publications, 1966), p. 104. 359 Index New England Anti-slavery Society, 88 New England Emigrant Aid Society, 217 Nisami, 149 Non-Resistance Movement, 49, 225 Norton, Andrews, 61 Nott, J. C., 181 Noyes, John Humphrey, 49 Palfrey, John Gorham, 22, 48, 93, 151, 156; Emerson campaigns for, 166-67, 170 Parker, Theodore, 6, 9, 50, 108, 127, 128, 143, 151, 167, 219, 246, 294; “Fast Day Sermon” (1851), 156; and Negroes, 182; and Anthony Burns, 200-201, 206, 214-15; and war in Kansas, 218, 223, 224; and John Brown, 229, 255, 258; and tribute to Emerson, 236; death, 258; Emerson memorial to, 259 Peabody, Elizabeth, 10, 14 Peace Party, 289 People’s Party, 286-90 Pendleton, George H., 307 Pennell, Richard (Earl of Lyons), 277 Persian poetry, 145 Personal Liberty Law (Massachusetts), 153, 155, 158, 165 Phillips, Wendell, 4, 9, 16, 20, 45, 50, 64, 87, 118, 127, 140, 143, 219, 228,

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.094

# American Transcendentalism: A History

Philip F. Gura

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|---|---|
| WORK | American Transcendentalism: A History |
| SELECTION | Heaven on Earth |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 165–166 · Hill and Wang, 2007. |

## Excerpt

William Henry Channing's The Present znd Brisbane's '^The Phalanx, included Brook Farm among the experimental communities they praised, prompting Ripley to consider more formal association with the New York Fourierist wing, particularly so that he could solicit its wealthy backers.

Matters came to a head in late December, when Brook Farm sent representatives to a four-day convention of Friends of Social Reform at the Tremont Temple in Boston. Joining delegates from Ballou's Hopedale enterprise, the Northampton (Massachusetts) Association of Education and Industry (established by radical abolitionists), and the Skaneateles Community from rural New York (also founded by abolitionists but distinctive in prohibiting private property) were most of New England's prominent reformers; Alcott. Garrison, Brownson, and the recently escaped slave Frederick Douglass (now lecturing for the Massachusetts Anti-Slavery Society), among others.

Parke Godwin, and William Henry Channing also attended. Ripley and others in the Brook Earm contingent returned to West Roxbury convinced that the community's success depended on its adoption of Eourier's economic principles, a transition they did not think would be that difficult. Shortly after the New Year, Ripley met with Brook Earm's shareholders to win approval for the plan. His task did not prove difficult, for the membership, whether or not they approved of the shift to Fourierism, understood the necessity of a change of direction.

In early January 1844 the community heard and approved a revised constitution and articles of agreement for what from that point on was called the Brook Farm Association for Industry and Education. The change reflected Ripley's decision to diversify the community's economy by taking in more craftsmen and laborers, which Greeley and Brisbane thought necessary but which irrevocably changed its membership. The new constitution reflected Eourier's scheme for the reorganization of work: a General Direction (that is, a committee of oversight), a Direction of Einance, a Direction of Education, and a Direction of Industry, with the old units of Domestic Economy and Agriculture now subsumed into this last and termed merely a "Series," another shift in the community's priorities. With this reorganization of labor into "Series" and "Groups" (Fourier's terminology), the Brook Farmers demonstrated their commitment to Fourier's notion of "Attractive Industry." In the Agricultural Series, for example, there were groups for plowing, planting, weeding, hoeing, and so on; and Brook Farm also instituted a Domestic Series and a Mechanical Series. One wit among them even proposed the "R. L. S. G.," the "rejected lover's sympathizing group.But other of the basic organizing principles did not change. Interest on one's investment remained at 5 percent, and all members were still guaranteed the necessities of life and the rights to personal property and to live in family units.

No American phalanx ever grew to anything near the size Fourier envisioned. Here the Brook Farmers, like other pioneer phalansterians, followed Brisbane's suggestion—in a series of articles in the Democratic Review in 1842—that Fourier's principles could be put into operation in a four-hundred-member community.^® Brook Farm, which already had a division of and reward for labor similar to what Fourier counseled, was ideally situated and suited for such an experiment. When Ripley announced the reorganization and put out a call for more participants, applications for membership soared. Six months after the publication of the new constitution, eighty-seven applicants had joined the community; and after the two-month trial stipulated in the bylaws, fifty-eight, primarily laborers and artisans rather than farmers or intellectuals, were admitted as members and accommodated into new Groups and Series. Between May I and September 30, 1844, Brook Farm received one hundred more applications. Clearly, the switch to Association brought new attention to the West Roxbury experiment.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.095

# The Transcendentalists and Their World

Robert A. Gross

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Transcendentalists and Their World |
| SELECTION | 15. The Spirit of Reform |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages reflowed ebook; no fixed page numbers · Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2021. |

## Excerpt

What was to be done? Concord was at an impasse, with local men hesitant or opposed to antislavery activism. If anything was to happen, the women would have to take the lead. The Grimké sisters pointed the way with their compelling rationale for female abolitionism and their principled defiance of masculine disapproval. And so, some sixty women overcame their trepidation and gathered in November 1837 to form the Concord Female Anti-Slavery Society (CFASS). Theirs was one of eight such groups founded that year in the Grimkés' wake. The Concord association belonged to a select minority in the Bay State. The great majority of antislavery societies were dominated by men; just a fifth—40 out of 221—were run by women. Far from being shamed by their wives and daughters, Concord's male leaders paid the new organization no mind. Its founding went unmentioned in the press; informally, it was "noticed but to be ridiculed," charter member Mary Brooks later recalled. The men did nothing on their own. They could establish one voluntary association after another to promote temperance, advance knowledge, and foster economic and social improvements, but no town-wide antislavery society ever sprang into action. Democrats and Whigs preferred to compete over economic issues and ignore the subject of slavery as much as possible, and when that proved impossible, they contended over whether and how to remove the scourge of human bondage from the nation's capital, restrict its expansion into the Western territories, and curb its reach in the supposedly free North. Abolitionism was not on their agenda; nor was it a top priority for any of the religious sects or even for the Transcendentalists. It was left to Concord's women and a minority of men to push for immediate emancipation in the South and equal rights for all citizens, regardless of race, right at home in Massachusetts.

And so it was with other social movements. Although men dominated the official leadership and controlled the public proceedings, women were the foot soldiers of reform. They signed temperance pledges in huge numbers; they contributed funds to women and children in need and to organizations aiding fugitive slaves; they pressed antislavery principles on lawmakers in massive petition campaigns to state and federal governments. Such action marked a bold declaration of the right of women to act on their own to promote religion, aid the poor and oppressed, and serve the Lord—even to shake up the social order. Ultimately, they would demand equal rights for themselves. In the 1830s and early 1840s social reform was a job not for the famous Transcendentalists of Concord but for their female kin—their mothers and aunts, sisters and wives.

The female antislavery society had precedent in Concord. It drew on the model and experience of the Concord Female Charitable Society, itself an innovative assertion of women's leadership at its founding in 1814. For more than two decades the "benevolent fair" of the town, led by wives of Social Circle members, had been assisting needy women and children. These errands of mercy were regarded as an extension of maternal care beyond the home. In reality, they expanded women's presence in the civic arena. The charitable society had given its members practical experience in running a voluntary association. It had adopted a formal constitution and bylaws, raised and spent funds, made investments, elected officers, and met annually in a public space to hear their reports. It was no stretch to apply this mode of action to the cause of the slave.

But that was to enter a realm fraught with politics and controversy. In Boston, New York, and Philadelphia, it was a step too far for the elite women at the helm of the leading charities. Not in Concord, where twenty-three founders of the antislavery society were alumnae of the charitable society and fifteen of the Trinitarian Ladies Sewing Society. These activists were no longer content to dispense alms to the Black and white poor; they aspired to strike at the

roots of degradation and misery among African Americans close to home and on Southern plantations far away. If this effort required them to challenge existing ways, such as speaking and acting in public, so be it. As they saw it, this was their moral and religious duty, free of partisan taint.

For all their challenge to convention, the charter members of the female antislavery society resembled their charitable predecessors. The typical founder was a wife and mother in her mid- to late thirties, approaching the end of her childbearing years. No longer caring for infants and toddlers, she could set aside an occasional afternoon and labor on behalf of the suffering slave. The cause was inclusive; the abolitionist sisterhood came from families prominent and obscure. Lidian Emerson was on the rolls, as was the sizable Thoreau clan: the matriarch Cynthia (whose mother had grown up in a slaveholding household before the Revolution), her sisters Sophia and Louisa Dunbar, her older daughter Helen, her sisters-in-law Elizabeth, Jane, and Maria Thoreau, and the two Prudence Wards boarding in her household. Mary Brooks and her daughter Caroline came from the heart of the Whig establishment, Maria Prescott from its Democratic counterpart. But elite support for abolitionism was thin. Only five members of the Social Circle had wives or daughters in the antislavery society; by contrast, nearly every married man in that exclusive club was united in wedlock to a “chattable.” The rank and file of the antislavery society belonged to the middling and laboring classes. The self-supporting tailoress Mary Minott, sister of the reclusive farmer George, joined in the founding. So did Susan Robbins Garrison, the only woman of color in the group. A sharp gap of class and race separated her from Maria Prescott, in whose fields Jack Garrison and his sons could often be seen laboring for a living. The antislavery society strove to blur, if not erase, that line. Soon after its debut, the group convened in the Garrisons’ new home in the onetime windmill off the river road.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.096

# American Reformers, 1815-1860

**Ronald G. Walters**

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|---|---|
| **WORK** | American Reformers, 1815-1860 |
| **SELECTION** | Heaven on Earth |
| **SOURCE LOCATOR** | Original pages 51–52 · Hill and Wang, 1997. |

## Excerpt

Transcendentalist Ralph Waldo Emerson agonized over whether to join Brook Farm and finally convinced himself (as he commonly did) that he was more valuable preserving his autonomy and remaining unaffiliated. He visited and observed Brook Farm with the same detachment his fellow Transcendentalist Margaret Fuller displayed when she spoke of going there to watch "the coral insects at work." When the influence of Transcendentalism was felt at Brook Farm, it was sometimes in the form of a thorny independence like Emerson's that weighed against the discipline essential to communal life. That was, nonetheless, part of Brook Farm's charm. It had room for playfulness, fads, odd attire, unfashionably bearded and long-haired men, and sweet eccentrics like Burrill Curtis, who, according to one account, "had been a model for a portrait of Christ." The motive of the original Brook Farmers, according to Elizabeth Peabody, was to be "wholly true to their natures as men and women." Those natures were deliciously varied and more Utopian than communitarian.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.097

# Brook Farm: The Dark Side of Utopia

Sterling F. Delano

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|---|---|
| WORK | Brook Farm: The Dark Side of Utopia |
| SELECTION | Preface |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2004. |

## Excerpt

That prompted me to read through virtually all of the more than 300 articles and the dozen or more books that deal with one aspect or another of America's most renowned utopian experiment. It was quite an experience. Not one of the numerous resources, I quickly realized, provides anything like a comprehensive examination of Brook Farm. The "standard" treatment is still Lindsay Swift's Brook Farm: Its Members, Scholars, and Visitors, which was published more than a century ago. Even more surprising was the amount of misleading, contradictory, and flat-out incorrect information about the community found in many of the sources—a good deal of it, surprisingly enough, in the reminiscences of the Brook Farmers themselves. Brook Farm deserves better than this, especially since there continues to be such an enduring fascination with the community—no doubt inspired partly by the association with it of such prominent figures as Nathaniel Hawthorne, Ralph Waldo Emerson, and Margaret Fuller.

Clarity is all the more essential because Brook Farm grew out of the same cultural seedbed that gave rise to Transcendentalism, abolitionism, the workingmen's movement, the women's rights movement. and other manifestations of antebellum social reform in New England, activities in which many of the Brook Farmers themselves participated. (Colorful New York labor organizer Mike Walsh, the leader of a group of reformers known in the 1840s as the "Spartan Band," once characterized the Brook Farmers as "pious professors and Infidels, Fourierists, Abolitionists, Non-Resistants, etc.. etc.") Brook Farm: The Dark Side of Utopia takes note of some of these reform programs along the way, but its real interest is in what early Brook Farmer Nathaniel Hawthorne later characterized as "the inner truth and spirit of the whole affair" Hawthorne hoped that Brook Farm's leaders—notably George Ripley, who founded the community and later achieved Frerace great prominence in New York City's journalistic world, or Charles Anderson Dana, Ripley's second-in-command, who afterward became the powerful owner and editor of the New York Sun—would one day document the community's internal drama, but neither of them ever did. No doubt the story was too painful to record for posterity. Brook Farm: The Dark Side of Utopia is the first study to do so.

Since Brook Farm evolved out of the phenomenon known in New England in the 1830s as 'Transeenclentalism, it might be expected that one of George Ripley's Unitarian brethren would naturally have played the role of biographer and documented the community's history. Several of them, after all, followed Ripley to the village of West Roxbury in 1841 to build anew the ~city of God" on the 200-acre dairy farm that served as the site of the experiment. Others, like Theodore Parker and William Henry Channing, were intimately associated with the community at different stages of its six-year existence. Transcendentalists like Emerson. Orestes Brownson, Parker, and Channing, however, were never any more united in their support of Brook Farm than they had been in the religious and philosophical principles that they supposedly held in common m the 1830s. Brook Farm may be "the best representation of the social aspect of transcendentalism" (as one commentator has put it). but given the inconsistent and wavering support of those Transcendentalists associated with the community, it's probably more accurate to say that Brook Farm is the best representation of the amorphous nature of Transcendentalism itself. A history of the community is in fact nothing less than a record of the demise of that remarkable American cultural phenomenon that we refer to today as the Transcendental "movement."

## Chicago Citations

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.098

# The Trials of Anthony Burns: Freedom and Slavery in Emerson's Boston

Albert J. von Frank

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Trials of Anthony Burns: Freedom and Slavery in Emerson's Boston |
| SELECTION | Excerpt from the supplied edition |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | supplied PDF 17–18 · Harvard University Press, 1998. |

## Excerpt

ries of cases, was a far greater impetus to revolutionary protest, at least in Massachusetts, than was Kansas-Nebraska — that this was true not only because the slave cases played out before the astonished public gaze, and not only because it gave human faces to good and

This "pocket revolution," as I have called it, owes its qualities of drama and spectacle to its locale, but it demands to be seen as participating in a broader revolutionary impulse that was bent on sacrificing the Constitution to achieve its antislavery aims, and that required in the end a civil war, a series of constitutional amend-

There has been for some time a tendency in academic circles to discount or deplore the social, moral, and ideological implications of Transcendentalism, and to regard Emerson himself as uncommitted to reform or as dissuaded from action by unattractive, privately held

I supposed that the best way to arrive at some answers was to linger, for once, over the historical moment, and to understand in such depth and detail as a novelist might command the crisis that brought these ideas to the test. The case of Anthony Burns was selfsufficiently dramatic.

Freedom would inevitably mean different things to Ralph Waldo Emerson and to Frederick Douglass; yet if each failed to see his own position reflected in the statements of the other, some kind of blindness or hypocrisy would have to be involved.

as when the figure of the fugitive slave — even Anthony Burns — comes into an ironic yet preeminent possession of the core idea of America and complexly represents to the nation the freedom it affirms most noisily and insistently, with flags and rockets and Fourths of

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**Shortened citation:**

Frank, *The Trials of Anthony Burns*, supplied PDF 17–18.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.099

# Transcendentalism as a Social Movement, 1830-1850

Anne C. Rose

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Transcendentalism as a Social Movement, 1830-1850 |
| SELECTION | Economy |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 132–133 · Yale University Press, 1981. |

## Excerpt

Thirty-two people in all became members of Brook Farm between 1841 and 1844, and while none was as active in evangelical Unitarianism or Transcendentalism as Ripley, a number were closely enough identified with these movements for us to assume they shared his priorities. Among those who signed the Articles of Association in September 1841, Minot Pratt was the printer of the Christian Register and Charles Anderson Dana was a former Harvard student. Three Unitarian ministers—Samuel D. Robbins, Lemuel Capen, and Warren Burton—signed the revised edition of the Articles in 1842. A majority of the members, moreover, came from social groups most likely to appreciate reform focusing on intellectual and moral development. Of the twenty-seven who can be identified with reasonable certainty, ten were ministers, teachers, writers, and their wives, and six were former students. The fact that only two were businessmen and nine were working people, five of whom were farmers and their wives, also suggests that Brook Farm steered a middle course between the spiritual anarchism of Fruitlands and trade unionists' demands for extensive economic and political change.[58] Ties of kinship and friendship made it possible to rely on voluntary allegiance to religious principles instead of on more formal methods of reform. George Ripley brought his sister into the community, for example, and Sophia Ripley her cousin and niece. Similarly, the social distance between Minot Pratt, the printer, and the Ripleys was minimized by their acquaintance since the early 1830s, when Ripley briefly edited, and Pratt compiled, the Register.

The number of Transcendentalists associated with Brook Farm, though not as members, reinforced the neighborly atmosphere of the community as well as the emphasis on spiritual means and ends. All of the Transcendentalists were frequent visitors in the first few years, and Margaret Fuller in particular used the farm as a retreat from the pressures of her increasingly active public life as editor of the Dial and leader of the Boston conversations. Transcendentalist children were some of the pupils in the school the Brook Farmers conducted—Fuller's brother, Lidian Emerson's nephew, and Orestes Brownson's son, to name the most important. The community also accepted paying boarders, and these were often friends of the Transcendentalists. Charles King Newcombe, a writer from Providence, was an acquaintance of Margaret Fuller, as was Almira Barlow, the estranged wife of an ex-Unitarian minister.[59]

## Author's Notes

58. See appendix C for a list of members, with the occupation, date of birth, place of birth, and date of admission to Brook Farm for each. I have used the following criteria for membership: signature of either edition of the Articles of Association (dated Sept. 29,1841, and Feb. 17, 1842, respectively) or signature of the Constitution (dated Feb. 11, 1844) or admission recorded in the minutes of meetings. All these documents are located in the Massachusetts Historical Society. Some texts have been published independently and in the secondary works and periodicals which I cite below. A resolution was passed on Feb. 18, 1844, that each member must sign the Constitution and supply the biographical information about him or herself that I have included. Thus the record after that date is almost complete. Before 1844, members generally signed the official agreements without supplying biographical data. Thus my identifications of the pre—1844 group, as well as supplementary information about later members, are based on a survey of the literature on Transcendentalism and Fourierism. The most useful work is Lindsay Swift, Brook Farm: Its Members, Scholars, and Visitors (New York: Macmillan, 1900), esp. pp. 111-201. On the three Unitarian ministers, see Samuel A. Eliot, Heralds of a Liberal Faith, 3 vols. (Boston: American Unitarian Association, 1910), 2:106 (Burton), 2:6 (Capen), and 3:336 (Robbins). Newspapers and periodicals are also extremely helpful, including the New York Tribune, Present, Phalanx, and Harbinger. 1 have not attempted to impose a tight social classification system, since members do not always fit easily into standardized categories (such as the students in the Brook Farm school, who were admitted to membership when they came of age), and I generally use descriptive analysis instead. It should be noted, however, that in the "working-class" category, I count all those who earned their living by manual labor, including farmers and printers, and in the "business" or "commercial" group, white-collar workers and owners of businesses. Wives, who usually listed no occupation, have been classified with their husbands unless otherwise stated.

59. On the students and visitors, see Swift, Brook Farm, pp. 69-109, 203-60. On Fuller's relation to Brook Farm, see William Henry Channing's comments in Memoirs of Fuller, 2:72-80, and Thomas Wentworth Higginson,☐ Margaret Fuller Ossolt (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1884), pp. 173-84. On Newcombe, see The Journals of Charles King Newcombe, ed. Judith Johnson (Providence: Brown University, 1946), esp. pp. 3-30, and his short story "Dolon," Dial 3 (July 1842): 112-23. On Barlow, see Haraszti, Idyll, pp. 19-22.

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Rose, *Transcendentalism as a Social Movement, 1830-1850*, 132–133.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.100

# Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life, vol. 1, The Private Years

Charles Capper

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life, vol. 1, The Private Years |
| SELECTION | 9. The Transcendentalist |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 310–311 · Oxford University Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

Altogether, these contradictory and overlapping developments encouraged a critical, dissatisfied, and millennially expectant tone in Northern culture that would continue to grow until the Civil War. That Transcendentalists should rush in to add their own sympathetic notes to that harmony—or cacophony— of reforms should not be surprising. Transcendentalist ministers like George Ripley had absorbed the traditional Channingite Unitarian uneasiness over selfseeking materialism and its patrician corollary belief in the responsibility of "the better sort" to arouse the capacities of society's poor and downtrodden. At the same time, more culturally radical Transcendentalists like Emerson, Alcott, and Brownson had recently come to extract from the new philosophy important protodemocratic notions: the potential divinity of individual men and women; the necessity to liberate souls from spiritually confining institutions; the call to achieve an organic integration of thought and action, labor and consciousness, intellectuals and common life, were all—potentially at least—socially radical Transcendentalist ideas.[6]

Finally, by 1839, many Transcendentalists were becoming extremely hopeful about the possibilities for what some of them were beginning to call "democratic" change. That year George Ripley began reading about European and American pietistic communities, an interest that would soon join with his dissatisfaction with the social conservatism of the Unitarian church to propel him out of the ministry and into a full-time career as a communitarian socialist leader. Simultaneously, Orestes Brownson, who had been trumpeting the ideals of Saint-Simonian socialism for several years, accelerated his efforts, along with those of his friend and patron George Bancroft, now the Democratic boss of Massachusetts, to convince his fellow Transcendentalistsstha a new, radicalized Democratic party was the political mechanism for social regeneration. Political radicalism now began to infect the Transcendentalist movement as a whole. Former anti-Democrats like George Ripley and James Freeman Clarke privately declared their "conversion... to Democracy" or "loco foco[ism]." The moderately Transcendentalist Western Messenger began publishing articles trumpeting the British working-class Chartists, "Loco-focoism," and "the development and realization of true democratic ideas." After hearing Emerson's opening lecture in his series "The Present Age" in December—in which he had welcomed "the fruitful crop of social reforms" that favored "pure truth" and "simple equity" over "mere commodity" and "the Colleges and all monied foundations of learning or religion" that favored "tradition"—Theodore Parker excitedly wrote the moderate Transcendentalist Club member Convers Francis: "It was democratic-locofoco thghout, & very much in the spirit of Brownson's article on 'Democracy and Reform' in the last 'Quarterly'.... Bancroft was in ecstasies." It is true that such "democratic" enthusiasm was somewhat misleading. Neither Ripley nor Clarke, for example, was especially pro-Democratic party, and Emerson, who privately stigmatized the party as "vain & loud" and "wholly commercial," harbored, in addition, deep skepticism about the prospects of achieving social regeneration through any social or political institution. So, even more, did Alcott (who coolly wrote in his diary, "The Kingdom of truth is within, not out there, in Church or State. Vox populi vox diaboli"). But, as Parker's letter shows, these were strategic matters that club members, for now, talked about, if at all, only fleetingly. Transcendentalists like Ripley continued to sound the call for a "philosophical democracy," and Emerson continued to urge his audiences to abandon all those unequal, luxurious, and "artificial modes of life" in business, labor, diet, and even housekeeping arrangements that make a person "a slave" and thereby "disgrace the soul." For the moment at least, Transcendentalism seemed to be indeed, as Emerson styled it, a "party of the Future."

How did Margaret Fuller fit into that party? One answer would have to be: philosophically at least, not very differently than she had three years earlier when she had first gotten to know Emerson and Alcott. Despite her readings in Plato, Coleridge, and, intermittently, post-Kantian philosophy, Fuller still had not found it necessary or congenial to work out anything like a systematic philosophy of the mind. On the other hand, her subjectivist aesthetics inspired by her German Romantics at least implied one. Meanwhile, her loyalty toward her own homegrown and now besieged Tiecks and Novalises remained as fierce as ever.

## Author's Notes

6. There is no comprehensive study of the social thought of the Transcendentalists, but for recent valuable analyses of some of its aspects, see Taylor Stoehr, Nay-Saying in Concord: Emerson, Alcott, and Thoreau (Hamden, Conn., 1979); Rose, Transcendentalism as a Social Movement; and David S. Reynolds, Beneath the American Renaissance: The Subversive Imagination in the Age of Emerson and Melville (New York, 1988), chap.

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**Shortened citation:**

Capper, *Margaret Fuller*, 310–311.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.101

# Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life: Vol. 2, The Public Years

Charles Capper

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life: Vol. 2, The Public Years |
| SELECTION | 3. Liberal Awakenings |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 108–109 · Oxford University Press, 2007. |

## Excerpt

Yet for the moment, as Ripley also noted, the popular "separate spheres" conservatives were gaining the upper hand. The early 1840s brought an outpouring of novels, tracts, gift books, articles, stories, and poetry summoning women to assume their "true womanhood" of piety, submission, self-sacrifice, and domesticity. Arguably, the shrewdest was the widely read 1841 Treatise of Domestic Economy by Sarah Grimké's antiabolitionist opponent, the influential educator Catharine Beecher, who called for "professional" housewives, virtuous mothers, and moral schoolmistresses whose cross-class self-sacrifice would help usher in a national millennium of peace, prosperity, justice, and Christian love. Meanwhile, the feminist abolitionists seemed to be deserting the gender field. While Sarah Grimké (in an ironic bow to the power of domesticity) retired from antislavery work to help her sister raise her children, the Garrisonians, preoccupied with a new factional struggle against pro-electoral action "political abolitionists," virtually dropped the women's rights issue altogether. Then there was the limitation of Grimké's message her conservative Quakerism imposed. Declaring she would depend "solely on the Bible to designate the sphere of woman," she appealed to a host of biblical "truths," including the fall of Adam and Eve, Christ's divinity, and the dangers of "heathenism," which hardly resonated with Unitarians, liberal Quakers, and Transcendentalists, who made up the majority of women's rights abolitionists, especially in Boston. Resting women's rights solely on an ethic of moral benevolence also weakened any claim on behalf of women's independent self-interest. Finally, Grimké and the "ultraist" Garrisonians' reduction of the gender question to moral equality and antislavery activism begged deeper gender questions, as Fuller had perceived in rebuffing Chapman. What was the nature of women's identity and psychology apart from their moral concerns? What was the right sort of education and culture for women? How could the abolitionists' claims of "benevolent womanhood" be reconciled with the notion of a gender-free moral sphere? What were the causes of female subordination? What was the best means of empowering women to act on their rights? What should the consequences of equal rights be for the institution of the family or work? The women's rights abolitionists were not indifferent to these questions; privately they wrestled with them. But publicly they were generally silent. With Enlightenment feminism dormant, abolitionist feminism fading, and an antifeminist backlash growing, the gender scene was ripe for a fresh intervention.

Of course, to contemporary feminists, Fuller's initial interventions would seem to have their own deficiencies, starting with her resistance to mixing social reform with self-culture. In that respect, Fuller was not so far from Catharine Beecher: both sought to advance the intellectual autonomy of women without either calling for their political activity or challenging their social subordination, the only difference being that Beecher advanced her domestic-millennialist call on evangelical grounds while Fuller did so on liberal Romantic ones. Yet Fuller felt some discursive pressures that both Beecher and Grimké did not.

One was the spreading contagion of socialism. Fuller and her Transcendentalist colleagues were increasingly making room on their bookshelves for, along with German theologians, philosophers, and poets, French radicals like Charles Fourier, George Sand, Pierre Leroux, and the Saint-Simonians, whose works bristled with demands for radically restructuring women's role in the family and society and heralded the coming of the "divine woman." Another was the ideological convergence of various radical perfectionist reform circles, a merger that two and a half years ago at the Chardon Street Bible Convention Fuller had thought was "so forced." Transcendentalists, Fourierists, and

Garrisonian abolitionists, already linked together in Boston by their liberal religious backgrounds but now unmoored from their more moderate Unitarian, Whig, and antislavery communities, were starting to find in each other's ideas startling new compatibilities. Transcendentalists were coming out as socialists, abolitionists as Transcendentalists, and soon both, in the wake of the impending annexation of Texas, as militant antislavery politicos. And brooding behind all these shifts was the most loosely Romantic convergence of all: radical reformers were beginning to sacralize reform itself. The church principal, Emerson declared, was "falling from the Church nominal." However surely Fuller had begun with the idea of keeping reforming women's culture hermetically sealed off from social questions, those questions were seeping in from all sides.

Meanwhile, something similar was occurring in her little corner of the Transcendentalist world. That spring, undoubtedly stimulated by their exchanges over love and friendship, Fuller and Emerson had started discussing the "state & duties of Woman" in the writings of Sand and Pierre Leroux. Although nothing is known about what they said, their simple posing of the question was provocative—although from Emerson's point of view, less than satisfactorily. "As always, it was historically considered," he grumbled in his journal, "it had a certain falseness so. For to me today, Woman is not a degraded person with duties forgotten, but a docile daughter of God with her face heavenward endeavouring to hear the divine word & to convey it to me." Although the antifeminism of this remark has often been exaggerated (docility toward God, the forgetting of duties toward man, and a special capacity to communicate divine revelations were hardly the stuff of conventional gender ideology), it is also true that his own gendered face could incline to the conventionally utilitarian as easily as the spiritually antinomian. And Fuller noticed it. A month later, he carelessly wrote her, speaking of the Wards' new baby, "though no son, yet a sacred event." "Why is not the advent of a daughter as 'sacred' a fact as that of a son?" she chided him. "I do believe O Waldo, most unteachable of men, that you are at heart a sinner on this point. I entreat you to seek light in prayer upon it." Considering that he wrote in his journal his "docile daughter of God" entry on the same day he penned his paean to "Margaret" rising before him into "heroical & godlike regions," she could hardly have gotten a better lesson on the gap between heroic talk and unheroic gender practice in even liberal American intellectuals.

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**Shortened citation:**

Capper, *Margaret Fuller*, 108–109.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.102

# The Inner Civil War: Northern Intellectuals and the Crisis of the Union

George M. Fredrickson

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Inner Civil War: Northern Intellectuals and the Crisis of the Union |
| SELECTION | The Doctrine Of Loyalty |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 147–148 · Harper & Row, 1965. |

## Excerpt

The divine right theory of loyalty was more than the key to a conservative theory of the state; it was also the basis of a generalized ""doctrine of institutions," such as the one proposed by Bellows before the war. This much was clear from Bushnell's claim that "loyalty" meant not only unqualified allegiance to the federal government but to all established institutions, especially the church and the family. The war gave impetus and direction to this kind of thinking and made it fashionable to condemn anti-institutional individualism in all its forms. The editors of Harper's, for example, now blasted away continually at the antiinstitutional "'doctrinaires.'" In January 1862, the inconsistency of the Garrisonian abolitionists, with their "charming doctrine of the power of just ideas to make their own way," was cited in the light of abolitionist support of the war with its inevitable "armies, navies, and fortresses." The military experience, it was claimed, brought ""discipline," and discipline suggested an acceptance of "government as a divine institution under all its forms, domestic, civil and religious."*

A year later, in January 1863, Harper's editorialized on "'Institutions and Men" and used the war as an occasion to defend institutions against "the individualism, the idealism, emotionalism, and revolutions that are sometimes arrayed against them." The time was deemed ripe for denying categorically the Emersonian notion that the isolated man has an importance apart from his participation in the organic life of the community, and much was made of the fact that "individuals are almost powerless unless they can come together under the auspices of institutions." The article concluded with the assertion that 'the whole history of individualism, whether of the emotional or mystical school, strengthens our faith in institutions, and makes us less and less inclined to think ideas, feeling or impulses, a sufficient guide to a community." The meaning of the Civil War was summed up in the description of the Northerners as "loyal champions of institutions.'

If the wartime "'loyalty" of 1863 and 1864 implied a vindication of "the doctrine of institutions,' where did this leave Walt Whitman and his belief that the patriotic feeling of the American people was an anti-institutional force and a fulfillment rather than a repudiation of the prewar faith in the ability of "ideas, feeling or impulses" to guide the community? As the war dragged on, Whitman grew increasingly uneasy. He became uncertain about 'the value of mere "patriotism" and deeply concerned about the "discipline" which seemed to be teaching subordination to hierarchical organizations to an American citizenry which had once believed so strongly in a full measure of freedom and equality. By 1863, in fact, Whitman was fully aware that the schooling of the nation in military discipline was one result of the conflict that would never fit into his view of the war as a saturnalia of democracy. He made this clear when he tried to interest a publisher in a book of sketches which would promulgate the idea that "our national military system needs shifting, revolutionizing & made ready to tally with democracy, the people— The officers should almost invariably rise from the ranks—there is an absolute want of democratic spirit in the present system & officers—it is the feudal spirit exclusively—nearly the entire capacity, keenness & courage of our army are in the ranks."*° It was no more appropriate for the democratic army to be led by an officer caste than for the democratic electorate to be managed by a class of professional politicians. For Whitman, a citizen army should be held together by a spirit of comradeship, not by subordination and discipline.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Fredrickson, *The Inner Civil War*, 147–148.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.103

# Understanding Emerson: "The American Scholar" and His Struggle for Self-Reliance

Kenneth S. Sacks

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Understanding Emerson: "The American Scholar" and His Struggle for Self-Reliance |
| SELECTION | Self-Reliance |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 67–68 · Princeton University Press, 2003. |

## Excerpt

Here Emerson extended the limits of self-reliance and linked freedom with commitment. But a year later, he cautioned himself about going further. Reflecting on the public debate around “The American Scholar” and the Divinity School address, he asked: “Why need you rail, or need a biting criticism on the Church & the College to demonstrate your holiness & your intellectual aims? Let others draw that inference which damns the institutions if they will. Be thyself too great for enmity & fault-finding.” Having attacked with unbridled passion the church and the college, Emerson then withdrew from the resulting controversy. Emerson believed that continuing his assault on what were, after all, bis church and bis college would make him even more dependent on both institutions. Protecting what he perceived to be his self-reliance, he failed to consider that his words had further emboldened his friends, whom by his subsequent silence he abandoned.[43]

Emerson compromised his intellectual freedom by being selectively candid. Avoiding conflict in the lyceum, the place where he made his living, was an uncomfortable concession to practicality. Bringing that conflict to Harvard and Concord, the institutions and people to which he was tethered, was an equally uncomfortable compromise of his self-reliance. There was a side of Emerson that always strove to be ethereal, bodiless: “I believe that I shall some time cease to be an Individual, that the eternal tendency of the soul is to become Universal.” Around the time of his Phi Beta Kappa oration, however, he chose not incorporeal contemplation, but action. To extol and demonstrate the self-reliance of the scholar, he himself had to be less self-reliant. A year later, Emerson felt unable to pay the price. He needed to be involved with, but ultimately detached from, others. As we saw in the last chapter, a large reason for his engagement at Harvard had to do with his immediate anger at his alma mater. But other forces were at work as well. In the next chapter, we’ll consider Emerson’s complex relationship to his Transcendental colleagues in the shaping of “The American Scholar.”

LOOKING BACK A CENTURY AND A HALF, EMERSON’S ENORmous influence on American letters and thought may seem obvious. As a result, Transcendentalism is almost inevitably interpreted through his eyes alone, with virtually every entry in reference works on Transcendentalism acknowledging his prominence. Because he commanded so great a presence, there were in his lifetime and certainly are in posterity several Emersons. The public Emerson of the essays is a powerful, searching figure striving for exceptional candor and self-reliance. As dominating as that persona may seem, in private Emerson could be insecure and heavily dependent on others. His friends played an important role in his decision to speak out. They served to shame him into action; by their own example, they helped define what he didn’t want to say; and they made him desire a kind of recognition they would never give him. Emerson’s relations with other Transcendentalists formed an essential aspect of his imperfect struggle for self-reliance and his decision to risk so much in “The American Scholar.”

Emerson s troubled dealings with friend and mentor Frederic Henry Hedge illustrate his complex relations with colleagues. Son of a Harvard professor, Henry had as a youth gone with George Bancroft to study in Germany as part of the first wave of Americans receiving European training. A few years after graduating from the Divinity School, Hedge took a pulpit in Bangor, Maine, a decision with which he was never fully satisfied.

## Author's Notes

43. Free should the scholar be: AS 140; why need you rail: JMN 7:200.

## Chicago Citations

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Sacks, *Understanding Emerson*, 67–68.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.104

# American Transcendentalism: A History

Philip F. Gura

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | American Transcendentalism: A History |
| SELECTION | American Transcendentalism |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 210–211 · Hill and Wang, 2007. |

## Excerpt

Emerson's courteous if somewhat tongue-in-cheek advice on how to initiate social change provided an answer of sorts. He began by noting how New England recently had witnessed manifold signs that the impulse to reform society had fallen away from "the church nominal" and had reappeared in various societies (like that at Amory Street) composed of "ultraists, of seekers, of all the soldiery of dissent."^ Without a touch of irony he listed the more unusual initiatives—dietary and agricultural reform of the sort instituted at Bronson Alcott's Eruitlands, for example, as well as assaults on the institution of marriage (with Fourier's speculations in mind). To these he added homoeopathy, hydropathy, mesmerism, and phrenology. Beyond the "petulance" and "puerility" of such efforts, Emerson saw greater problems.

In the reformers' haste to do away with the old, he observed, they often did not adequately prepare "to affirm and to construct," for they were satisfied to eradicate an evil without consideration of what should take its place. "Society gains nothing whilst a man, not himself renovated," attempts to renovate things around him, with the "disgusting result" of vanity or hypocrisy. Further, to be swept up too exclusively in one category of reform could make an individual morally obtuse. Emerson was adamant about the ill effects of such "partiality." To focus solely on one moral evil elided the fact that "the wave of evil washes all our institutions alike," so that one could not afford to waste one's time in such exclusive attacks. "The street is as false as the church, and when I get to my house," he continued, or to my manners, or to my speech, I have not got away from the lie."^

Just as problematic as this moral obliquity and partiality was the reformers' increasing reliance on "association" to combat social injustice, the approach Hedge, Ripley, and others advocated. Emerson applauded such intentions, admitting that Brook Farm and the Northampton Association of Education and Industry were comprised of "men and women of superior talents and sentiments." Over time, however, he feared that the communities might become asylums for those who had "tried and failed" in the world. Friendship and association were fine, as long as one realized "that no society can ever be so large as one man." In relying too much on others, a person becomes a fraction of himself There simply can be "no concert in two," Emerson declared, "where there is no concert in one."^

Here is the heart of Emerson's belief about reform; only after an individual experiences the paradise within can he join with others, similarly enlightened, to restore the outer paradise. Only then would institutions, comprised as they were of discrete individuals, change. Admittedly, men and women at work together appeared to accomphsh more when they met as equals. But reform remained only cosmetic unless this union was "inward." It did not consist merely in external covenant, for those who banded together in an imperfect state were, on all sides, "cramped and diminished" in proportion. "The union," he concluded, "must be ideal in actual individualism."'^

This belief in radical individualism, articulated so powerfrilly in Emerson's Essays (1841) and Essays, Second Series (1844), was at the heart of his Transcendentalism. In "New England Reformers," the final essay in his second volume, he reiterated his profoundly democratic sense that "the net amount of man and man does not vary."

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Gura, Philip F. *American Transcendentalism: A History*. New York: Hill and Wang, 2007.

**Footnote citation:**

Philip F. Gura, *American Transcendentalism: A History* (New York: Hill and Wang, 2007), 210–211.

**Shortened citation:**

Gura, *American Transcendentalism*, 210–211.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.105

# The Imperial Self: An Essay in American Literary and Cultural History

**Quentin Anderson**

| | |
|---|---|
| **WORK** | The Imperial Self: An Essay in American Literary and Cultural History |
| **SELECTION** | The Imperial Self |
| **SOURCE LOCATOR** | Original pages 30–31 · Alfred A. Knopf, 1971. |

## Excerpt

Time, providence, and society were real for Emerson's contemporaries; they eased the pains of a selfhood so isolated that it might be called antinomian by reference to the compelling needs of the time, and the definition of these needs was carried on in the Examiner and elsewhere as part of a discussion of current European works in literature, history, philosophy, and theology. For these men there was a continuing context in which such discussion was not only possible but imperative. The familiar distinction in Emersonian scholarship between Emerson and such "reforming" transcendentalists as Theodore Parker is quite insufficient to describe the importance of this split. Emerson held out against a powerful current of thought: he would not be involved in time, he was not a member of a generation. Almost as if social space had been appropriated as the scene of a designated range of experience, and time by an ultimately Christian view of an hurrying providence, Emerson turned to "nature." His contemporaries, those who were best prepared to sympathize with him, saw institutions as passing but necessary shadows of what welled out of the self; Emerson saw them as fatal to it. In him alone was the social voice stilled in his great years. I do not mean that he had no impulse to find an audience— far from it—but he did not conceive of that audience as needing guidance in framing new institutions, utopian or other.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Anderson, Quentin. *The Imperial Self: An Essay in American Literary and Cultural History*. New York: Knopf, 1971.

**Footnote citation:**

Quentin Anderson, *The Imperial Self: An Essay in American Literary and Cultural History* (New York: Knopf, 1971), 30–31.

**Shortened citation:**

Anderson, *The Imperial Self*, 30–31.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.106

# The Transcendentalists and Their World

Robert A. Gross

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Transcendentalists and Their World |
| SELECTION | 17. Walden and Beyond |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages reflowed ebook; no fixed page numbers · Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2021. |

## Excerpt

Not everyone was so enamored of Emerson or his influence over youth. In July 1840 the long-suffering Parson Frost delivered an unusually "animated" sermon against such "humbugs" as abolitionism and "Emersonianism." Then on April 19, 1843, the minister renewed the attack in a lecture, "The True Principles of Reform." Speaking near the end of the series that had featured so many calls for root-and-branch change, Frost charted a middle way between the poles of conservatism and radicalism. Both positions, in his opinion, fell victim to the same error of clinging rigidly to abstractions. The "ultra conservative" equated the "imperfect institutions" of the present with "immutable truth & justice & love" and would not alter them one whit; the "ultra reformer" held current arrangements up against the ideal model in his head and would accept nothing less than a perfect fit. Each perspective purported to be the only solution to the world's ills. Frost wrestled with the dilemma of choice. He was "afraid to oppose the ultra reformer, lest he should oppose all reforms," and "slow to oppose the ultra conservative lest he should encourage the revolutionary spirit of the radicals." What was this anxious moderate to do? Triangulating between extremes, the minister discovered "the true principle of reform" in "improvement": "It is not casting away the past, but proved by experience, matured wisdom, and adding our experience to it."

Despite his claim to be evenhanded, Frost skipped over the conservatives and trained his sights on reformers of all sorts, past and present, in church, society, and state. From the early Christians to the Protestant Reformation, and thence through the English, American, and French revolutions down to his own time, the advocates of change were prone to "separate [and] shut themselves up in their peculiar ideas, & deny all truth in others." The president of Concord's Total Abstinence Society was well aware of the intolerance and infighting in the "great Benevolent enterprises of the day." He was especially disturbed by the do-gooders who declined to engage with their neighbors and withdrew into enclaves of the like-minded. Come-outers deserted the churches, particularly Frost's own; nonresisters refused allegiance—and taxes—to government; the "community people" at Brook Farm turned their backs on a corrupt world to create their own Eden.

Then, Frost continued, there were the alienated young for whom Waldo Emerson advocated. In the January 1843 issue of The Dial, the Concord author had published his lecture "The Transcendentalist," which had debuted in his 1841–1842 series "The Times." The piece presented a sympathetic portrait of youthful idealists so put off by the shallowness and selfishness, the dishonesty and insincerity of everyday life that they could not bring themselves to join in the work of the world. Conventional callings were beneath them. Better to retreat into solitude, "ramble in the country," and wait for something worthy of their talents and ambitions. If these dissidents were neither "good citizens" nor "good members of society," if they declined to vote, if they did not "willingly" contribute to charities and aid benevolent causes, so be it. Emerson held out hope that one day "the good and wise" would realize their genius and "carry salvation to the combatants and demagogues in the dusty arena" of daily existence. This prophetic minority would, in the end, serve society "by speaking for thoughts and principles not marketable or perishable." They were the caretakers of the highest ideals.

Frost could hardly believe what he read. Here was "something new under the sun": a select society of superior souls deliberately withholding their contributions to "the cause of improvement" and doing so "out of a misguided principle." To his astonishment, such self-indulgence was being defended in print by a fellow minister whose name he did not deign to mention. Having long suffered the criticisms of Emerson and his supporters, Frost struck back,

and he did so donning the mantle of Ezra Ripley. Everyone, he insisted, belonged to the community, with an obligation to the collective good. Nobody lived alone. That was as true for the Transcendentalists as for everyone else. Far from waiting for the world to come around to them, these "men of purer fire" had a duty "to convey the Heavenly spark" they alone apprehended "to the cold & inert bodies around them." The field of labor was immense, the need nearly inexhaustible: "Can it be possible that any can want work in a world like this, where the drunkard lies weltering in the gutter, the poor stretching out their hand at the corner of every street? where Education, government, religion all call for reform & new life?" Surely the rarefied spirits Emerson admired would not be so selfish as to turn away from their neighbors in need.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.107

# The Rites of Assent: Transformations in the Symbolic Construction of America

Sacvan Bercovitch

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Rites of Assent: Transformations in the Symbolic Construction of America |
| SELECTION | / Rites of Assent |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 308–309 · Routledge, 1992. |

## Excerpt

Pierre Glendinning and Hester Prynne are classic fictional representations, negative and positive, of the "traditions of American individualism" that link Francis Fukuyama, fames Atlas, and Irving Howe. I have argued that those traditions build upon a complex symbolic-ideological system, involving a distinctive myth of history (predicated on the American Way "as the final form of human government"), a nationwide ritual of generational renewal and rededication, and a theory of pluralist interpretation that simultaneously empowers and constrains the self. In this chapter I focus on two journal passages by Ralph Waldo Emerson, the central philosopher of American individualism, whose major essays have become the locus classicus of American dissent. In part my purpose is broadly historical, to describe the confrontation between socialist and liberal ideologies in Jacksonian America. In part it is specific to Emerson, and what I take to be a decisive shift in his thought. Still another part, pertaining to the ambiguities that redeem Hester and undo Pierre, has to do with the dynamics of oppositionalism in liberal culture at large.

The first of the two journal entries, recorded in late November or early December 1842, seems to have come in response to the utopian socialist schemes which had just eventuated in the founding of Brook Farm. It marks Emerson's first use of the term with which he has been most closely identified and, more largely, the first formulation of radical individualism in the modern world: This brief passage may be read as an index to the development of the concept of individualism in Jacksonian America. To begin with, it reminds us that that development was not intrinsic to liberal discourse, but on the contrary grounded in the European socialist attack on free enterprise; that in fact "individualism" was coined in the 1820s by French radicals such as Pierre Leroux to signify "the vice of the age," by which they meant the source of the various evils that characterized the "modern bourgeois order": "ruthless exploitation," "civil anarchy," "spiritual rootlessness," "infinite fragmentation," "heartless competitive... attitudes," "social atomization," "confusion of interests," "mean egoism."

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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**Shortened citation:**

Bercovitch, *The Rites of Assent*, 308–309.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.108

# Slavery: A Problem in American Institutional and Intellectual Life

Stanley M. Elkins

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Slavery: A Problem in American Institutional and Intellectual Life |
| SELECTION | Chapter 3. Sin, Guilty Innocence, and Reform |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · University of Chicago Press, 1959. |

## Excerpt

"What is a man born for," he insisted, "but to be a Reformer, a Re-maker of what man has made; a renouncer of lies; a restorer of truth and good, imitating that great Nature which embosoms us all...?"

1830*5—with the appearance of Transcendentalism, of abolitionism, of the reform-conscious Jacksonian "workingmen's parties"— that America was entering an extraordinary period of reform. The drive, momentarily halted with the panic and depression of the late thirties, burst forth once more in the forties in a veritable fury of reform projects of every imaginable sort—temperance, millenarianism, perfectionism, spiritualistic Shakerism, utopianism, pacifism. It could probably be said that much of the aggression which such activities surely generated found its satisfaction in the splurge of Manifest Destiny and war with Mexico in the middle and late forties, for by the 1850^ a great number of the reform schemes so absorbing a few years earlier had lost their vitality. By then the field was vacated, so far as most people were concerned, to a single reform preoccupation—antislavery. That movement, present in some form since the early thirties and inflamed rather than alleviated by the exertions of the Mexican War, grew to formidable proportions in the i850's.

The point being examined here is the relationship of intellect to the questioh of slavery in the United States from the 1830^ on. It has been asserted, with regard to the functioning of intellect in culture at large, that a state of vital tension among the institutions of that culture makes a very great difference in the focus or lack of focus which its intellectual activity is to have.

"Man the Reformer," in Wor\s, I, 221, 223-24. Ibid., p. 236. tained (and, conversely, subverted); only thus are questions of power and social policy likely to take on for him a quality of concreteness. It has been further asserted, by way of example, that the most notable intellectual expression of the logo's and 1840^ in the United States—Transcendentalism—was quite unable in this respect to "transcend" its culture and its age at all: that, far from "revolting" against the age, Transcendentalism embodied in aggravated form certain of its most remarkable features—its anti-institutionalism, its individual perfectionism, its abstraction, and its guilt and reforming zeal. Moreover, the intellectual features of the reform movement most relevant to this inquiry— abolitionism—very strikingly duplicated those very features just enumerated, particularly guilt and its counterpart, moral aggression.

But before spelling this out, it will be necessary to make a final digression in order to give some special attention to the lastnamed of these qualities—social guilt and its various adjuncts. Reform movements in the United States appear to have been given a unique character by reason of the special part played in them by guilt; we should therefore examine some of the conditions which have typically made reform movements possible in this country.

It should in the first place be recognized that in the history of American reform no direct correlation can be found between the extent of any given social evil and the intensity of the reform activity directed against it. It is frequently to be observed that some of the most notorious of abuses have been allowed to go unchallenged while others comparatively superficial may be attacked with inordinate energy, or that continuing ills may have been ignored at one time and ferociously denounced at another. Something more than the mere existence of such ills is therefore needed to explain the action which they may evoke.

John W, Ward, in "Two Versions of Individualism" (a paper read at the 1957 meeting of the American Historical Association), pointed out the very close resemblance between the popular thought of the Jacksonian era and the leading ideas of the Transcendentalists. "The body of assumptions made explicit in Emerson's thought," he said, "are implicit in contemporary political theory, religious thought, and the celebration of the Old Hero, Andrew Jackson himself." Thorcau's Walden, Professor Ward added, "can stand for us as a kind of cultural metaphor, expressing an emotion that had a deep hold on the imagination of die time."

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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Elkins, *Slavery*, no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.109

# Brook Farm: The Dark Side of Utopia

**Sterling F. Delano**

| | |
|---|---|
| **WORK** | Brook Farm: The Dark Side of Utopia |
| **SELECTION** | Beginning of the End |
| **SOURCE LOCATOR** | Original pages 281–282 · Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2004. |

## Excerpt

Roxbury Association. Like Ryckman, he was more interested in organizing the burgeoning ranks of New England workingmen. One of the towns in which Allen and his fellow Brook Farmer John Orvis had stopped during their two-man lecture tour in the winter of 1845-1846 was Lowell, Massachusetts.

[19] Both Ripley and William Henry Channing had also appeared there in March 1846 as the Lowell Female Labor Reform Association, and Channing and Al-

Lowell Union of Associationists, making it in the process an affiliate of the American Union of Associationists. That work accomplished, Aldidn't have many opportunities to do so because he now was an agent for the AUA.

The once common threads that had held the Brook Farmers together in 1844 and 1845 may have not been the strongest, but nonetheless most conspicuous leaders found themselves marching to the beat of their own different drummers: Louis Ryckman to the National Reform Association; George Ripley and John Allen to the AUA; and Charles Dana to the Boston Chronotype. And while William Henry Charming at Brook Farm.

## Author's Notes

19. Guarneri, The Utopian Alternative: Fourierism in Nineteenth-Century America (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1991), 303.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

Delano, Sterling F. *Brook Farm: The Dark Side of Utopia*. Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2004.

**Footnote citation:**

Sterling F. Delano, *Brook Farm: The Dark Side of Utopia* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 2004), 281–282.

**Shortened citation:**

Delano, *Brook Farm*, 281–282.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.110

# The Quest for Nationality: An American Literary Campaign

Benjamin T. Spencer

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Quest for Nationality: An American Literary Campaign |
| SELECTION | Nationality Through Region and Locale ( 1815-1892 ) |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 269–270 · Syracuse University Press, 1957. |

## Excerpt

If before the 1830's they placed a premium on the use of Southern themes, they did so not so much to enhance their section as to give authenticity to its literary work. Even when the Southern Review (1828) appeared, it was acclaimed not as a sectional instrument but as a medium of literary interchange with all sections "of our happy country"; and when a few years later the major literary organ of the section, the Southern Literary Messenger (1834), was inaugurated, its editor James E. Heath bespoke the literary aid of his "northern and eastern brethren" and assured them that the appearance of his journal did not presuppose "any unkind feelings" toward Southern literature on the part of "the aristarchy [sic] of the north and east." Indeed some editors, like W. C. Richards of the Orion, even in the 1840's were so alert to the misunderstandings implicit in the term "Southern literature" that they preferred to use the phrase "literature in the South," or frequently "a literature at the South." But whatever the terminology, Southern editors until mid-century were generally explicit in their policy of delivering the South from literary "vassalage" and, at the same time, keeping it an integral part of the national literary design.

As mid-century approached, this editorial profession of loyalty to the cause of both an American and a Southern literature was sustained by the two most prominent writers of the section, Poe and Simms. Poe wished a Southern literary independence from the North as he wished an American literary independence from England only in order to free the individual author to follow his own course toward "originality." "We are embarked in the cause of Southern Literature," he wrote on behalf of the Messenger in 1836, "and (with perfect amity to all sections) wish to claim especially as a friend and co-operator, every Southern Journal." Poe's own "amity" with most of the New England writers was, of course, short-lived; but the several breaches with Lowell, Longfellow, and the Transcendentalists were usually personal rather than sectional in origin; and when they did at times involve Southern literature as a whole, they rarely related to the political aspects of Southern literature. When he attacked Margaret Fuller's essay on American literature as "a silly and conceited piece of Transcendentalism," and when he accused Lowell and his "set" of affecting a belief that there was "no such thing as Southern Literature," he was not advancing a Southern point of view but rather protesting what he regarded to be the impingement of a zealous and arrogant sectionalism on the privileges of the American imagination.

Simms, like Poe, sought an American literature free from British domination and a Southern literature independent of New England critical doctrines. But with this independence, Simms thought, both a national and sectional literature were responsible for reflecting the "moral aims" and "political achievements" of the area from which they sprang. Hence Simms became the ardent exponent of both an organic American and an organic Southern literature, and he reconciled the two on the principle of a literary confederacy. Subsumed under the broad scope of universal values were the distinctive cultural modes of nations, he supposed, and subsumed in turn under the American national character were the peculiar emphases of the several sections. As distinctive national cultures were the channels toward the universal, so the aggregate of the sections constituted the national. When, in the decade before the Civil War, Simms judged Southern interests to be short-weighted in the national scale, he became the proponent of a Southern literature wherein the moral and political aims were not merely distinct from but also antithetic to those of other sections. Yet most of his long editorial and critical career was spent on behalf of an American rather than a Southern literature, and in his sustained effort for a national literature he attacked British criticism,

encouraged native writers, suggested native themes, campaigned for a copyright law, and through a varied fiction exemplified his own theory of an American romance. In this double allegiance to a sectional and national literature, many of his prominent compatriots joined. Simms's editorial associate, James W. Simmons, the editor of the Southern Review, Hugh Legaré, and the mid-century editor of the Messenger, John R. Thompson, for all their sectional loyalty, were for the most part concerned that the South not fail to contribute her share to a national utterance distinctively American.

Within the framework of this inclusive interest in American literature as a whole, the campaign for a Southern literature recapitulated on a smaller scale the stages of the campaign for a national literature begun after the Revolution.

## Chicago Citations

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**Shortened citation:**

Spencer, *The Quest for Nationality*, 269–270.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.111

# Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life, vol. 1, The Private Years

Charles Capper

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life, vol. 1, The Private Years |
| SELECTION | Preface |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages no stable fixed page labels in supplied edition · Oxford University Press, 1992. |

## Excerpt

I have written this biography of Fuller, then, on one level as an act of historical recovery. To accomplish this I have gone back to the sources. These include not only her letters and journals, which have never been used before in any extensive or accurate way, but also the voluminous papers of her family, friends, and colleagues. My purpose has been three-fold. First, I have simply wanted to get the facts straight. This is no small matter. Most biographers of Fuller have freely reproduced "facts" based on legends, claims of previous biographers, and, in several cases, sentimentally imagined scenes. By contrast, all my factual assertions, unless otherwise indicated in a note, are derived from critically examined, firsthand sources. Second, I have tried to do justice to Fuller's complex personality. "What a Sphynx is that girl!" burst out one day in his journal James Freeman Clarke, who had known Fuller intimately and often encountered her daily for a decade, "who shall solve her?" I do not pretend to have solved her, but I have tried to understand her, especially the practical and hyperemotional sides to her character, which in virtually all Fuller biographies are selectively privileged. Third, I have used my sources to create a social biography. My text is filled, as Fuller's life was, with people, many famous, many obscure, but almost all interesting and all revealing of Fuller as she was—shifting, responsive, and ultimately comprehensible only in relation to the people with whom she interacted. The "real Margaret Fuller" is a phantom. What makes her live—and what my biography tries to provide—is Fuller thinking and acting with others. Yet, I should add, acting not just with other individuals. For Fuller's interactions were also with movements—from American Unitarianism to German Romanticism, from women's education to Italian republicanism. "Such a predetermination to eat this big universe as her oyster or her egg, and to be absolute empress of all height and glory in it that her heart could conceive, I have not before seen in any human soul," wrote Thomas Carlyle, who was not exactly an abstemious soul himself. When properly read, her life presents an illuminating window on these oysters and eggs of her time.

At its deepest level, though, my biography is about Fuller's life as an intellectual. This approach has been shaped by my interest in the American intellectual as a cultural type, of course. But it also seems to me to be dictated by her life itself. Fuller spent most of her waking hours reading, thinking, and writing. Without knowing what she believed, what she argued for, what she conceptualized, what she made into symbols, we cannot possibly know Margaret Fuller. More important, ideas and fantasies of intellectual identity, both of herself and of her culture, were the ruling preoccupations of her life. This truth was no better revealed than in the great moral drama of her life, which the titles of my two volumes are meant to highlight. That was her sudden movement at the beginning of her thirties from a "private" life of family, study, Boston-Cambridge socializing, and anonymous magazine-writing, to the life of a "public" personage, speaking in a commanding, if often complex and ambiguous voice, defining for America the intellectual character of womanhood and, a little later, from the vantage point of New York and Europe, pronouncing on its literary works and on the international political movements of her age. In the space of a few short years, she became America's female intellectual prophet in the mode of her difficult mentors Carlyle and Emerson.

## Chicago Citations

**Bibliography entry:**

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.112

# Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life: Vol. 2, The Public Years

Charles Capper

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Margaret Fuller: An American Romantic Life: Vol. 2, The Public Years |
| SELECTION | 7. Young America's Critic |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 251–252 · Oxford University Press, 2007. |

## Excerpt

Alluding to her theory that the bad drove out the "excellent" by dulling the public's capacity for discerning the difference, Fuller wrote in her review, "Such works as Mr. Longfellow's we consider injurious only if allowed to usurp the place of better things." But what were those "better things"? If the country's older Romantics were fast fading, its sentimentalists mostly wan, and its leading literati not leading, who or what did she look to beneath America's "official" literary culture for the seeds of its later flowering she so confidently predicted? The broadest answer would have to be a Romantically informed literary "democracy." It is true that, given the right provocation, she remained as ready as ever to blast the country's popular culture. (In a review of a grammar book, she blamed the English language's "degradation" on, successively, "uncultivated" immigrants, slang-spewing businessmen, and unrefined housewives.) If one thinks, however, of a literary democrat not as a cheerleader of the given culture but as a critical encourager of avant-garde literary tastes and practices that she hoped would vitalize a potentially popular literature, then the label fit. Certainly, she knew in a modern capitalist democracy there was no alternative: without princes and nobles to patronize literature and the arts, she said in "American Literature," "here is only the public." She rested her cultural hopes on two current social "symptoms." One was society's current spirit of reform, although, she quickly added, before it could produce poets, it needed to "penetrate beneath the springs of action." The other was the widespread felt need to be "even sternly sincere," not in the later attenuated Victorian sense of honesty or frankness but in the Romantic meaning of integrity or authenticity. "No man can be absolutely true to himself, eschewing cant, compromise, servile imitation, and complaisance," she wrote in one review, "without becoming original, for there is in every creature a fountain of life which, if not choked back by stones and other dead rubbish, will create a fresh atmosphere, and bring to life fresh beauty. And it is the same with the nation as with the individual man." In short, she assumed what she and Emerson had at the Dial: if individuals would become, unlike Longfellow, authentic observers of life within and without, they would collectively create a "fresh atmosphere" conducive to the birth of an original American literature.

In her "American Literature" essay and several reviews, Fuller also demonstrated what Emerson did not: the democratic possibilities for that prescription in the era's popular print culture. She approached it gingerly. She decried the "system of cheap publication" driven by new print technologies and the piracy of English books, which so reduced royalties that only a handful could afford to practice professional authorship and even those to write only what would immediately sell. She totally ignored lurid reform pamphlets, religious tracts, crime novels, and other texts that literary historians have claimed "subverted" the middleclass literature of sentimentality but that she no doubt would have considered formulaic and (in a favorite word) "vulgar." In one impish article on Congress's recent halving of the postal rate on letters, she tossed out enough skeptical barbs at railroads, itinerant lecturers, and garrulous letter writers to have satisfied the progress-skeptic Thoreau. Yet, unlike mid-twentieth-century critics of mass culture, she was hopeful about mitigating the tendency of the print revolution toward superficiality and conformity. Like her Young America allies, she thought an international copyright law would raise authors' incomes and so make them more willing to take unconventional risks in their writing. In her survey she also found promise in her new profession as a venue for the "life of intellect." The new electric telegraph gave reporters more time to arrange and interpret the news, while the need for brevity, rather than just encouraging the rushed and fragmentary,

made the newspaper a perfect repository for condensed essays, short stories, and even lyric poetry. Most important, since one could not fully explain or revise, it encouraged sincerity and spontaneity in a new national "conversation." "Newspaper writing is next door to conversation," she explained, "and should be conducted on the same principles. It has this advantage: we address, not our neighbour, who forces us to remember his limitations and prejudices, but the ideal presence of human nature as we feel it ought to be and trust it will be. We address America rather than Americans." Even Emerson would likely have been impressed with that democratic Transcendentalist magic.

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**Shortened citation:**

Capper, *Margaret Fuller*, 251–252.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.113

# Waking Giant: America in the Age of Jackson

David S. Reynolds

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Waking Giant: America in the Age of Jackson |
| SELECTION | Wakinc GIANT |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 262–263 · Harper, 2008. |

## Excerpt

"In literature it is only the wild that attracts us," he wrote. "Dullness is only another word for tameness." British literature, he stressed, had no "wild strain. It is an essentially tame and civilized literature.... There was a need for America." He declared, "America is the she-wolf of to-day." Elsewhere he wrote, "We must look to the west for a new literature," predicting that popular expressions "which now look so raw slang-like and colloquial when printed another generation will cherish and affect as genuine and American and standard." Thoreau developed his mature writing style in response to an American popular culture that feasted on sensations and hungered for curiosities. Thoreau, the hermit who lived on the simplest foods, was perceived by some as one more American oddity. One magazine compared him with P. T. Barnum in a piece called "Town and Rural Humbugs." Another writer said of Thoreau's style, "Sometimes strikingly original, sometimes merely eccentric and odd, it is always racy and original." James Russell Lowell charged that Thoreau "seeks, at all risks, for perversity of thought.... It is not so much the True that he loves as the Out- of-the-Way. As the Brazen Age shows itself in other men by exaggeration of phrase, so in him by exaggeration of statement." Reviewers caviled, but it was precisely the sensational or bizarre elements that attracted the popular audience. His idea for Walden came from a lyceum appearance where his audiences were curious about the details of his solitary life in the woods. When he began to lecture about his Walden experience, it was the strange, diverting moments of his talks that were the most popular. His biting "Economy" lecture, commented one magazine, was "sufficiently queer to keep the audience in almost constant mirth.... The performance has created 'quite a sensation' among Lyceum goers." By contrast, a tamer lecture, which became audience." When selecting passages from his writings to reprint, periodicals of the day most often chose the freakish or wild passages, such as "I grow savager and savager every day, as if fed on raw meat" or "There is in my nature, methinks, a singular yearning toward all wildness." As Thoreau revised Walden for publication in the seven years after 1847, he heightened the sensational qualities of his prose. He added shocking images that might fit into the penny press: tortured people taunting loon; the eerie owl hoots; and the passage about wanting to eat a woodchuck raw. He also invited us to laugh at the freakish or theatrical, as when he writes, "We know but few men, a great many coats and breeches," or "The head monkey at Paris puts on a traveller's cap, and all the monkeys in America do the same," or, about the transatlantic telegraph, "perchance the first news that will leak through into the broad, flapping American ear will be that the Princess Adelaide has the whooping cough." When Walden appeared, several reviewers noted its popular techniques. One stated flatly, "He coveted readers, and believed that he should have them." Another explained that he wrote Walden to satisfy "an inquiring public" and that "in the whole course of the book he keeps this audience in mind, goes out to meet it, and by a most conspicuously popular style adapts himself to it." And to some degree Thoreau satisfied this popular audience. Although Walden was not a best seller, it originally sold over two thousand copies—then a strong sale for a nonfiction volume—and proved popular over time, staying alive for future generations through its prose that absorbed popular images. If the Transcendentalists carried the Democratic ideology toward radical individualism, Hawthorne followed it into metaphysical ambiguity. Born in 1804 in Salem, Massachusetts, Hawthorne was bookish child and went on to attend Bowdoin College from 1823 to 1827. He then entered what he famously called the "dismal chamber" period of literary productivity—a statement that has wrongly led some to say that he was an isolated genius, distanced from his times.

## Chicago Citations

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Reynolds, *Waking Giant*, 262–263.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.114

# Understanding Emerson: "The American Scholar" and His Struggle for Self-Reliance

Kenneth S. Sacks

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | Understanding Emerson: "The American Scholar" and His Struggle for Self-Reliance |
| SELECTION | Chapter Two |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 21–22 · Princeton University Press, 2003. |

## Excerpt

WHEN THE YOUNG EMERSON STOOD BEFORE AN ASSEMBLAGE of some of the most important intellectual and civic leaders of his day, he was driven by both a desire to achieve self-reliance and, conversely, a deeply felt need to defend himself and friends that would compromise that self-reliance. In responding to this inner conflict, what Emerson did precisely was to offer an entirely new interpretation of what it meant to be an American scholar. It was a problem as old as the United States itself. Coming to a new land, Puritans had hoped to establish a City on the Hill to provide light unto all the nations. With the country's independence, the search only intensified for a literature to match the brilliant political achievement. Phi Beta Kappa, first established at the College of William and Mary in that year of independence, 1776, was originally a forum for contemporary political debate. When the press of politics receded, annual orators spoke instead of the need for the independent American scholar. As a teenager, Emerson had hoped his brother would address the theme in a college essay. Then he assumed the conventional understanding of American scholar as a writer substantially free from European influence. The question became so much the standard fare of the literate class that even in his oration Emerson acknowledged the subject as the expected theme: "I accept the topic which not only usage, but the nature of our association, seem to prescribe to this day,—the American Scholar. Year by year, we come up hither to read one more chapter of his biography."[1]

James Russell Lowell believed that Emerson fully succeeded: "The Puritan revolt had made us ecclesiastically, and the Revolution politically independent, but we were still socially and intellectually moored to English thought, till Emerson cut the cable and gave us a chance at the dangers and glories of blue water." But how exactly did he cut that cable? Little in the talk pertains to anything specifically American. Nearing his conclusion, Emerson acknowledged, "I have dwelt perhaps tediously upon this abstraction of the Scholar. I ought not to delay longer to add what I have to say, of nearer reference to the time and to this country." He then recommended to his audience the study of popular culture, citing as models European writers—Goldsmith, Burns, Cowper, Goethe, Wordsworth, and Carlyle—and following with an odd allusion to the beliefs of Swedish mystic Emanuel Swedenborg. What to Emerson was especially American about the scholar, if so controversial to his audience, had to be far more complex than meets the eye. To a country with a fragile hold on its new identity, it was uncompromisingly iconoclastic. To those in the audience, it was a particularly shattering vision.[2]

A decade before Emerson entered Harvard, the religious environment of the college, growing increasingly liberal and rational during the previous seventy-five years, took an even more dramatic turn. After a struggle within the Harvard Corporation, the Hollis Professorship of Divinity was offered in 1805 to Henry Ware, Sr., an anti-Trinitarian and follower of what would soon become known as American Unitarianism. A few years later, Harvard elected a president of the same faith, and by 1831 the Christian Examiner could proclaim of Harvard Divinity School: "Now we do not deny, that the Professors of the School are Unitarian; and we rejoice in the fact. We do not deny, that the probability is, that the students will come from the School impressed with the truth of the Unitarian faith. God forbid that it should be otherwise." Because training ministers was still perhaps the most important duty of the university, the rest of the institution followed pretty much in lockstep.[3]

## Author's Notes

1. Puritans: David Minter, “The Puritan Jeremiad as a Literary Form,” in The American Puritan Imagination: Essays in Revaluation, ed. Sacvan Bercovitch (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1974), 45. William and Mary: Current, Phi Beta Kappa in American Life, 5-7. Conventional meaning: Bliss Perry, “Emerson’s Most Famous Speech,” in his The Praise of Folly and Other Papers (Boston, Houghton Mifflin, 1923), 81—113, points out that it had “become a standard undergraduate theme.” 1837: AS 132-133. Although clearly having in mind the American scholar (as noted by a contemporary reviewer, William Henry Channing, Boston Quarterly Review [1838]: 110), he entitled the initial version “An Oration, Delivered before the Phi Beta Kappa Society at Cambridge, August 31, 1837.” He renamed it in 1849; see Joel Myerson, “Practical Editions: Ralph Waldo Emerson’s ‘The American Scholar’,” Proof 3 (1973): 380.

2. Lowell, North American Review 1865: 600. AS 142, 144. Theophilus Parsons and Sampson Reed may have been the only Swedenborgians in the audience. John Pierce, Memoirs, vol. 7, 162, MHS, believed there was one Swedenborgian minister among Harvard alumni.

3. Harvard history: William R. Hutchinson, The Transcendentalist Ministers: Church Reform in the New England Renaissance (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1959), 6-12. We do not deny: “Review of Dr. Codman’s Speech in the Board of Overseers of Harvard College, February 3, 1831,” CE 10 (1831), 144.

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CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.115

# The Raven and the Whale: The War of Words and Wits in the Era of Poe and Melville

Perry Miller

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | The Raven and the Whale: The War of Words and Wits in the Era of Poe and Melville |
| SELECTION | The Literary Prospects of 1845 |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 131–132 · Harcourt, Brace, 1956. |

## Excerpt

131 The Literary Prospects of 1845 when the Democratic praised Poe's lecture, and, while mildly deploring the vehemence of the charge against Longfellow, admired Poe's courage: "It is something for a man to encounter so formidable an opposition in this day of newspapers and public opinion, when the opportunities for the gratification of a whim or prejudice, to say nothing of malice and disappointed hate, are so ready at hand." Poe may be a harsh critic, often unfair, Duyckinck said, but he will not puff. Thereupon Duyckinck used Poe to proclaim the faith that was in him, on which he fell back as the literary prospects of 1845, like the political, went sour. There is nothing more humiliating or dastardly than to treat literature as a poor, mean, good-natured thing. "It is for the interest of literature that every man who writes should show his honesty and not bring letters into contempt." If in doing so he becomes rude, "it is better both for the cause of truth and virtue that this should be the case than that a man should be always dull and complaisant." Evert Duyckinck is as tortuous as the others, but the reason he stood so stanchly by Poe, even though loyalty hurt him, is that Poe did, along with his meanness and irresponsibility, incarnate for Duyckinck the dignity of the artist.

Duyckinck also believed that Simms was sincere, in which he was not mistaken, though it led him to exaggerate the performance. All these months Duyckinck steadily boosted Simms through his now numerous columns, while he and Jones contributed to the Southern and Western. As Simms collected pieces for his volume in the American Library, he returned the compliment: Duyckinck is unique in that of all American critics, "you have a hearty love for the art, unimpressed & uninfluenced by petty prejudices of your own, and a still more petty subserviency to cliquism." The group never seem to have thought that, if they could address each other in this style, from Clark's point of view they made a faction more clique-ish than his. But Clark was not privileged to see the caution Simms felt obliged to add: Duyckinck's habit of reading more than writing would injure him: "The luxury of literature is with you. The care with me." The problem always was whether Duyckinck would, in the moment when action was needed, prove too luxurious for action.

Duyckinck hoped he was displaying the qualities of leadership by a piece in the Democratic Review for May, "On Writing for the Magazines," which endorsed Poe's thesis that the magazine rather than the book is the form best suited to this age, and boldly encouraged magazine writers not to be afraid of "egotism"—that is, writing in the first person. "What is genius but this secret spring of egotism?" The piece ends with another plea for fraternity among writers. Simms, in all affection, thought it too cursory; actually, the Knickerbocker for that month almost stole all the thunder of Young America with "Necessity for a National Literature," which was Clark's idea of how the patriotic appeal should be managed. This also declaims against corruption by European imports, but on the moral ground that they bring in "foreign licentiousness and immorality." If we Americans do not have a traditional lore, we still have a great people, a short but •crowded history; our writers should record our "struggles against evil." The unspoken point was clear: one of the evils America must overcome is Edgar Poe.

Clark had proof of that in June. Dr. Thomas Chivers, in New York to publish The Lost Pleiad, his bid for sharing with Simms the title of chief Southern writer, found Poe drunk in Nassau Street, and was taking him home to 195 East Broadway when they met Clark, whom Poe tried to assault. That was not helping Duyckinck, but a worse blow was an

article in the American Review in that very month; it was by E. W. Johnson, entitled “American Letters—Their Character and Advancement,” and though Colton prefaced it with a notice that he did not entirely agree, he did print a piece which is decidedly a conservative’s attack on Young America. Our literature is a poor thing, but do these nativists, asked Johnson, have any idea of the new literature they call for? “Do they mean a new body and mode of thought? or a new vehicle, a new dialect, for the old ideas? Is the change to arise out of a greater refinement and cultivation? or is it, on the contrary, to spring from a return to simplicity—a banishment of artificial forms of fife?” These were shattering questions. Young America were compelled to face an issue they had no way of facing: what specifically would constitute that literature, greater than Shakespeare’s, they supposed they were creating? “What is to create it, or wherein it is to consist, they have by no means given themselves the trouble to inquire. All they really mean is that American writers will live in America; if they want something really native, let them consider the Ethiopian Minstrels: let them hold up as the national symbol not Behemoth but Jim Crow!

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**Shortened citation:**

Miller, *The Raven and the Whale*, 131–132.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.116

# American Transcendentalism: A History

Philip F. Gura

| | |
|---|---|
| WORK | American Transcendentalism: A History |
| SELECTION | American Transcendentalism |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 74–75 · Hill and Wang, 2007. |

## Excerpt

In 1837 Ripley wrote George Bancroft, a prominent member of the Democratic Party, that with such men as Brownson he "hoped to see the time, when religion, philosophy & politics will be united in a Holy Trinity, for the redemption & blessedness of our social institutions."^^ Through Ripley's efforts, Brownson soon was presented with just such an opportunity—to replace Joseph Tuckerman as minister at large to Boston's poor. Chafing under a low salary and the needs of an ever-growing family, and lobbied heavily by Unitarian friends in the city, Brownson accepted. In the summer of 1836, the year of Harvard's bicentennial and the Transcendental Club's first meeting, he moved his family to Chelsea, near the center of the Unitarian universe. "I am trying to democratize religion and philosophy," he wrote Bancroft.Now he walked shoulder to shoulder with other liberal Christians who derived from Romantic philosophy and religion the impetus to reinvigorate their faith and work toward a realization of more democratic ideals.

In these years Brownson was not easy to miss. He was imposing, over six feet tall and broad-shouldered, his black hair brushed straight back without a part. He had hazel-brown eyes, a long upper lip, and hands in proportion to his large frame. Particularly distinctive was a swallov^ail coat, worn "at all hours of the day, even in his study." A powerful speaker, to some he was abrasive; to others, uncouth; and to some, who feared his social radicalism, downright intimidating. His regimen was Spartan: he frequently worked until three in the morning, ate little (but drank strong coffee all day long), and at a time when temperance was in the air, already had sworn total abstinence. His only noted vice, besides being cantankerous, was chewing tobacco.

His intellect was just as striking. Although he had never attended college, making him unusual among his fellow Unitarian ministers, he read Latin, French, and German and had a seemingly boundless appetite for works on religion and philosophy. He also wrote prodigiously. When he did not have enough copy for an issue of his Boston Quarterly Review, he dashed off articles and reviews (even of his own works), frequently filling an entire issue and thus lending an ironic justness to the journal's subsequent name.

Brownson's Quarterly Review}"^ His collected works, far from complete, comprise twenty volurnes. His friend Isaac Hecker put it baldly: Brownson, he recalled, "was routine in nothing.

He had one other distinguishing characteristic. As the conservative Trinitarian clergyman Noah Porter wrote, Brownson was "manifestly and avowedly in a state of continual transition,—in a certain condition of perpetually becomingly but of never bein£f7^^^ But although he may have been, by his own account, "mercurial" in intellectual matters, he never wavered in his vocation. His was one long attempt to realize a social harmony he had never been fortunate enough to know, and particularly to provide the laboring classes with the education and ministry they needed to better their lot. This devotion to bringing the kingdom of God to earth is what convinced Ripley and his friends that the Canton minister, born and raised on society's margins and yet versed in the same Continental philosophy that captivated them, should succeed Tuckerman as minister at large to Boston's poor.^^

In Ripley, Brownson found a soul mate. Later in life, long after he had broken with the Transcendentalists, he testified to his friend's influence. "In the formation of my mind," Brownson wrote, "in systematizing my ideas, and in general development and culture, I owe more to him than to any other man among Protestants." Brownson concluded, "I loved him as I loved no other man."^^ In 1836 these two were the de facto field generals of the

emergent Transcendentalist movement, popularizing Idealist thought through their seminal publications and applying it to pressing social needs.

Christian Examinery for example, in Bangor, he was too distant to exercise any concerted influence on his peers. Convers Francis, despite his presence at the Transcendentalist Club's early meetings, was only a fellow traveler in Transcendentalist circles.His good friend, Theodore Parker, eventually a lion among the group, was still at divinity school. Waldo Emerson, another promising foot soldier, had few publications to his credit and none with the intellectual heft of Ripley's or Brownson's essays in The Christian Examiner.

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Gura, *American Transcendentalism*, 74–75.

CHAPTER 12 · SECONDARY SOURCE S12.117

# The Rites of Assent: Transformations in the Symbolic Construction of America

Sacvan Bercovitch

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|---|---|
| WORK | The Rites of Assent: Transformations in the Symbolic Construction of America |
| SELECTION | / Rites of Assent |
| SOURCE LOCATOR | Original pages 38–39 · Routledge, 1992. |

## Excerpt

In other words, the Whig leaders brought the violence of revolution under control by making revolution a controlling metaphor for national identity. In a sense this was simply the product of anticolonial struggle. The rhetoric that prepared the colonists for revolution provided their leaders with a vehicle of social control: the pattern has become so familiar as to seem a condition of modern nationalism. What distinguishes the American revolution within this pattern is the rhetorical mode it brought to fruition. When the patriot Whigs expanded the concept of the errand into an apologia for independence, they gave full and final sanction to the ideology of consensus. Once and for all, the errand took on a special, self-enclosed American form. Independence from England completed the separation of the New World from the Old. Henceforth, Americans could direct the process of migration toward its proper goal, the conquest of a continent. Independence became the norm for representative selfhood: independence of mind, independence of means, and these twin blessings, sacred and secular, the mirror of a rising nation—what could better demonstrate the bond of personal and social identity? Elsewhere, to be independent was to challenge society. In the United States, it was to be a model of consensus. Above all, independence gave a distinctive national shape to the idea of progress. The sacred origin was the Puritan migration; the telos was the Revolution. Drawing out the logic of the errand to a point undreamed of by their forebears, the patriot Whigs announced that the long-awaited apocalyptic moment had arrived on July 4, 1776.

It took another generation or so before all the details could be worked out—before Washington could be enshrined as savior, his apostles ranked, the Judas in their midst identified, and the Declaration of Independence adequately compared to the Sermon on the Mount. But the ritual plot, the narrative frame of the ideology of errand, had at last found its focus. With the revolution, the Puritan vision flowered into the myth of America. For the errand itself was rooted in biblical myth. However eccentric their interpretations, the Puritans had relied on the authority of scripture. No matter how flagrantly they distorted sacred history to justify their experience, they were appealing, finally, to Christian tradition. The Revolutionary Whigs took the justification, rather than the tradition behind it, as their authority. No matter how piously they invoked scripture they were appealing not to Christian tradition, but to the series of recent events through which they defined the American experience. Their symbology centered on the act of migration; their text was the progress from theocracy to republic; their source of prophecy was the pilgrimage of the representative American.

The story they told was broadcast through the land every July Fourth, the high holy day of American civil religion. A new era, so the story went, had begun with the discovery of the New World, and the Revolution confirmed it, as Christ had confirmed the new era of faith. In both cases, the event was at once definitive and heuristic. Christ had invoked the authority of the prophets, but it was His mission that verified their prophecies. Such too was the relation between Old and New Israel. As the patriot spokesmen put it, the Revolution "is indissolubly linked with the Redeemer's mission." It is "the wonder and the blessing of the world," the moment "from which the new order of things is to be reckoned," the epoch-making "accomplishment of all... the great events, designed from eternal ages" to "promote the perfection and happiness of mankind." "Here, from the analogy of reason and providence, we can expect God's greatest works." With the Revolution, God has shown that "The UNITED STATES OF AMERICA are to be His vineyard"—"the principal Seat of [His] glorious kingdom"—wherein the promises of the past "are to be

brought to harvest," for "the benefit of the whole world."

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